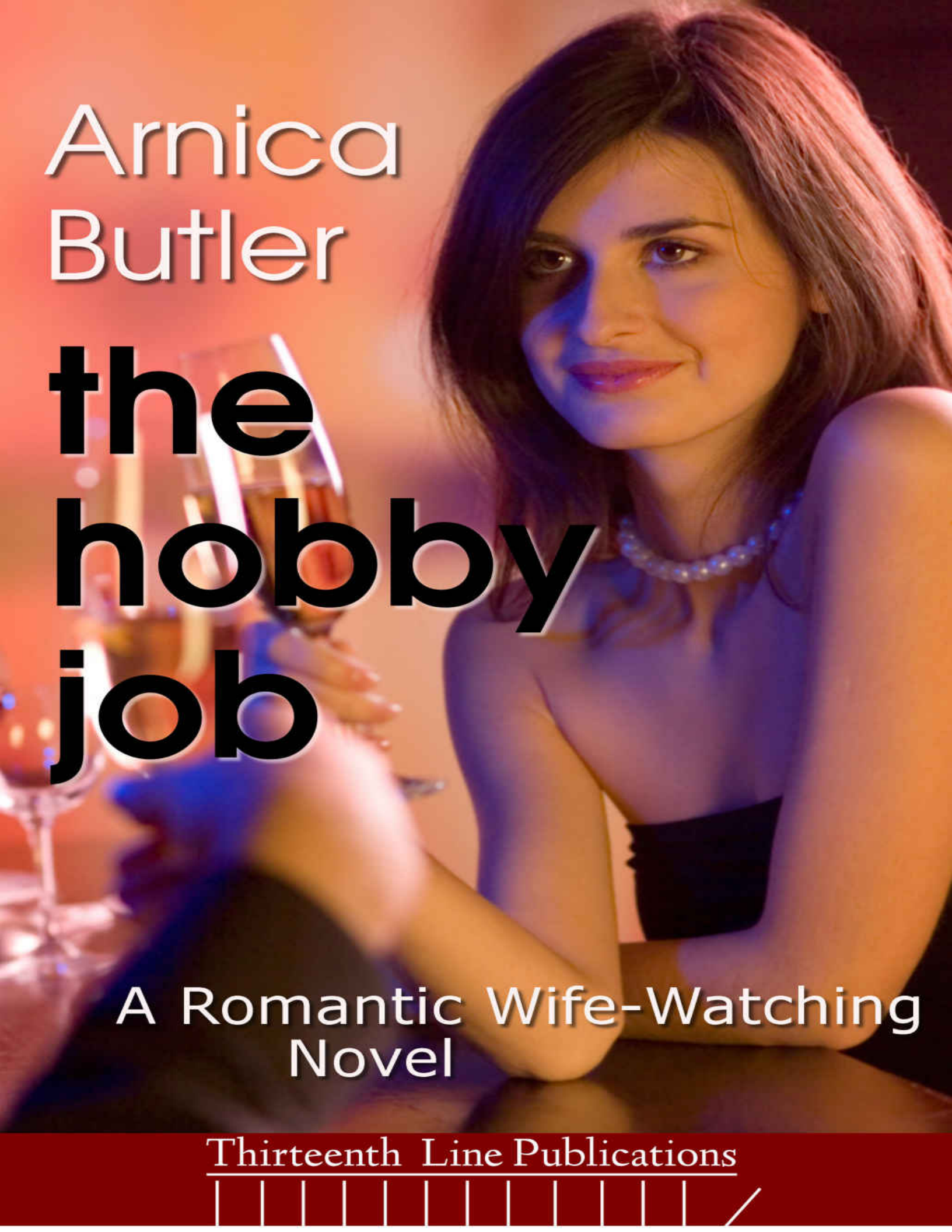




Arnica
Butler

**the
hobby
job**

A Romantic Wife-Watching
Novel

Thirteenth Line Publications



THE HOBBY JOB

A Romantic Wife-Watching Novel

By Arnica Butler

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TO THE READER

I get asked a lot why I don't write my hotwife stories from the perspective of the woman. I am, after all, *really* a female author. I have the same answer every time: I try it out, something about it doesn't work for me, and I end up going back to the husband's voice.

But I really wanted to challenge myself with this latest novel, so I set out writing from the perspective of Laura, a career-professional-turned-housewife who is feeling a little bit trapped in the boonies, living out her charming country dream life.

Should be a cinch, this particular character, I thought.

But, as usual, I felt really boxed in by something.

So then I had an idea to alternate voices.

I was advised, by more than one person whose opinion I value, *not* to write this book the way I did. When I discussed alternating from first-person male to first-person female, most people were like, “I don't like that.” Or, more sagely: “you won't be able to maintain the tension in a hotwife story, because so much of it comes from *not* knowing what the other person is thinking.”

As usual, I thanked everyone, knowing they were probably right, and then did it anyway.

I wanted to try it out and see if I could make it work, and protect the “not-knowing” through a variety of tricks and narrative omissions. Originally, it was just kind of a fun experiment. I thought it might not end well, but no harm in trying.

However, I am really thrilled with what I have done here. I think I've made it work, and I'm very happy with the writing and the story.

I know this story deviates a little bit from the typical Arnica Butler novel. It's a little bit more psychological than super down and dirty, and a little more realistic (because is it anchored, as you will see, in real life). I hope the change is refreshing, and the realism is exciting for you.

This is, like *The Gamble* and *The Hotwife Tattoo*, a slower burn. But as always, I've tried to make it worth it at the end. Also, what's not to love

about a great tease?

As always, I hope you enjoy the fantasy I've created for you as much as I enjoyed writing it.

PRELUDE

1997 - CONRAD

Eliza. Eliza, who is not my wife and was never my girlfriend, is the place where all of this got started, at least for me.

“Eliza,” I repeated. I looked at the long-limbed, dark-skinned girlfriend my buddy Troy had brought to the bar, trying to place her ethnicity, and maybe steal a glimpse of her huge breasts, swimming underneath a tantalizingly loose shirt.

In Troy's direction, I nodded in approval: she was hot. I forgave him silently for pulling a disappearing act for nearly a month.

I swiped the bar top with a semi-clean towel and tried to look suave, which was no easy feat in The Yard, the dump I worked in all the way through college. “What'll it be?”

Eliza stretched her long arms across the bar and ordered a gin and tonic in a voice that was two octaves lower than I'd expected. It was sultry, slightly nasal, and felt like listening to jazz in a speakeasy. Not that I'd ever done that, but it's the first thing that popped into my mind. The words left her full lips and her mouth quivered with a smile, inviting my eyes along for a walk all over her body. Her eyes lowered and invited me for a stroll down her swan-like neck, along the collar of her loose, small shirt, and lower still, if I wanted. She had a glint in her eyes that was egging me on to do it.

Her mocha skin faded to a milkier shade of caramel where her large breasts moved around beneath the fabric of her semi-transparent shirt. The shirt left little to the imagination, and it was clear she didn't care. She had big, dark aureole and long nipples, and they darted around beneath the stripes of metallic and the more revealing stripes of transparent black. “One for you, too.” She gave me a full smile, and her dark eyes went up and down, before she spun in her chair and sauntered off to play pool.

Troy watched her leave and turned back to me. “Yeah. Get me a beer, good buddy,” he said. “So whadya think?”

“Hot,” I said, but I was on guard. I set a glass on the table and started to pour her drink. She *was* fucking hot, but the whole interaction had seemed a little too flirtatious, given that Troy was right there.

“Don't forget yours,” Troy told me, reminding me of Eliza's drink offer.

I squeezed the lime and smiled. *She-wasn't-serious*, the smile said. Troy shrugged.

“This girl,” Troy said, leaning over the bar and taking his own glass from the behind counter to fill it with beer from the only tap he could reach, “is fucking incredible. I mean...fucking *incredible*. I think I'm in love.”

I raised my eyebrows. This was not Troy-like. Behind him, out of focus, the lithe figure of Eliza leaned over the pool table and her breasts swung dangerously forward and back, barely within the confines of her skimpy shirt. My eyes were sucked away to view them, only briefly, and then I looked down quickly at a glass of water to cover up my gawking.

Troy gave me a grin, and nodded. I hated this kind of shit, to be honest: gawking at girls like Eliza; shared, locker-room smiles and nods.

“She's sort of half-black,” he continued, leaning closer and lowering his voice, “so she has this tight, curly bush -”

I set my water down and held a hand up. I shook my head to indicate I did not want him to continue.

Troy never took “no” for an answer when it came to this sort of thing.

“And her pussy, man, gets *so wet*. ”

I was thankful that someone a few seats down held his hand up and hollered for a Molson. That doesn't mean I didn't have an image of Eliza's small, tight curls overlaying a purple, or maybe bright pink, cunt in my mind. The appeal of something so exotic, dripping wet, was winding my cock up whether I wanted the image in my head or not. I blinked slowly and fought the urge to look over at the pool tables, where, my peripheral vision was telling me Eliza was bent over the table. The round, full globes of her tight ass were displayed for the entire bar. I tried, and failed, not to superimpose over this scene the image of her pussy, planted in my mind by Troy.

Troy changed the subject when I went back to him. Every guy in the place was angling their stool a little to have a better view of the pool tables. There was a TV with a minor-league hockey game above the table where Eliza was stooping and shimmering in her faux-alligator pants, but I knew as well as anyone else the hockey wasn't the attraction, no matter how glued everyone's eyes were to the TV. Eliza's legs, long like a colt, almost seemed to dangle from her hips. She crossed and uncrossed them as she bent over to

size up her shot. Between shots she tossed her shimmering black hair over her shoulder and moved her fingers over the tip of the pool stick in nimble circles. You couldn't help imagining her doing the same thing to the tip of your own cock.

“What time you get off?” Troy asked, as though he were completely unaware of the sizzle Eliza had added to the room. “You want to hang out? Eliza has a friend at this club downtown.”

I found some glasses to wash and busied myself with the task. “I dunno, man,” I said.

“When you get off? Or about the club?”

I shrugged. “I don't wanna be a third wheel,” I said. It was nearly always the case. Troy made an okay wing-man, on the rare occasions he didn't find an attractive girl and head off with her first, or didn't have an unstable girlfriend getting us kicked out of a place. The rest of the time, I was an obvious third wheel.

“It ain't even like that,” Troy said. “Seriously.”

I had no idea what he meant by “that.” Sometimes Troy seemed to read my mind. He was always the one with the girls flocking around him, even though he was a typical ass. Always doing stupid shit, like climbing trees to rescue cats at three am., jumping off rooftops into pools, and other idiotic nonsense that girls claimed to hate but seemed to swoon over. And it seemed to pay off, at least in the way he wanted it to: he never went home alone.

In college I was a pretty fit guy – who wasn't? - and I didn't have a ton of trouble getting girls to flirt with me. I just wasn't into so gratuitously, as Troy put it, “closing the deal.” I liked having a girlfriend, for one thing, and most girls became annoyed by Troy after a few nights out with him. I was in a dry patch at the time, and I was starting to get annoyed by Troy as well. It didn't seem like sitting around in a club while he and the beautiful Eliza played kissy-face was going to get me any closer to having what I really wanted. A nice, friendly, fun, attractive girl I could eat pizza and play video games with.

“I am telling you,” he continued. “This will be fun. She has some friends. *Hot*. I think you'd like them.”

I poured him another beer. “But they're not for you?” My tone was sarcastic. Fifty percent of Troy's relationships had ended because he had fucked his girlfriend's best friend.

Troy shook his head. "I'm telling you. True love. Eliza and I have it all worked out."

I leaned backward so I could look down my nose at him. He called this my "bifocal move." I was aware it was pretty irritating, made me look like my dad, but it was innate. It was almost the only way to get under Troy's skin.

Troy just grinned at me, though, instead of getting annoyed. Then he walked off to play pool with the lovely Eliza.

This is not a story, though, about how hot Eliza was.

I mean, she was. Hot as balls, as Troy would have said. She was also incredibly fun. She tipped her head back to laugh, and it warbled from her throat, warm and delicious. She smiled and told great, dirty jokes. But she wasn't really my type. Too big, even though she was thin – big, like she took up the whole room with her personality and her deep voice, and her mouth seemed to swallow her whole face, and her tits managed to be everywhere all the time.

I gave in and we went to the downtown club.

There was another thing about Eliza, too. She was sort of a slutty flirt. To get us into the club, she had slinked up to the bouncer, and thrown her arm around him. I watched, feeling awkwardly for Troy, as she placed her big lips next to the bouncer's ear and whispered some kind of spellbinding thing to him. His drawn face broke apart into the kind of smile that only comes from thinking about a humorously filthy sexual act, and he unhooked the chain and waved us through.

But he stopped Eliza with a big arm, as we filed through, and I turned my head to see him holding her close to him. Eliza placed a long finger on his lips and they chuckled to each other wetly, like a new couple.

When I looked back at Troy, he had summoned a toothpick from his shirt and had it between his teeth. His mouth was smiling, strangely. His eyes appeared to be right on Eliza.

I had almost no time to think about that strange scene, though, because Eliza came at us like a cannonball, her black hair shining red beneath the lights and her mouth open like a burst black cherry. "Boys," she yelled over the music, which started building up at that particular moment. "Let's get our dance on!"

Her forearm was against my neck, and floating over the tones of canned smoke and body odor and sour beer I could smell her soap. Something unflowered, and not fruity. She smelled, almost paradoxically, like clean laundry.

Eliza's friends were, as promised, hot. Squealing, shaking, glittering, blonde-and-bright red hot. A platinum-haired girl with wide-set eyes and tight, pretty features squeaked at me over the music and laughed at everything I said for about five minutes. But after a few drinks her smile started to seem crazy, sort of the way Cameron Diaz's does, and so I declined an invitation to join her dancing.

I mean, I wasn't headed out there anyway. The cliché is true, and I could be convinced to dance by a pretty girl if the floor was full and there was no chance of me being fully seen doing whatever it was I did out there.

I knew what it looked like.

Eliza began with Troy, and then her black hair was swirling everywhere. In flashes of strobe I saw her leaning forward, her mouth open, her pressed up against a shadowy figure behind her.

Not Troy.

My eyes flickered around the scene. Eliza disappeared and another part of the dance floor was lit up. When I saw her again she had her forearms resting on the shoulders of another guy.

Not Troy.

Jesus, I remember thinking. I remember feeling bad for Troy, who really seemed deep into Eliza.

I looked down at my drink and then at one of Eliza's friends, who had collapsed in the booth about three feet from me and had over-dilated eyes. She gave me a hollow drug-smile, and I looked into my beer again.

My mind was giving some brief thoughts – very brief, mind you, because Troy and I didn't have *all* that close of a friendship – about whether or not I should say something to Troy about his girlfriend, when Troy peeled Eliza's stoned friend away from the booth to climb behind her and plop next to me.

I looked up at the dance floor. Eliza had squeezed her way back toward where we sitting, and she was dancing *very close* to a black man. My eyes darted over the scene. The guy had his hands on her hips and was moving them down...down to her ass.

I looked at Troy.

Since his body wasn't reacting to the scene, I expected to see him preoccupied with something else. Instead, he was just picking his teeth with his toothpick and watching.

I looked back and forth from Eliza to Troy, making sure the line of sight was, in fact, lined up.

I looked back at Troy's face. His eyes were lit up, like he was watching a boxing match come in big for him.

"Dude," I said. Or rather, yelled. "What the fuck is going on?"

Troy rubbed his chin, where an unsightly goatee was growing into some weird triangle, and he just smiled.

I looked back at Eliza. She had turned to snuggle up against the man she was dancing with. Her back was pressed against his chest, and her ass was nestled in his crotch. She raised her hands and exposed her whole stomach – a very nice view – and I watched in horror as the man's hands slid under her loose shirt...under, and up.

I snapped back to Troy. He was still just watching.

Back to Eliza. The man's hands were very clearly on her tits now. The image of her dark aureole peeking out of her shirt at my bar filled me head, and my palms itched with the desire to have my hands where this guy's hands were.

And then Eliza, who had been dancing with her eyes closed, lifted her eyelashes, and her big brown eyes locked.

On Troy.

Their shared look burned through the room. At the time, I was so shocked, so I didn't appreciate it. Who knows how to act in a situation like this? But later that night, when I had time to think about it, the look these two exchanged would be the most lasting image of the day.

"We have it sorted out," Troy said, for me, even though he didn't move his eyes or take them off of Eliza. "I'm gonna have to go soon, buddy."

He never looked back at me. Eliza's dance partner turned her around and leaned close to her ear, his mouth nibbling at her skin as he told her whatever he told her. Eliza's eyes left Troy's briefly, but they were back on him again soon enough. She gave him a wink.

It was like she *wanted* him to be jealous.

I looked at Troy. He was enjoying the whole scene.

The man pushed Eliza into the bouncing mass of the dance floor, toward the exit. Troy absent-mindedly slid a fifty toward me, and said something I couldn't hear. His eyes were locked on the place where Eliza had gone, and he didn't look back.

“Sorry I ditched you the other day, man.”

I acted like I had to recall this information. I swiped the inside of a glass and then squinted. “Oh. Yeah man, what *was* that?”

Troy was looking fairly haggard, even for him, and had trudged into the bar at precisely eleven. He had propped himself up against the bar top and mumbled incoherently. Now that he had a beer, he was speaking English again.

Troy's attention had been captured by a game on the TV. He yelled at it, and then turned back to me.

I blinked at him. “What *was* that?” I repeated. I didn't want to let him off the hook. I had been thinking about everything I had seen that night, almost nonstop, since it happened. Mainly thinking about Eliza's burning look, while another man nibbled on her ear.

Troy looked confused for a moment, and then his eyes lit up brightly.

“*That*, ” Troy said, “is the solution to all my problems.”

He waved a finger at me, and for a moment I thought we were maybe not talking about the same thing. Like he was thinking of duct tape, and I was thinking of Eliza.

“Yeah, you know...I wasn't super into it at first. It was all Eliza's idea.”

“What was?”

“Man, her...” he leaned over the table, “her *fucking other guys*. It's so *fucking hot*.”

My head was having a hard time processing things, if only because this was not the Troy I knew. *Troy* was the slut, not the girls he dated.

Okay, well, maybe the girls he dated. But not like this.

I cocked my head in genuine confusion. “So what, like...you have an open relationship?” I made air quotes around “open relationship” and immediately felt like an idiot.

Troy shook his head. “Gimme another beer.”

We were silent while I poured his beer, and he gulped half of it in one sip. “Ahhhhh!” he announced to the bar. Then he looked back at me.

“No, see. This is thing. It's not an open relationship. It's just Eliza, fucking guys. In front of me.”

I smiled, trying to look wiser than I felt.

Surely he was fucking with me.

“You don't believe me,” he said. He held a hand up, as though taking an oath. “Swear on my mother's grave.”

“Your mom isn't dead.”

“When she's dead. Look, whatever, I don't even care if you believe me. I'm just telling you, it's the way to go.”

“Letting your girlfriend fuck other guys.”

Troy was drinking some more of his beer, and it slid down his chin as he shook his head fervently. “No, no. No man, you got it all wrong. It's not...I'm not *letting her* fuck other guys. She's doing it for me.”

I stared at him.

“I don't get it,” I said, after a beat.

But something inside of me sort of turned over. Like I maybe *did* get it.

Troy shook his head, this time at himself. “Yeah, no. No, not at first you don't get it. But it is like....the hottest fucking thing I have ever seen. She does the *nastiest shit* with these guys, and she's like, you know, doing for me. Like she's making a porno for me to watch.”

“Buuuut...” I sounded like I had a frog in my throat. To tell the truth, just imagining Eliza doing anything nasty had made my cock twitch a little. But there was something about the image growing in my mind, of Eliza on all fours, taking it hard from some other guy, looking at Troy with that searing stare. It was surprisingly hot to me.

Really, *really* hot.

“Wouldn't you rather be in the porno yourself?” I argued.

Troy held up a finger. “You'd think so, wouldn't you? But no man, that comes later. It's fucking crazy, I know. But it's so fucking hot. You have to try it.”

My mouth went dry. For a moment I thought it was a real offer, and I opened my mouth soundlessly.

“First, though,” Troy said, his eyes going back to the TV, “we gotta get you a girlfriend. *No FUCK!*” he screamed at the TV, sucked back into his game.

And that was the last I heard about it for a long time.

But it wasn't the last time I thought about it.

The more I thought about it, the more I could understand it. The images of Eliza looking to Troy while another man nibbled her ear, looking at him while another man slid his hands up and over her breasts, in public, replayed in my mind. Every time I thought of them, my cock got hard and I had to jerk off.

There's nothing new, I told myself, in being attracted to another man's girlfriend. Especially the Elizas of the world.

But I knew there was more to it than that. It wasn't, after all, Eliza leaning over the pool table and showing her perfect ass off that I thought about.

It wasn't Eliza's big dark mouth opening up for *my* cock that I fantasized about.

It was Eliza, Eliza with cock in her mouth, and her eyes looking the other way. To her boyfriend.

You hear about this kind of thing, of course. (I mean, you hear about everything nowadays.) You see it as a choice on porn sites, and I had just kind of glazed over it. I was a single guy, I didn't have a wife, and to tell the truth I thought the kink was pretty wacky.

Until Troy and Eliza.

Until Eliza and her sexy, burning looks. Until I saw other men feeling her up and tasting her, right in front of Troy's eyes. Until I got a taste of the excitement that crackled through the air when Eliza looked at Troy, and Troy got an eyeful of another man stroking her long nipples under her shirt.

And then, of course, he got to see the whole thing.

Or did he?

It was eating me up. It was pretty much on my mind all the time. I wanted to know more about it, but it took me a while to get up the courage to say anything.

Finally, I broke.

“You know that thing you say you do with Eliza?” It was a lazy Saturday, and we were having an informal party in the courtyard of my apartment complex.

It was a ludicrous time to bring it up with Troy. Half the apartment complex was there: a loose collection of sometime enemies and sometime

friends, depending on how loud a party was and whether you were invited to it. I don't think I even knew anyone's name.

Eliza was sitting in a kiddie pool half-filled with frigid water. She was wearing a black bikini and had her face upturned to the sun. The cold water had splashed goosebumps all along her legs and arms, and hardened her nipples beneath the thin fabric of her bikini.

Most importantly, she was ten feet away and could easily hear us, even over the too-loud music and the loud-because-drunk voices at the barbeque.

But for some reason, I didn't care. I'd had a few beers and the curiosity that was burning inside of me finally got the better of me.

In response, Troy just nodded, as if it were the most natural topic in the world to bring up. Like I had asked about a snowboard he had purchased, looking for advice.

I looked at Eliza. There was no telling if she was listening. She had propped her head up on a pile of beach towels, and large black sunglasses hid her eyes from view as well as giving her an extremely glamorous, movie-star appearance. She could be asleep, or she could be enjoying all the guys' eyes wandering up and down her body.

"Do you..." I hesitated, and lowered my voice to a semi-whisper. "Do you, like...get to see the whole thing?"

Troy leaned back, as if to get more comfortable in his chair because he was about to tell a long story. In the pool, Eliza shifted, and her big breasts undulated on her chest, teasing us all with the promise of slipping out from under the bikini. Pretty much every guy there, and even some of the girls, waited with baited breath. Her breasts did not fall out, however, and so I turned back to Troy. He had a light grin on his face, I suspected from enjoying everyone watching his girlfriend.

"Oh," he said, and his voice was not low. "Yeah. Yeah man, I hide in the closet or something. It gets tricky. Some guys are into it, you know, just let you sit there and watch. But some guys think it's gay and shit. But yeah. I like to watch it." He sucked himself forward by the abs to get out of the pull of the flimsy lawn chair, and leaned on his knees. I was thankful he dropped his voice at least a little to say: "You can smell it, too. You know? So yeah, you gotta watch."

At that moment, I had the most amazing olfactory experience I have ever had in my life. I had a hallucination, a smell hallucination, and the

scent of pussy and Eliza's soap rose up in my nostrils, singeing them as if she were really there.

I put my beer in my lap, against my cock, hoping to cool it down.

In the pool, Eliza came to life, just barely. She lifted her sunglasses, and winked at me. Then she let them drop onto her nose.

Something inside me flipped and flopped.

"How do you choose the guy?" I said, because curiosity was pushing me on, even if Eliza was listening to the whole thing. Or maybe *because* of that.

"Oh, it's like...sometimes her, sometimes me. You know. Sometimes it's a game, like we bet on two of them and then try to get our own guy to win. Flip a coin. Sometimes she just likes someone." His voice suddenly sped up with enthusiasm. "That's my favorite. When Eliza picks."

I looked furtively at the pool. Eliza had smile on her face, and she turned her thumb up in the air silently.

I looked back at Troy. He had sort of faded into a fantasy of some kind. Then he snapped out of it. "Hey man," he said. "Can you reach that cooler? Grab me another brew."

So I watched this unfold for a while. Maybe months. They didn't do it every time we went out; sometimes they just hung out at The Yard and Eliza played pool in tight pants while every guy in the place watched her bending over. Sometimes Eliza spent the whole night plopped on Troy's lap, laughing her big laughs, tossing her shiny hair, and smashing her pillow-breasts into his face.

But other nights, Eliza stopped on her way back from the ladies' room, and let another guy buy her a drink. Troy watched from wherever he and I were sitting, as she slid into another booth with another man, and touched her lips while he told her all about himself.

It was a strange experience. Eliza wasn't my girlfriend, and of course I knew that. I didn't even want her to be. But I was getting off vicariously, I guess, through the experience. Watching Eliza let another man touch her collar bone. Seeing another guy let his fingertips wander down her soft skin to the line of her tube-top, his mouth getting closer and closer to her lips...

In truth, I think I only saw Eliza leave with two or three men, with Troy leaving right after. He stiffed me with the bill once, just up and disappearing and leaving me to pay the tab and get home. He apologized

later, explaining it all just happened so fast, which was true because I didn't even see Eliza leave.

And then came the night I got to see what happened, from start to finish.

We were meeting a group of people for “Amber's birthday,” and who Amber was or why anyone cared about her birthday, I never found out. I don't even think we saw the mysterious Amber all night.

The bar we ended up at was the ultra-trendy Blue Martini, an open-concept open bar that was, inexplicably, entirely red inside. The only blue in the whole place was a giant neon sign in the shape of a martini.

“It's so...*Cocktail*,” Eliza declared, taking the scene in from the entranceway.

She was wearing a particularly hot pair of pants that night; they were tight, white, and made of a thin fabric that allowed the darker hue of her skin to show through. Just barely, not untastefully – just hinting at what was underneath. As the night went on, black lights would reveal the outline of a white thong nestled between her round buttocks, and in front, just a sliver of white that was the only thing covering her dark, curly snatch.

It was clear from the moment she stepped into the place that it was going to be one of those nights. She turned to Troy and gave him a sweet kiss on the cheek, and then she began to move in that very deliberate way of hers.

Some beautiful women move like skanks, where every step is so over-the-top sexual that it's practically desperate. Eliza wasn't this kind of girl. Not so obvious. But there was an element of sexuality that she turned up, just a little, when she and Troy were up to their game. A slight smacking in her narrow waist. A little more of a sway to her round ass.

She left us with a promise to get drinks, and then she was gone. Eliza cut through a crowd much more easily than we did. Everyone got out of her way, and then they closed up the gap she made to catch her retreating figure.

The music got louder. Troy pointed at a group of girls who appeared to be abandoning a half-circle booth that looked out onto the bar and a dance floor.

Eliza came with drinks and went, but she didn't get very far. Nearly every guy she passed said something to her. Some she smiled at, and tossed

her hair for, and even touched on the arm. Some she rolled her eyes at, or gave the finger. Some she ignored.

I looked at Troy, who was sipping his beer and watching everything unfold like he was watching TV. I had a realization that I was keenly jealous of Troy for a bunch of reasons: one, that he could be so calm while his girlfriend flirted with other men, and two, that he had the kind of girlfriend who did that sort of thing.

After about half an hour of blaring music, no conversation with Troy, and no hope of attracting any of the high-pitched, hysterical girls that were swarming the place like schools of glittering fish, my mood soured. I decided to try and leave early. I didn't even know why I was there.

I mean, I did. I liked watching Eliza flirting with other men.

But I also didn't.

"Troy," I said. "I think I'm gonna roll."

Troy raised his eyebrows, and then his glass. "Why's that, man? Evening's just getting started."

Maybe for you.

I pointed vaguely at my throat, and my head, meaning, I guess, to indicate that I felt sick. I picked up what was left of my beer and slammed part of it.

Troy held up a finger. "Man, let me get you another drink. Okay? We came all the way down here."

He was gone before I could protest.

A cluster of blonde girls, all in baby-pink babydoll dresses, all of whom looked very under-aged, edged toward the booth. They fluttered and giggled, and finally a brave one, with blue eyeshadow on her pastel eyes, pointed at the table. "You leaving?" she mouthed, and then clamped her lips on her straw.

I shrugged.

The girls rolled their eyes and scooted away.

Eliza plopped into the bench next to me, sliding over the back of it, long legs first. Her shirt caught on the pleather and rode up, over her smooth stomach, all the way to the soft curve of one breast. Then it slid back down.

I looked the other way, as though assessing something by the bar. She was blocking my way out now, and looking at me with a peculiar expression.

“How's the hunt going?” I joked. I wished I had a beer to sip or something to do. “You find your man?”

Eliza tossed her hair. “Now, Connie, it almost sounds as though you disapprove.” I could see her smiling in the corner of my eye, her jaw lifting, her eyes devouring me – though exactly how or why, I couldn't fathom. “But yes, yes. I got my man.”

I set my beer on the table. Eliza's long leg was crossed now, and her pants slid up to reveal a swath of her toned calf. Her perfect ankle and smooth foot were bobbing lightly, criss-crossed by straps of red leather that matched her shirt and the bar itself.

It seemed as though she were expecting something. I looked up at her. Her eyes were on me. Burning through me. She tapped her fingers on the pleather.

“Good guy?” I said, not really sure if I was joking with her anymore.

“He's cute.” She put a finger between her teeth and bit on it.

I nodded. Eliza disarmed me. I tried to play it cool when these two got up to their games, but it wasn't easy.

“So?” I said, looking around.

Troy, just then, hopped – actually hopped, one hand on the back of the booth, legs in the air – into the booth next to me. His feet came within an inch of a passing girl's face. He had it smoothed over in seconds, with his charming grin. “All good here?” he shouted, at Eliza. The music had suddenly gone louder.

Eliza gave her foot another sultry spin.

Troy turned to me. “You good, buddy? I told her it might be..I dunno...weird.”

My eyes were still on Eliza, and she raised her eyebrows, just a millimeter or so.

Suddenly I got it.

They had chosen me to be their bull.

“I dunno,” I said. I did know: I knew perfectly well that even though it was little off of my *actual* fantasy, it was still close enough that there was no way I was turning it down. I also knew that Eliza was licking the ridge of her upper lip, and staring at me with her fuck-me eyes, and that my cock was doing most of the thinking for me.

Eliza was amused. She shook her perfect foot a little and squinted. “Too weird,” she said. But she didn't seem to believe it was. She seemed to

know she was going to get what she wanted.

I imagined all girls like Eliza would know that sort of thing.

There was an awkward pause between us.

Troy waved his hand in their air. "Look, man, if you really don't want me there..."

I felt a sinking sensation in my chest.

It took me a moment to put my finger on it. On why I felt a sense of disappointment, of an opportunity escaping through my fingers.

Luckily, at that precise moment, a passing girl recognized Eliza and screeched her name in the high-pitched squeal all women use for other women they haven't seen for a while. Eliza stared at me for just a moment, and then broke her spell to look up. She popped out of the booth and began doing one of those rocking-hug things girlfriends always seem to be doing.

From there, the evening went along as most evenings did before it. I had too much beer. I sat around waiting for something to happen, looking at pretty girls with Troy. Watching Eliza flirt.

But in the back of my mind, this time, was the offer that Eliza had put on the table, and then seemingly abandoned. It's what kept me from going home.

Inwardly, I was struggling with my disappointment. I tried to tell myself it was for the best. I didn't want to get involved in something like this with a good buddy's girlfriend. I didn't want to have some group sex thing happen.

It was all for the best.

But the lecture I was giving myself wasn't really working. It wasn't even that I genuinely didn't want to have sex with Eliza, or that I cared so much about what would happen with Troy. I was in college after all. It wasn't a time of deep thoughts about whether or not to have sex.

The disappointment came from *wanting* to see Eliza tease him; from wishing that it was me she was teasing instead of Troy.

I found myself alone at the mirrored bar waiting to place a drink order when Eliza appeared next to me.

She stood close, even though there was no crowd at the bar, and her hot skin touched my bicep, burning through my shirt. She smiled at me in the mirror.

Then she leaned on her elbow, and placed her fingers close to her mouth. She bit one of them. The bartender, who had been ignoring me,

caught sight of Eliza and appeared in front of her almost magically.

As he did, his eyes devouring Eliza, she snuggled up to me and placed her hand on my back.

“What can I get you, darlin’?” the bartender said.

Eliza turned to me, as though we were very, very close friends. She moved my torso with her hands, so she could put her arms on my shoulders. “What will it be, honey?” she said. She leaned closer, and by then my cock was so hard I knew there was no way to hide it from her. She gave a flicker of a smile when her leg rubbed against it. Her breasts were brushing against my chest, and I could feel her nipples through her shirt and mine. Her mouth was by my ear now.

“You want me to do this guy while you watch?” she whispered. “Is that it?”

Her words made my cock get even harder with a thud. For a second I went completely blank. Everything was tingling with excitement, from deep inside me, outward to my skin.

She leaned away from me and appraised my face. “That’s it,” she said. She had assessed the situation and now she knew. Her hand traveled down my torso as she turned back to the bar, and it wandered over my cock, tracing its shape through my pants.

I stood there, dumbfounded, my ears ringing.

She tossed her hair and leaned over the bar. She made the bartender smile with whatever she said. Or maybe because her two breasts were dangling there for him to look at. Only a small collar of red silk and lace hid her nipples.

She ordered drinks, and they came to us promptly. I just stood there, watching her flirt, absorbing what it felt like to be Troy. I stayed facing the bar, because my erection was enormous.

She turned to me after the bartender left to attend to other customers. She scrunched up her nose. “I don’t think he’s into it,” she said, casually as ever. “Also, he doesn’t get out of here until 3am.”

I stared, a little stupidly, because I had almost forgotten what planet I was on, let alone what we were talking about. Then her words spread through me again: *You want me to do this guy while you watch.* The skin on my neck turned pebbly with goosebumps at the thought of it.

She turned to me after a pause and batted her eyelashes. “I need my beauty sleep. I can’t wait until three.” She moved closer to me, forearms on

my shoulders again. “Soooo....I guess you'll just have to settle for *me*.”

When she said this, she leaned closer with every word, until her lips were incredibly close to my mouth and I could feel the light puff of her breath on my lips. A wave of electricity traveled through me. I was too stunned to move, too turned on to say anything.

Her body came even closer, and the heavy fullness of her breasts melted into my chest. Her arms entangled me, and I could feel her legs against mine, through the fabric of my pants. The muscles of her thighs were firm, and my mind went immediately to what it would be like to have them on either side of my hips. How it feel to have those tight thighs pulling me deeper and deeper inside of the pussy I had not stopped thinking about since Troy had mentioned it at the bar the first day I met her.

I had no idea what to do with myself, or my eyes. I looked down, and saw her full breasts smashed against my chest, spreading out into two big pillows of warm-cocoa colored flesh. Her shirt had rippled a little and a wave of lace opened up and let me see a crescent of dark areola. I looked helplessly away to where Troy was sitting on the couch, and I caught his eye. He was watching the whole thing with amusement.

Back to Eliza's face, so close to mine. Her fingers were on my spine now, just below my neck, stroking me. They moved in little circles, up to my hairline, into my hair. Her long nails raked through my hair and sent a real shudder through me. Her pupils widened in excitement when she felt it, and her fingers prodded me forward. Her lips were close now, dark and full, and just centimeters away from my mouth.

“Don't you worry about Troy,” she said, and her voice hummed on my lips. “Just pretend it's you and me.”

She lifted her leg a little, to rub the top of her sculpted thigh against my erection. Her mouth twitched in a little smile. “Good size,” she said. She moved her mouth along my jawline, and up to my right ear. “I can get the whole thing in my throat. I can lick your balls while I do it.”

I sucked in my breath, and when I did it occurred to me that I hadn't breathed at all for a long time.

Eliza leaned a little away, and over the bar. Her long hair slid like black sand across her shoulders and almost hid her face. She brought her drink to her lips and knocked it back.

Whiskey. It stayed on her mouth, wet and fragrant, so when she leaned back in to kiss me, she still tasted like it. Another jolt went through

me, and then a single fleeting thought about Troy. And then her lips pressed against mine, and her teeth nibbled at my lower lip, and I forgot all about everything except her.

She reached down and took my hand, and then held it up over her head as she sauntered through the bar. I followed, entranced, never once giving any thought to who had paid for the drinks or about my jacket, which I never did find after that night.

Things worked with a strange clockwork from there. A cab seemed to be waiting for us, and Eliza pushed me in. I opened my mouth to ask about Troy, and she placed a long, beautiful finger on my lips and shook her head. Her eyes showed that she knew what I was thinking, and her smile told me not to worry about it. Troy, she seemed to be saying, had it all figured out.

She gave an address to the cabbie, and then turned toward me.

At that moment, it all seemed really absurd. Maybe the high she had given me in the bar had a little time to wear off. A tiny voice in the back of my mind was suggesting that I call things off. It was feebly sending images of me and Eliza, being watched by Troy. Feebly telling me this was a bad idea, one I was not into, a thing that would be sort of weird...

But Eliza's hands got to work, sliding up and down my thigh, and then between my legs. She didn't even glance at the cabbie, whose eyes flickered occasionally to the mirror for a peek. Eliza snuggled close to me, her hand rubbing the length of my shaft through the fabric of my pants. My eyes were on her mouth, and the thoughts my conscience attempted to deliver up were stomped on by the memory of her voice:

I can get the whole thing in my throat...

My eyes went to her swan-like neck, and my mind imagined her throat opening up, the flesh spreading apart as my cock moved down her throat. Just I pictured this, her dark pink tongue emerged from her mouth and moved along my lips, before she pressed her whole sweet mouth against mine and her tongue darted around in my mouth. She bit into my lower lip as she pulled away.

We were already there. The cab had slowed and as I panted, almost immobilized by my lust, it stopped and Eliza fished into her jacket for a twenty, which she flung at the cabbie without any indication of wanting change.

She pulled me by the arm out of the cab, and I followed like a zombie, up the steps of a walk-up and through the door of what I assumed

was her own apartment. I watched her incredible ass, almost at my eye level on the steep steps, and pictured the dark bush that framed her cunt between her legs.

The inside of her apartment smelled like her. I gave the place a quick glancing over. Clothes were scattered everywhere. I had a brief thought about Troy, and what would happen with him, but my thoughts were obliterated by Eliza moving like a serpent, twisting out of her transparent white pants. The white thong that the blacklights had hinted at occasionally was now visible, a skimpy piece of lacy fabric that, I knew, cut between her perfect buttocks in the back, and formed a tiny v-shape just between her legs. She hooked her fingers beneath the fabric, and shook her hips a little, as though she meant to slide them away and show me the patch of curls I had been imagining. But she stopped, and instead lifted the tight red shirt, an inch at a time, as I watched with my breath caught in my throat. Finally the fabric caught on the swell of her breast, and lifted them with it, up and up. I watched, transfixed: any moment it would give.

At last, the shirt was too high, and her full breasts slapped back down to her chest. They were huge, totally natural, loose and jiggly and full. Her aureole were dark and enormous, and her nipples, as promised through her skimpy bikinis and half-transparent shirts, were long and already pebbled with excitement.

I heard the door click behind me, and that's when I realized this elaborate strip-tease had been less about enticing me (I was, after all, already completely enticed and a sure thing at this point) and more about waiting for Troy.

But Eliza didn't even give a glance over my shoulder. She was standing, still in her very high-heeled shoes, naked except for her white panties. She was glorious, and she knew it. She tossed her hair over her shoulder, and stepped toward me. One foot in front of the other, like a model on a catwalk, or a stripper. Her long legs seemed almost shiny. She put her hands on either side of her breasts, plumping them up, pushing them together. She rubbed her thumbs over her own nipples.

She had a grin on her face, because she knew what she was doing to me.

Closer still. She was right in front of me now, and I placed my hands on her frame. Her skin was hot, silky, and her overheated sexuality seemed almost coiled beneath it. I slid my hands down to her hips, and then I pulled

her to me by grasping her incredible ass. It was solid in my hands, hard and perfectly round.

But she pushed against me. "I gave you a promise," she said.

She moved down my torso, pulling my shirt up with one hand while her mouth found my abdomen and sucked my skin between her two full lips. Her other hand was expertly working on my pants, unbuttoning my fly, unzipping me. I felt my pants slide down my hips with her gentle tug, and then the elastic of my boxers was going, down and over my cock with a slightly painful snap, down to my knees as well.

By now, I had completely forgotten that Troy had anything to do with any of this. It was only Eliza and me, just as she had promised. Her hand was slightly cool as it closed around my cock. She gave me a squeeze and loosened her grip, sliding her hand up and down my shaft with a feathery touch.

When she reached the tip on a third or fourth pass, she used her thumb to swirl around the tip of my glans, lightly scraping her fingernail along the ridge. Lightly, softly, she made a circle around me. She looked up at me while she did this, watching my reaction.

My eyes, though, were on her mouth. As good as it felt to have her tease me with her soft hands, I wanted what she had promised: her whole mouth to swallow my cock, and her tongue to lap at my balls.

She guided the end of my cock closer to her mouth, and moved it slowly over her lips. Her lips were wet and the moisture coated the tip of me, so that when she pursed her lips and exhaled on my head, her warm breath cooled the light coating of saliva and sent her breath right through me.

She extended her tongue, and flicked it at my cock. She squeezed my shaft and pumped me until a tiny bead of precum formed, which she sucked off, actually sucking, until it felt like she might suck my entire orgasm from my dick.

She teased me this way for a while – likely it wasn't that long in real life, but it seemed like an eternity to me at the time. And then, finally, she opened her mouth and began to take me inside of her.

Until now, Eliza had looked at me, and we had maintained the illusion that it was only the two of us in the room. So much that I had really all but forgotten about Troy, or that this was his girlfriend. Eliza looked at me as she took me all the way inside of her mouth, all the way to the back of her

throat. Her lips were still stained with the cherry-red lipstick, and she made good on her promise to give me a ring around my cock: her lips pressed against my hair and I could feel them on the tender skin of my scrotum.

And then, her tongue shifted in her mouth, sliding against the underbelly of my shaft. I struggled to keep myself together as I felt the soft and wet meat of her tongue slide against my cock, between her teeth and lips and out of her mouth. The soft-hard tip of it grazed delightfully across the super-sensitive skin of my ball sac.

As the tip of her wet tongue tickled the skin of my scrotum, I made an incomprehensible noise and fought to keep myself from going over the edge. I wanted to make things last as long as I could, but it was hard to take the heat of her mouth wrapped around my cock, and the soft pulse of the back of her throat as she strained to lick my balls.

I held myself back as she made several passes over my balls, and her throat spasmed around my cock with the effort. I might have lasted a little longer, but then Eliza's long lashes lowered, and swept her eyes away to where Troy was watching us.

Now, you may think this is strange, considering that I had a hot woman's mouth around my cock and she was lewdly sucking it all the way to the base and licking my balls, but the sight of Eliza looking at Troy was what made me burst at that moment. Eliza, with my cock in her mouth as deep as it could go, with her red lipstick smeared into my pubic hair and across my pelvis. Sharing that same burning, complicit look, not with me, but Troy. That's what did it.

I put a hand down to her head, to give her some warning, but Eliza was not really in the room with me. She kept looking at Troy, and retracted her tongue to slide her mouth quickly up and down my shaft. As I came she opened her mouth wider, and pulled back so only half my cock was in her mouth. My cum gushed out, dribbling from her lips and onto her chin.

All the time, she looked at Troy, giving him that cock-stuffed smile of hers.

Eliza licked my cock off good. I had never seen or heard of a girl actually doing this, but she extended her tongue and lifted my still-hard, sensitive cock to place her tongue flat against the bottom of my shaft and lap up the dribbles of cum from my balls to the tip. She made slow, lazy circles around my shaft, getting every drop of stray cum. She pulled my balls into her lips, and sort of pressed them together to rub the skin of my

scrotum together between her two strong lips, and slurp the last droplets of cum from every hair on my ball sack.

It felt so good it almost hurt, and she held onto my cock with a fierceness that let me know I was not to make a move until she was done.

The thing, though, that got me hard again, so soon after exploding in her face, was that she looked at Troy the whole time she cleaned me up. Smiling, almost winking, as she lapped up my cum and licked at my cock, and nibbled on my balls.

She finally returned her eyes to my cock, and she smiled, as though she was surprised to see what she must have already felt in her hand to be true – I was hard as a rock again.

She looked up at me, and rubbed my shaft. Her smile was both friendly and challenging.

Abruptly, she stood up.

In her shoes she was exactly my height. She slid her panties down, slowly, to just above her knees.

I had no idea what she was up to, what she wanted from me next. My head felt drained of oxygen, and I could hear my heart in my ears, pounding.

Eliza turned and climbed onto an item of furniture that later in life I would learn was a chaise lounge. The apartment was small, a bachelor, and so it was directly behind her. She leaned on the back of the lounge, and bent over. She tossed her hair and looked behind her. First at me, then at Troy.

I still hadn't looked at Troy, and I didn't now. Eliza's legs were bent together at the knee, where her stark white panties seemed almost to tie her knees together. She splayed her feet, with their heavy red shoes, in opposite directions and kicking up slightly, so her spiky heels were waving and teasing in front of her ass. Her bare, flawless ass, and the dark little patch of hair on the edges of the bright pink gash.

I watched as she smiled at Troy, and then at me, and then slid a finger between her legs and into the fuchsia-colored flower, dripping with her own excitement. A sticky crackle came from her gash as her finger slid up and down, between the lips of her beautiful flesh. She reached further, dragging her juices up to the puckered hole of her ass, where she made a circle, moaned, and then headed back to her clit.

I was transfixed by this, I might have watched forever. She began to finger-fuck herself. First one finger, then two. I watched her mocha skin

moving in and out of the unfolding pink flesh of her cunt, absorbed as though by a fire, until she purred. “Conrad. I want you to fuck me until I come.”

I obeyed her, stumbling over to her upturned ass and nearly falling over my own clothes. I knew she had arranged things for Troy to watch, and that was what my mind was on as my cock sank into her pink flesh. What would it be like to watch your girlfriend toss her hair back and moan as she took another guy's cock inside of her?

I gripped her hips and thrust deep inside of her, and then, when I felt myself coming, I pulled out and watched my cum splatter across the honey-brown rounds of her ass. I stood there, panting, dizzy, and then sort of backed up and sat down on the floor before I fell over.

It wrapped up sort of awkwardly, with the two of them collapsing into a make-out session on Eliza's bed that looked like it would get pretty intense. I made up an excuse about having to leave, and Troy waved me away. I rode home in a cab, thinking about what it would be like to grab my girlfriend's ass, feel the hot, wet cum of another man on my palms, and then fuck her with my aching cock.

I didn't end up talking much to Troy about that night. I saw him at the bar again, and he might have said something like, “We cool?” to which I probably said, “Yeah, man.”

At the time, I dismissed the whole thing as a drunken adventure. It had been really hot, and I kept replaying it in my mind, but for a while I told myself that was because the blowjob had been incredible, and because Eliza was fucking hot.

But all this time, the image that stays with me from that night, and the thing I thought about the most, was Eliza's eyes on Troy as she sucked on me. I don't dredge up much else about Eliza – like I said, she wasn't really my type. But the sight of her eyes meeting Troy's, off to the side, staring right at him while she sucked on my cock, that's what I couldn't get out of my head.

By the time I got around to realizing what it was about Eliza-Troy that had turned me on so much, Troy had left for a job somewhere out East. I wanted to talk to him about his relationship with Eliza – how he made happen, whose idea it was, how it worked out for him.

But it wasn't the kind of things you just called someone up and talked about.

So I did what any man would do.

I turned to the internet.

It turned out, of course, that there were a lot of men out there who liked to see their girlfriend with another man. Or their wife. Whole communities of men, whole forums full of advice about how to approach the "lifestyle." It was a common fetish, it turned out, which made me feel better. But that being said, it wasn't exactly "out there." You never saw it in a movie, for instance.

I was a lurker, too. Everything guys wrote about how they lured their girlfriends or wives to the idea just didn't ring completely true for me. The pictures were silly: nothing more than regular porn with a caption that asked me to believe it was my girlfriend doing another man.

But of course, it wasn't my girlfriend. A guy can only suspend his disbelief so much.

The porn was even worse, because none of these women acted like or were anything like the women I was dating. They didn't scream like them, or say the things my girlfriends said, or move their hands the same way when they clawed at the sofa or the bed.

The only thing I really had was my own imagination, which I put to good use at night.

The one image that remained with me, that really worked? Eliza's eyes looking the other way, meeting Troy's eyes.

Or even better, when I could hear her voice, grating right through me in the most sensual way. Soft like velvet, and serrated like a knife:

"You want me to do this guy while you watch? Oh...that's it."

And later, when I had a steady girlfriend, all the way up through and including Laura? I loved to imagine that very same scene. Except I am where Troy is, and Laura's eyes are on mine.

And Laura's mouth is on another cock, and the cum welling up in her mouth is the cum of another man.

But how do you say that to your wife?

So that's how things were.

This was all just fantasy. Something I whacked off to and thought about of myself. I didn't dare to share it. And then life took a surprising turn

of events.

SOMETHING HAD TO CHANGE

LAURA

“Are you crying?”

Was I? Was I crying?

I felt my cheeks.

“I think I'm just having some kind of hysterical fit,” I said, and my voice was calm, calmer than I expected it to be. It didn't even sound like my own voice.

A laugh was leaving my throat, also. It all seemed to be coming from someone else. I even looked around, from face to face, to see who it was. Who the fuck had the nerve to laugh right now?

My eyes moved over the scene in front of me again. Even my eyes seemed to be moving on their own.

This must be it.

This must be how people have a psychotic break.

I remembered reading, once, about people who had gone into fugue states. They had just walked out the door one day, forgotten everything about themselves, and wandered around, maybe getting a new job and a new house, and in some cases, a new family. And then ten years later or something like that, they snapped out of it.

I had a private fantasy, just for a few seconds, about doing that exact thing. Just faking it.

Faking a fugue state. Why not? It was better than cleaning this up.

“I just don't understand,” I was saying, and my voice sounded a lot like my mother's, which only caused my chest to tighten even more, “how....how?!!! HOW?!”

I was about to lose it. I had more to say than that, but my mouth, like my eyes, seemed to be on its own course.

Something about my voice was obviously crazy enough to make everyone, including the dog, stop and stare at me. Anyone old enough to have the idea began looking sideways for an exit.

Conrad was eying the door.

I pointed a finger at him. “Don't you even think about it,” I seethed. “And get that animal into the laundry room before he -”

I watched the whole motion sort of roll through Bruce, the family dog. Up his spindly legs, into the muscles of his hindquarters and forelegs. I was going to happen, I could see that. The torque was building. It was going to wring itself through his muscles, then skin, then fur.

And all of that blood-red spaghetti, and all of that dark sticky chocolate milk, it was all going to turn into droplets of sticky, staining nastiness.

I watched them launch. Thousands of different trajectories. They streaked through the air.

And landed. Landed, landed, landed. On the ceiling. On the paintings. On my new pants. On the sweaters, tablecloths, and cupboards.

I closed my eyes as spaghetti – still warm – splattered all over my face.

I don't want to be this person.

That's what I thought first. Before “that person” even took hold of me, like I was possessed.

I didn't want to care about spaghetti on walls. Or whether or not enough fucking vegetables had been served to these two gnome-sized people who refused any food that wasn't white. This person who was so filled with bitter, bitter rage because there were no matching socks in the entire fucking house.

This person, who was going to end up cleaning spaghetti off the ceiling, because I had left the room for ten minutes.

With another adult *in the room*.

I opened my eyes and sent them, like daggers, at Conrad.

The white walls of the kitchen, and the ceiling, and the children, were all flecked with red.

A sort of red, murderous haze started to creep up from the bottom of my eyes.

No. It was more like the red of desperation.

Go-crazy-and-get-committed red.

It wasn't as if nothing like this had ever happened before. We had two small kids, a dog, and a turtle. We'd seen a lot of shit, literally and figuratively.

So I don't know why. I don't know why this one, particular thing was “it.”

A sound emerged from my chest, and sort of gurgled around in my throat. By the time it left my mouth, I had no idea what it was. It didn't even feel like it came from me. Tears began to well up in my eyes, and then my sight was filled, as if I were underwater.

But I was also laughing.

"Oh god," I heard myself saying. I was wiping frantically at my eyes, but they were filling up faster than I could wipe the tears away. "Oh god." I sounded hysterical.

Then I realized:

I *was* hysterical.

I was *actually* hyperventilating.

Conrad – I think – helped me to a couch in the other room. Cleaned the kitchen, called a babysitter, told me to take a bath, brought me some wine.

I barely remember any of that.

My eyes were red and salty, but I was calm and actually feeling a little bit foolish, when Conrad came into the bathroom and sat on the toilet.

I mean, who has a breakdown over spaghetti?

He had his jokey, friendly, problem-solving smile on.

This smile. It's a kindly smile that somehow is fatherly and best-friend-y. Sort of over-charming, like George Clooney or Mathew McConaughey. The kind of smile you feel like you shouldn't let someone get away with, because it's just *too* fucking charming. But the kind of smile you also know you're just going to go along with and feel better because of.

The smile was, among many other reasons, a thing I had married him for.

He just smiled this smile, and raised his eyebrows, and the whole conversation was done with.

This is something I appreciate about Conrad, even if it's also a little aggravating. There's no need to talk for thirty minutes about how, even though I was a super person and trying my very best, I was coming apart like a five-dollar watch. No need to say what a great mom I was and how anyone would start losing their mind; no need to tell me that maybe Jenny Heller did fine with her four kids but she was also pretty dumb and didn't need much else besides her homemade fucking pies to be entertained to pieces, besides she probably had a stash of Valium somewhere. No need to say this was straining our relationship, that I was becoming uptight and

slightly crazy, that we never had sex, that all I talked about was organizing socks.

He just got that all out with his smile and his eyebrows.

Something needed to change, he was saying.

And he was right.

I leaned back against the edge of the tub and closed my eyes. "I know," I said. "I know."

"I have a plan," he said.

I shook my head. "If this is some, send-me-to-a-spa-for-a-day thing, it's great, I'll take it, but..." I could feel mild hysteria building up in my throat. "I just...it's not enough."

And it wasn't enough. I needed something...else.

"You don't want to go back to work, do you?"

I shook my head. That would be worse, I somehow knew.

Although...

I remembered my old job. I saw things in a new light now. Rows and rows of clean, orderly file cabinets. Clean hallways, that someone else cleaned. Tidy "in" and "out" boxes, with everyone putting the right thing into them. All the tall people walking around, unsupervised, who could be trusted not to stick anything metal into the uncovered electrical outlets even if you turned your back on them. The sweet, sweet silent times and hours where I just typed and completed things and no one complained all day that their Leggos were too big to put through the cheese grater or cried because the dog was white and they wanted a spotted dog.

It actually seemed like a dream.

Conrad had already moved on.

"Do you need an afternoon to yourself?"

"We tried that before..." I said.

Such a waste of money. I just felt guilty the whole time. I usually ended up shopping, or taking some overpriced yoga class, and then buying an overpriced coffee, and the whole time it wasn't even relaxing because I knew the babysitter was at my house letting the kids eat millions of crackers and trash the place. And I was paying her for it. Fifteen dollars an hour because I lived in the sticks.

I groaned.

"You want to do some kind of nonfiction story, right?"

My head was spinning. I had no idea where he was going with this.

He was referring to my oft-dismissed ambitions as a writer. A mental image of my dusty laptop, storing the 237 pages of unassembled and half-useless memoir, pained my head.

I squinted my closed eyes.

“Okay...so I have an idea. Don't knock until you think about it, okay?”

He waited.

I groaned again. “Okay.”

“Okay.”

I opened my eyes.

Still with that cheesy smile. Involuntarily, I grinned back at him. Oh, whatever I felt about any of this, at the end of the day, I had a great guy in Conrad, and I *did* love him. I swirled the wilted bubbles around and held up my hand. My fingers were pruned. “*Okay*,” I insisted.

He just wanted confirmation. I have a tendency to react poorly to suggestions right off the bat.

Conrad was still smiling.

I splashed him. “Okay. I got it. Okay?”

He wiped his face off with a towel.

“Okay. Here it is.”

And then he waited for like a full minute, just to irritate me. I started sliding down, into the water. I blew a flotilla of bubbles away.

“*Conrad*.” I am not a patient person.

He laughed. “What if you got, say...a hobby job?”

For some reason, this had no effect on me whatsoever.

In fact, it went through me in a flat way, like a steady hum.

And then it felt almost...appealing.

I sat up. I was already thinking of problems. It's what I used to do.

“The only thing is -”

Conrad held up a hand. He started speaking quickly to keep me from interrupting. He had given it a lot of thought. “I know. But surely there's something you could volunteer for or...I dunno, like wait tables or something just one night a week. It's something to do, you're making some money so you don't care about the babysitter, you can quit any time, you'll meet some new people, you won't feel guilty, and it might give you something to write a short piece on -”

“I got it!” I shouted. I splashed him again. “I got it okay? You're brilliant, you thought of everything.”

I sank down again and let my head disappear under the water. The world was muffled to near-silence.

A hobby job.

I hated that it was such a good idea.

I hated that I hadn't thought of it myself.

I already knew the places I would apply.

I already felt a little bit guilty that I was already looking forward to leaving the house behind, to seeing someone else besides Conrad for the evening, to doing something, anything, besides be here.

I didn't want a real job, either.

I wanted some kind of entry-level, brainless, mindless, pay-your-way-through-school job. Or a shift at a factory. Something like that, where I could just tune everything out and chit-chat with people. I loved articles about that kind of thing. They were all the rage right now among the would-be journalists of the world. I had just read one by a guy who had worked as a meat-packer. I had loved it.

I sat up, out of breath.

“I'll think about it,” I said, wiping water from my eyes. “Now get out of here.”

Conrad smiled and handed me a facecloth. He knew his suggestion was great, and he knew I didn't need to think about it.

“So fucking smug,” I told him, wiping my face.

He kissed me on the forehead, and left the bathroom.

I put the washcloth over my eyes. At the end of the day, no matter what happened, at least I had Conrad. Sure, some resentment built up about the minutia of life, but at times like this I remembered how lucky I was to have him.

We had moved to the small-ish community of Kearny, about thirty minutes outside of the last rings of the city, with the great intentions of relaxing in the country. Conrad worked at the edge of the downtown core, and in point of fact, his commute wouldn't be that much longer. Some friends had told us about the property, because they were always “leaving town” to go look at antiques and apple orchards, and they had discovered

this little town – maybe hamlet would be a better word – at the bottom of a big ravine, almost a valley, tucked away into the trees.

In Kearny, you could almost believe you were really out in the country. A collection of houses were scattered alongside the creek, which was usually just a bed, and a convenience store and “hall” were all that contributed to the “town.”

But a ten-minute drive south placed you in the ever-expanding suburbs, which had come crashing against the city's greenbelt, a tract of undevelopable land. Kearny was inside the no-development zone, and so Kearny would remain as it was.

At least we hoped.

The house we bought even had a septic tank. We had to order propane gas.

Before Madison, I had thought I could keep working and take care of the kids and manage everything just fine. It became clear, after Madison in particular, that not only was it a ton of work, it wasn't any fun. I made a decision I thought I would never make.

To be a stay-at-home mom.

I didn't even like thinking about that phrase. It gave me a queasy feeling.

But...it relieved the pressure. No more food thrown at the microwave and scraped off the lids of Tupperware bowls. No more grocery store at ten pm. No more cramming feet into shoes as quickly as possible to get them in the car and to day care, no more high blood pressure in the car at 6:17pm, feeling the ten-dollar a minute late daycare pick-up charges draining from my bank account.

Time to invest in writing, which is what I had wanted to do all along anyway.

The house was great, the best of both worlds. Big-box stores fifteen minutes away. My friends were all on the other end of the city, but who cared? I was too busy to do anything with them, anyway.

It all seemed like it was going to be a dream. And in many ways it was.

But then the boredom set in. The routine of it all. The whining, the daily grind. There was no time for anything I had hoped to do. No sitting on the nice porch and watching the cattle on the adjoining farm graze their way

through the pasture. No idyllic afternoons of canning freshly picked apples from the trees at the bottom of our yard (they were full of worms, for one thing, and canning, it turns out, was a huge pain in the ass).

No writing.

Just whining, messes, driving to stores, putting things purchased at the store into a cupboard, and listening to more whining.

No. It was great. It really was. I preferred it. I really did.

But by the time Conrad got home, my brain was diluted so much I couldn't carry on a conversation.

And what's more, I really didn't want to. I had nothing to tell him about except how much milk had been spilled on the floor or how many loads of laundry I had done. How the dog had gone missing for an hour. Who knew to where?

And then there was the resentment. It's inevitable. Conrad never did any laundry. Conrad never put anything back in the fridge. Conrad was always so tired from *his* job, while I envied the hour in the car he had to himself, *twice each day*, to finish one or two fucking *thoughts*.

I almost always went to bed at nine. Conrad wasn't too tired to put on some TV, or go to his office, where I knew but just didn't care much that he watched some porn.

I didn't want to admit it, or talk about it, but I didn't really care.

I mean, yeah – I wanted to have sex. I knew he did, too.

But it was all just so tiring. So mundane. It was hard to get excited about things. Before I knew it, a month had passed without us doing much more than kissing goodbye in the morning. A quick kiss, the kind that didn't really even get on the mouth.

I felt a twist in my stomach. A long-buried longing, to feel Conrad's body next to mine. Not through clothing, not just lying there dormant and sleeping...skin-to-skin, his cock getting hard next to my thigh, or maybe in my hand.

Something had to change.

PIED PIPER

CONRAD

“Believe me, it's fine. I don't even care where we go.”

Laura smelled like a citrus bubble bath, and her brown hair was still slightly damp from her bath. She seemed to have emerged from the bathroom a little like a butterfly from a chrysalis, so I was feeling pretty good about myself and my idea. It wasn't just that she had worn her hair down, or put on a nice dress – she was smiling. Vibrant. Completely changed.

She flipped the sunshade down to look in the small mirror while she applied lipstick.

I tried to keep my eyes on the road. One of the things I've always liked about Laura, and never really told her about, is that she doesn't make that stupid face that most women do while she puts lipstick on. Instead of shaping her mouth into a creepy “o,” fit for a horror movie, to stretch her lower lip out, she just puts it on. And then she gives herself a little pout. I like to catch it when I can.

“Oh my god Con, you're halfway in the oncoming traffic.” She didn't look away from the mirror, though, and her voice was calm. Nothing was diffusing her good mood, which was great but mildly disconcerting since she had been close to going to the looney bin this afternoon.

I steered back into our lane. I heard the light puff of air of her lips pressing together and then popping. She smiled. “This lipstick is so whoreish. Where did I even wear this? To work?”

“I think it looks good,” I said. I meant it. I let my eyes pass over her legs.

She swept her straight, full brown hair from her face and sat back in the seat.

I slowed the car, but hesitated. “Are you sure about this...we can always drive into town -”

“Meht,” Laura said. “I've always wanted to try this place, and I really don't care what we're doing. I'm going to drink an enormous beer.” She pointed at the sign, which hilariously proclaimed: *The Pied Piper. Scottish*

Music. Enormous Beers. “But plus also, I want to ask them if they'll hire me.”

I turned into the parking lot. “Fine,” I agreed blithely. I dismissed the part about them hiring her as a half-joke.

I was a little surprised by how enthusiastically Laura was taking to my idea of getting a hobby job. Usually, Laura shot down any ideas that didn't originate in her own mind with a meteor shower of reasons it wouldn't work. Then, a few days later she would come back and propose what she called a compromise, but which was essentially the same idea with some moderate twist.

When I called her out on this she laughed at herself and then claimed it had to do with her career leaving a permanent residue on her mind. Which was bullshit. She was just stubborn.

So it was a little odd that she had not only agreed to my plan, but was now joking about implementing its first stages less than an hour later.

She moved toward me in the parking lot and linked her arm through mine. I felt a shiver course through her and she pulled herself close to me like she wanted to tighten a knot. She flipped her hair over her shoulder and looked up at me. The night was much chillier than the season, and felt like a late fall evening, like it would bring snow with it by the end. Her cheeks were red already.

She gave me a smile. Not the wan, tired smile that she gave me nowadays, almost always, but a real smile. An invigorated smile. She was excited about something, and it had energized her.

I stepped hard on the urge to compliment myself on how wise my idea was. I just wanted to enjoy her buoyant mood.

The Pied Piper, to which Laura had told me to go, was a divey restaurant on a two-lane highway into the city, as you went in from Kearny. One of those places that stands all by itself in a bunch of hayfields, and you aren't really sure how it got there.

The name was a corny play on words. They served five kinds of Shepard's Pie and had a live bagpipe show on Tuesdays, apparently for the large numbers of Scottish retirees who had holed up in one of the suburban tracts down the road.

It was Wednesday, thank God, and the live music seemed to be all quiet guitars without too much amp. The place was, in spite of the weekday hour, pretty busy.

Laura surprised me by passing over the hostess podium and heading straight for the bar. She was quicker than me, as though she knew where she wanted to go all along. I watched her knee-length skirt swing back and forth over her ass, and noticed that her bare legs were dimpled with gooseflesh from outside. Her calves were strong and shapely, and they ended in a pair of black shoes that looked a little like a ballerina slipper. From behind she looked almost girlish, with a thin black sweater clinging to her shape. She shed the light sweater from her shoulders as she walked, and revealed her smooth arms, toned by many years of hauling children around. The dress, which I had seen before but all but forgotten, was a pretty black number, just barely casual enough to be at The Pied Piper. Her shoulders were almost completely bare, because the collar of the dress swept low and wide. Looking at her smooth skin, I felt a little pang of longing and excitement.

It seemed like Laura was already transforming. She sat down with a flourish and placed her elbow on the table, reaching behind her to run her fingers through her shoulder-length hair. She watched me approach the table, and gave me an impish smile. She bit her lip. "This place is perfect," she said, and I knew she didn't mean for dinner. Rather, for the plan I had made.

I know I should have just been thrilled that Laura was in a good mood. That she seemed to be recovering from the near breakdown she seemed to be having in the kitchen. That she was listening to my advice for once, and trying to make the situation at home – which honestly had been spiraling out of control for months now – better.

But it irked me a little that she was so...*excited* about it. Embracing it so much.

I had this uneasy feeling as I sat down at the small bar table with her. She stretched her arm across the table to me, but instead of feeling, as I should have, a simple pleasure that she was squeezing my forearm affectionately, I surveyed her gesture critically. She was draping herself over the table, swinging one bare leg over the other, playing with her hair. Her movements were more those of a younger Laura. A flirtatious Laura. The kind of Laura who I had crossed the room to talk to so many years ago.

I should be happy about this, I thought.

Instead, I felt something nagging at me. I looked around the room, and saw one of the waiters, in passing, run his eyes up and down Laura's

body.

The bartender popped out from behind the bar and set down two napkins. He was one of those hardened characters, who had been a bartender for too long, in too many half-dives like this one. His face was grainy and yellowed by too much smoking, and his boyish features were crumpled into what appeared to be a permanent, no-nonsense frown.

But the guy's features softened slightly when he looked at Laura, who was really laying her limbs everywhere on the table and flipping her shiny hair around quite a bit. I watched his eyes do a skillful scan of her body, and then his downturned mouth softened. Just a little. But it did. "What can I get for you lovely people?" he asked. "A glass of wine? Martini?"

The "lovely" was clearly intended for Laura.

"A giant beer," Laura said. Her enthusiasm gave him a kick, and the pleasure registered on his face as his smile grew a little. He was turning in tiny increments more and more toward Laura, and away from me.

"We only have enormous beers," he said wryly.

"Oh. I had really hoped for giant one."

Laura's eyes were sparkling and she gave her hair a little fluff from behind her neck.

She was. She was *flirting*.

"One giant beer for a lovely lady," he said, warmly. I could hear the flirt building up in his voice. His like for Laura was evident, and he wasn't doing much to hide it.

It was just a little too long, a matter of seconds really, between the end of this proclamation and when he turned to me. During which time I saw his eyes make another, professional sweep over Laura's body – the man had skills, it went completely unnoticed by Laura – before he looked at me. His face began to harden as soon as it was out of Laura's sunny glow.

"And for you?"

I wanted a wine, to be honest, but I ordered a "giant beer" to not look fruity next to my wife.

Laura guzzled down her beers, plural. Three, in fact. She was fascinated by the menu, scanning it for fifteen minutes and excitedly pointing out the menu items to me that made her squeamish ("Haggis egg rolls" and "Haggis and Bashed Neeps" made her particularly squeaky.) "What is even in haggis, really? Oh god...you don't think they make it here

do you?" She was whispering, a little drunk, leaning over the table with the large menu spread open in her hands.

Most notably, she had kicked off her shoes. Her foot was busy between my calves, stroking me, very sexually. Her hands occasionally went for my knees and my inner thighs in the same sexy manner.

I almost wanted to look under the table, though, to make sure it was her, because above the table she was simply reading the menu as if it were the most interesting thing in the world.

The mixture of nonchalance and heady sexuality was driving me wild.

Also, it had been ages since I had seen Laura like this. Animated. Flirty. Sexual.

All of a sudden, she was blinking at me, as if she expected an answer. My own thoughts were entirely on her exposed collarbone, her wandering foot, and the occasional view I could glimpse of her breasts, when she leaned forward.

"No way, though, right?" she said, saving me from having to explain that she was distracting me too much. "Oh look! They also have fried pickles...pickled eggs...Jesus! Look at this: Scotch Egg."

She pointed to the menu, and I pretended to read the description as her foot tickled the back of my calf. I ended up just looking at her lips.

"You're not reading," she told me, matter-of-factly, but cheerfully. "We'll just get one. Let's get one." She waved the bartender over.

Laura preceded to eat a Scotch Egg (a deep-fried, meat-wrapped, hard-boiled egg that was delicious and would ordinarily have prompted Laura to tell me how she would need to run for an hour a day for a week because of it), fried pickles, and, after two and half "giant" beers, the Haggis egg rolls.

"I have to work here," she said. "I have to work here, it's like, it's *fated*." She tossed a half-eaten haggis egg roll into the basket. "I will not, however, be eating that again. Oh, god."

In a series of flirtatious exchanges between Laura and him, we had learned the bartender's name was Mac. Mac appeared out of thin air and took the basket. "I could have warned you about that."

Again, he spoke only to Laura. Edging his body toward her, cutting me, metaphorically anyway, out of the picture.

His voice was warm.

Laura laughed. A little over-the-top laugh, as if he had just told some very clever joke she would never forget. She reached out and placed her hand on his arm.

I watched her hand with a mixture of dread and delight.

It was just a friendly, drunken pat, I told myself.

“Hey,” Laura said (and was it my imagination or did her voice seem sultry?) Her foot was still against my calf, her little shoes had been kicked off and her bare foot was worked up under my pant leg. She rubbed her toes against my leg, but she batted her glistening eyes at Mac with her hand on his arm.

The scene sent a new, savory thrill through me.

“You don't have any job openings here, do you?” Laura sang.

Mac looked perplexed, his game having taken a very confusing turn.

“Uh...is it like, for...”

“It's for me,” Laura said. “I just need something to get out of the house, so like one night a week.” She had her hand in her chin and her hand was *still on* Mac's forearm. She had propped her hand up on her fingertips, and she gave them a tiny walk on his arm before she seemed to realize what she was doing, right in front of her husband. She quickly pulled her hand away. Her eyes gave me a quick, apologetic glance.

“Uh...yeah, I mean, you could stop by tomorrow, Lorraine'll be here. It don't really know what she's got planned.” I could see his mind churning. Thinking of how nice it would be to “share a shift” with Laura.

He even brought back a card with a phone number and the hours Lorraine would be there printed on the back of it with his block handwriting. Laura took the card in her slender fingers and somehow managed to move it in her hand in a flirtatious way, rubbing along the edges and tapping lightly at the corners.

Oh god, I was going fucking crazy. I realized I was drunk.

“You don't really want to work *here*?” I said to Laura, who's eyes were still locked Mac and smiling at him as he retreated.

She snapped her look back down to me suddenly, and it was at that moment that I saw she had been mostly putting on an act. The entranced, drunken flirt was gone, and the expression she wore when she was cooking up a plan for work or writing had taken over her face.

Again, I felt a wave of mixed feelings slap me in the face.

Was I disappointed that she hadn't been flirting?

“Are you kidding?” she whispered. “This place is perfect. So many sad stories,” she said, and her eyes went quickly to Mac, “so much strange, Scottish angst, haggis, walking distance to the house, and like...what is this place, out in the middle of the country, but not? There's a Staples like a mile from here and then a dairy farm out back, you know? I will definitely find something to write about here.”

She took her beer in one hand, but the glass was so large and the momentum of the beer made it slip down and away from her, sloshing around. She laughed at herself and set it down. “Oh god. I'm hammered. Let's go home.”

And her foot resumed making its way up my leg. Now she was looking at me with a look that it had been a long, long time since I saw.

My spirits lifted.

I waved my hand in the universal sign for “check.”

Laura tipped her head back in the car and laughed. “Oh, my god, I really hope I get a job there. That place is a *gas*.”

She turned her head and looked at me. She was slouching a little in her seat, and she had placed her feet on the dashboard. Her conservative-lengthed dress had slid down her thighs, almost to the round curve of her ass.

I noticed that whatever it was Laura had been doing in the basement of the house as a workout had definitely paid off: her ass was tight, and kept its round shape even there on the seat.

“Hmmm,” I said. “Are you sure you aren't just trying to get some 'gas'...going with....Mac...”

Laura was laughing by the time I got to the end of my sentence. “Is that your idea of a play on words, Con?” she said. But she was entertained.

“Yeah,” I admitted. We laughed together.

“Put your seat belt on,” I advised her.

Laura leaned forward, leaving her feet on the dashboard. Her skirt slid even further down her legs. “Get my gas stove lit by Mac,” she teased. “Gonna gas it up with Mac.” She lost it again, and I chuckled. God, it was so good to see her in a great mood, even if she had to have three beers to get there. It had been a long time.

She was peering into the darkness, and making no move to put her seat belt on.

“Laura,” I said. “Buckle up. Seriously.”

She leaned on her thighs, pressing her cheek against hem and blinking at me. “You could just go that way,” she said. Her arm extended toward the windshield.

I looked into the darkness. “It’s a field...” My statement began matter-of-factly, but I keyed in on what she was suggesting halfway through it. “Ohhhh,” I sang, enlightened.

Was Laura seriously suggesting we go have sex in the field in our car?

“Really?” I said.

Laura laughed. “Do it. Do it quick so we get home in time for the babysitter.”

The parking lot of the Pied Piper, in the middle of semi-nowhere as it was, ran up against a field that had no fence and appeared to belong to no one. It was a hayfield, and twice a year we had seen someone bale the hay, but a lot of trucks and tractors evidently used it as a shortcut between sideroads, which were spaced nearly a mile from each other in the Greenbelt.

I drove forward. The solitary sodium-orange light that barely lit the Pied Piper parking lot quickly faded away.

“Turn out your headlights,” Laura said.

Laura, when I had first met her, had been a surprisingly daring girl. You would never have guessed that about her, from the looks of her – her plain face, her plain attire, her Midwestern suburban glow – but she was quite crazy at times. That had all ended, of course, with the kids. I was enjoying the little flicker of it in her now.

I turned off the lights.

The hay was long, and it slapped against the car while I tried to put all of the bad things that might happen to the undercarriage of my vehicle out of my mind. What it is it that happens to us as we age? I had sworn I would never be this way: a hot girl was in my car and she wanted to fuck, and I was thinking about hay getting stuck in my engine compartment.

The car lurched with a loud pop as we hit a serious hole. I stopped and turned off the engine. “Okay,” I said. “I think that’s far enough.”

Laura leaned back against the seat and laughed. She reached a hand between her legs, and I watched her silhouette, barely visible in the moonlight and weak street lights that barely reached us.

The seat shot back and she laughed again as it slammed at the end of the track.

She was serious.

She pulled on her dress, fully exposing her thighs. She looked great. Her legs were in taut, athletic shape. The material of her dress slid all the way to her waist, where it bunched up just above her panties. Black. Lace.

I reached out and stroked her inner thigh. She had shaved her legs in the tub, apparently, and they were silky-smooth. It felt so good to touch her again, like this. With excitement. I put a hand on the collar of her dress, and traced its very low cut along her bared shoulders, over the swell of her breasts. I was satisfied when her breathing was arrested for a moment, and she started to flush.

Thoughts from the evening rose up, unbidden. Flashes of Laura, looking sexy and pretty, almost like another man's wife, filled my head. Her hand on Mac's arm, her fingers doing a little dance on them. Laura tossing her hair and batting her eyelashes for another man.

The desires I kept submerged most of the time overtook me in a rush. I climbed over the seat, and I did in a way that surprised me: hungry, with the ease of youth. I pulled on the lever to lean Laura's seat back, and she whopped as it slammed down with our dual weight.

But I was beyond having "fun;" my mind was being carpet-bombed by image after image of Laura. Laura in reality, flirting at the bar. Laura in my fantasies, sucking on another man's cock.

Laura placed a finger on her lip and stroked it. I pushed my fingers into her panties, past her neatly-trimmed bush (also a product of her long bath,) and found her slit. It was hot, and she was delightfully wet.

I indulged the thought: *wet because she was flirting with another man.*

Laura gasped as I passed over her engorged clit. She really was fired up, ready to go. It felt like a long, long time ago, when sex was a matter of urgency and need, not the chore it had lately become.

She had her hands on my belt buckle and was ripping away at it. When she got me free, she grasped my cock.

I allowed myself another indulgence: I imagined Laura picturing another cock. Comparing mine to another lover's. Wishing the shape of it was different, or the size.

Laura smiled as she stroked me. I guessed she was excited to find me as ready as she was.

I pushed her panties down, and held them as she steered my to her wet, ready opening. Her hot flesh enclosed me and I closed my eyes to steady myself.

My thoughts about Laura with another man had put me dangerously, dangerously close to the edge. But Laura moved underneath me, grinding herself against me, and her mouth opened slightly. She was also close. She moaned lightly and lifted her hips from the seat to slide up and down my cock.

To my delight, she closed her eyes.

Thinking about another man, my imagination prodded.

She opened her eyes, and looked right at me, as her muscles clenched my cock and her pussy seemed to turn to juice.

And then my mind let another image rise up inside of it: Laura just like this, her mouth open, and her eyes open.

But for another man. Another man on top of her, pounding her...

I buried my cock inside of her, but as her wet flesh throbbed around me I was thinking more about her being stretched open by another man than about my own cock inside of her. We both yelled as I slammed into her hard at the end, burying my seed deep inside of her.

Thinking, though, about her cunt filling up with another man's white cum.

Laura started laughing first, into my shoulder.

"What was *that*?" I said. It was a real struggle to get back into the driver's seat. I looked behind me and around the field as I buckles myself up. Laura was still amused, which had the effect of being disconcerting and heartening. This Laura, laughing in the passenger seat of a car after having sex in a field, was much more like the woman I had married.

But still. We were in our late thirties, and after the heat wore off from the sex, the whole thing seemed almost childish.

Laura removed a facecloth from her purse and leaned forward, after snapping the seat upright, to wipe her footprint off the humid windshield.

That was more like Laura.

But she was wiping a tear of laughter from her eye.

That was more like Laura ten years ago.

She looked at me, still smiling, and her voice was only comically urgent. “Con. Get us out of here before we get arrested.”

It looked like my plan, so far, was a good one.

A SHIFT

LAURA

The Pied Piper was not a pretty place in the backroom in the morning. The back room was lit up to its detriment by the daylight. The paint and tables were chipped and the carpet was a sea of concentric stains. It smelled of stale beer and, somehow, cigarettes.

Something about it, nonetheless, was appealing to me. The same thing I had liked about the night before. The near-trashiness of it offered so many possibilities for actually doing some kind of story, which would doubtlessly never get accepted but at least give me something to do.

Lorraine, the owner, was clearly not Scottish and seemed better suited to running a jerk chicken shop. She had agreed to interview me, without really telling me whether she had a job open or not.

She was looking up from a list of questions. Her voice was bored, and I could see she wasn't listening to the answers.

"Describe how you would up-sell a menu item," she droned.

I smiled. The only way to up-sell the Pied Piper was to recommend the patrons get in their car and drive to another restaurant. People were obviously here for the weird bands, enormous beers, haggis, and the heavy-handed bartenders.

"Look," I sighed. I remembered, suddenly, that I could take or leave this job. I decided to just lay it on the table. "The truth is, I just want four or five hours out of the house. I don't even care if I make that much money. But I paid my way through school waiting tables, I don't do drugs, my husband makes good money so I have no reason to steal, and I don't really care if you cut me most nights. You have one night a week I can do that?"

At first, it wasn't clear how this went over. Lorraine squinted, and then her huge body began to shake from the center of her torso outward. The laughter reached her face last, as if it had to crack through the cemented frown she had been wearing during the entire "interview."

"Oh," she said. "Lord, you have no idea how long I have been waiting to hear somebody say *that*. 'I don't do drugs...' 'I don't care if I get cut...' You know how many people I have stealing to buy drugs they do here at work

and then complain at me, I cut them too early, meanwhile they so stoned they set that deep fat frier on fire while they -”

Lorraine pounded her chest and wheezed to emphasize how amusing this next bit was:

“While they smokin' over it?”

Then, suddenly: “You can have Thursdays. You ready this week?”

“Uh,” I said. I hadn't honestly expected my tirade to work. “Yeah, sure.”

“Gotta have a sexy shirt. You got anything a little more...you know. Tight? Black.” She waved at me with a pencil. “Better tips.”

Sure. I thought. I know the game.

And so began my job at The Pied Piper.

In college, I'd paid most of my bills working in a restaurant as a waitress. I always said it really sucked.

But the Pied Piper wasn't anything like my old job. For one, I didn't need it. For two, I was looking forward to all the quirky characters as fodder for writing.

I wasn't there more than fifteen minutes, though, before all the plans for the Pied Piper turned to smoke. In a way.

I mean, everything just shifted, in a single moment.

“You the new girl?”

The voice was distinctly young, almost adolescent. I turned around and was face-to-face with a lanky, dark-haired *boy* with curly hair and cold blue eyes. A young twenty-something.

I will admit it. He was also hot. A really good-looking guy. All of the things I used to like in guys.

And then, a really frightening, delicious, horrible feeling spread through me from the center of my chest:

Oh god. He was giving me the *eye*.

I folded my arms over my chest and leaned against the counter, the way this crotchety old bitch named Nancy used to do when I worked at Tyson's Pit Barbeque Joint. Nancy was the woman I always admired most for not taking any kind of shit from anyone.

I'm sure my imitation of her was missing something, because he just kept looking at me the way he did.

“I’m the new *server*,” I said. I think the intention was to emphasize to him that I was not a *girl*.

Even while I was doing this, I couldn’t help but catch his flat chest against his faded black t-shirt, and his arms, solid and toned.

And I couldn’t help it. I felt a little flutter inside of me.

I actually had to force my eyes not to go any further down.

Jesus. What the hell was wrong with me? For a second I almost felt like I was back in college, working at Tyson’s, flirting with the bartenders, going out for drinks during lunch break, coming back and waiting on tables half-drunk in the lazy summer afternoons. The feeling swamped me with nostalgia. I felt queasy. Excited.

My “Nancy Impression” was amusing to the guy – the kid – and he smiled at me almost affectionately. “You’re the lady who wants to get out of the house,” he said, nodding. He had a flat salad bowl in his hand, and he palmed it and turned it upside down over the trash without taking his eyes off me. The wiry strength in his hand, holding the salad bowl with such ease, sent a liquid pulse through me. And not in a very virtuous place.

What the fuck, Laura?

“So you came here.” He waved around the kitchen of The Pied Piper, as though he were showing off a palace. A leaking pipe let a fat drop of water splash on a dirt-encrusted painter’s bucket, as though on cue.

A cook in the prep area chuckled and began to stir a vat of sauce.

I raised my eyebrows. *Keep it together*. “News travels fast in a restaurant,” I said lamely.

“Lotsa things do,” he said.

I was utterly unnerved by the effect this kid was having on me. I felt sure he was making some kind of sexual innuendo, but my mind couldn’t keep up with it. Instead, it was on his trim, youthful chest under his shirt. His dark, unruly hair. His hands, palming the salad bowl with an easy strength. The way he moved with so much energy underneath his skin.

I mean, seriously.

Before I could think of anything witty to say, he backed up and shuffled to the dishwasher. “I’m Nate,” he said. He gave a spin, and went out the door before I could say anything. But I *did* let my eyes drift down to his jeans, where his ass was very neatly tucked away beneath his hip, faded denim.

Did I just actually do that?

“Jesus. Laura. Get a grip,” I said, under my breath, and then cast a glance at the dishwasher to see if he heard me. He was spraying dishes and humming a foreign-sounding song, so I was probably safe.

I blinked. Was I actually feeling an...ache? Between my legs? From watching a guy palm a salad bowl?

I reminded myself that I was almost two decades older than “Nate,” technically old enough to be a mother to most of the staff who worked here.

This job was for fun, for possible journalistic purposes, and because I was going crazy at home.

I was thirty-eight, not twenty.

I pinched the bridge of my nose and shook my head.

I needed to get to work.

But my heart was beating faster, and my arteries were filled with excitement.

There was no denying that.

I got right back into the groove of being a waitress. I was a better waitress now that I'd juggled two kids and real, high-pressure jobs. Nate got under pressure and I helped him out with one of his tables. He was impressed, as was I, by my long-retained ability to hold three water glasses upright in the palm of one hand. Pretty soon the jokes were flying, and I found myself standing around in the circle of smokers outside in the back, “hanging out.”

I quit smoking when I quit waiting tables. Now the scent of the cigarettes was rising up in my nostrils and beckoning me for the first time in decades.

I wasn't going to smoke. Jesus, that was stupid.

But the open door, the laughter, the sight of Nate's casual stance, one foot up against a low cement wall – something about it was calling to me.

I walked out the door. It was dead in the dining room and someone would call if we were needed. I'd finished my most of my sidework hours ago and cleaned out the pantry for something to do.

I put my hands in my apron to show them I wasn't there to smoke, and they gave me the cool-kid head jerk of the head in response.

“You meet the new girl?” Nate said, to another twenty-something wearing the white apron of the cooks. He was sitting on the wall, elbows on knees. I stamped down on the quickening of my pulse. Another young guy,

busting with energy, tapping his foot on the ground. His arm was covered in tattoos.

“New *lady*,” I corrected, lifting my hands without taking them out of my apron to wave. I could see the two of them found it funny, and I felt a warm, flirty sensation spread over me. It had been such a long time since I had been around any real male energy – everyone we knew was married, or just older, more tired. The guys were giving me smiles of appreciation.

The cook blew smoke from his mouth without removing his cigarette from between his lips. “Don't you have a real job or something? What the fuck are you doing here?”

I don't know what happened in this moment, or why that particular comment made me feel this way. I just know that all the sudden it was like I was back in college. Smoking outside, free from any real worries, about to stay out late until three in the morning and meet new people, flirt with new guys. Nate and the cook were young, burning with testosterone – you could actually see it sort of glowing off of them, that vibrancy. I reached out to Nate, in that casual way that smokers do, but intimate smokers, friends, and he moved his hand without saying anything to give me a drag.

“Just want to have a smoke in some fucking peace and quiet,” I said, before I put the cigarette to my lips. I admit to knowing what I was doing as I did it. Batting my lashes a little. The gestures felt old, rusty, but still familiar. It had been a long time since I'd stood around by a trash can and...well, relaxed. The joke made them laugh.

The smoke curled up inside of my mouth. Instead of burning it went down like a smooth drink. Fuck, I thought. So many years of not smoking and the truth was it was fucking great.

The reasonable mom in me was already rising up in the back of my mind and having a level-headed conversation with the Laura who had taken over my body. You will not have another one of those, ever. *Don't even think about it.*

I handed the cigarette back to Nate. “Fuck that's great,” I heard myself saying. I could almost see myself now, through their eyes. Lifting my chin, blowing the smoke out of my mouth. An older woman. Still sort of hot. Interesting. Mysteriously working at the Pied Piper.

“Lorraine says you got kids. Is that true?” The cook, who had still not introduced himself, asked me.

I nodded.

He let out a whistle.

I suddenly felt like I was doing something wrong. I dropped the cigarette and put it out.

“I gotta get back to my tables.”

There were no tables. I just needed to cut myself off. I felt something inside of me that was a little frightening. Like my grip on the tightly ratcheted control I exerted on my life, at home, was slipping.

That was bad.

So bad.

I looked around the kitchen as I left it, making a list of things I could busy myself doing, to take my mind off...whatever it was my mind was on.

I mean, honestly. I could not believe how carried away I was getting by the first guy I's spent any time around for five years.

And he was so...young.

So lean. So athletic. So tingling with heated, animal, energy -

Laura, god! Stop it.

The dining room was as dead as when I had left it, so I went to the bathroom to cool off.

I looked at myself in the mirror.

I had worn an old shirt of mine, because it was the only slightly-fashionable, somewhat sexy item I could find. It predated the children, and I had only worn a few times. It was tight against me, and I looked at my shape in the mirror with a critical eye, even as I wondered what the hell I was doing.

I frowned at the curvier mid-section. Definitely different.

But still...not bad, right?

I turned sideways.

I was thicker, that was for sure. But I had worked hard to get rid of the pouch of fat the kids had left behind, and it was almost gone. I sucked in my stomach and straightened up.

Good as new.

I looked at my face.

I had never been a great beauty. I had a lot of quirky features and they didn't mesh, like some omen's did, into something stunning. I was “pretty.” Wasn't here some quote about how ugly people could be beautiful, but pretty people, never?

Anyway, I had somehow avoided crows-feet and baggy eyes, but my cheeks were doing that thing. Sort of falling. Like a souffle.

I had put on a little bit of makeup. My lips looked nice.

I tried to cheer myself up. For almost forty, I was not looking bad. In fact, with the silly waitress get-up, and the jeans, and the pony-tail, I looked pretty good. Pretty young.

I smiled at myself. I was fun.

Suddenly realizing what I was doing, I felt so silly I raised my hand to my mouth and stifled a laugh.

“Oh my god,” I said aloud. I looked around, as though someone might have sneaked in and heard me. This was ridiculous.

I shook my head at myself and walked out.

A rush of people, mysteriously, showed up around 9:00 pm to eat in the restaurant, so I didn't end up getting cut, as I had half-hoped I would.

And half-hoped I wouldn't.

I didn't know what I was hoping.

I was glad for the rush, glad to take my mind off of the really weird thoughts I was having about Nate, but without actually having to leave and not be around him.

I mean, they weren't even thoughts. No – if they had been actual thoughts they would have been smarter. I was having something more like a fever, shivering beneath my skin whenever I felt his presence was near.

I ended up having to re-do all my sidework, rolling silverware into napkins while listening to the dishwasher and cook – both Serbs – yell at each other over my head. I assumed they were fighting over soccer. It felt like old times, back when I waited tables through school. It gave me a little rush, feeling like part of a crowd from a different time in my life.

I smiled to myself.

Nate came whipping through the kitchen, whistling or spinning dishes on his fingers while he waited for an order. I kept my eyes on my silverware. I knew he wanted me to look at him, and believe me, I *wanted* to look at him.

I'll confess that I consoled my uneasy conscience (which was definitely taking a beating for feeling things stir way, way low in my abdomen) by telling myself I was ignoring him because I was being

virtuous. I was a married woman, and I wasn't going to be flirting with some young kid at a job I just started.

There was a darker truth there, though, and that was that I knew my ignoring him was getting under his skin.

And I wanted to be under his skin.

I rolled the last bit of silverware, and tried to get myself out as quickly as possible. This restaurant was...completely crazy. I needed to get home and think in the shower or something.

Unfortunately, Lorraine wanted to talk. She waved me in to her dingy office to have a chat about my first day.

As she fired questions at me about how things had gone, I smiled and shrugged and said “Good, oh, great,” over and over, but my mind was on Nate.

I tried to rein it in. Okay? I reminded myself I was married. I told myself I was being a desperate middle-aged woman. I tried thinking of my kids.

But I always ended up back on Nate. This fucking guy who I had just met.

The shocking thing, to me, anyway, is that I wasn't just thinking about Nate while I was sitting in Lorraine's office on my first day of work at the hobby job my thoughtful, wonderful husband had been kind enough to arrange for me. Not about how he was cute, how I might like to go on a date with him and ruffle his black curly hair. How maybe he was secretly into film noir or something.

No.

I was, whether I wanted to admit it outright to myself or not, thinking about how much he weighed, and how that would feel on top of me.

What it would be like to have a different cock in my hand. Inside of me. A different shape, a different size...

How much more enthusiastic a younger man might be. About *everything*.

Lorraine was looking at me, suddenly. Blinking, as though waiting for an answer.

“Yeah...” I murmured. “No, yeah, all fine.”

A brief wave of confusion crossed Lorraine's face, but it was just as quickly wiped away. I clearly hadn't answered her question, but she also didn't care. “Great. Okay. See you Thursday then.”

I hurried out to the car, half-laughing at myself. The laughter was mingled with admonishment – I mean, even just by having thoughts like this I was being a real shit to Conrad. He would never know, but I did.

As soon as I had stepped out into the night air, the strange trance the restaurant had been having on me had dissipated and I felt like a fool.

“God,” I said aloud, sticking my keys in the lock, since the remote had been broken, along with everything else I owned, by my kids. I shook my head. It was all so...tawdry. And stupid.

And then:

“Hey...new girl!”

Was I happy to hear his voice?

I felt excitement ripple through me. I felt all the false things I was telling myself hit me in the face and also blow away. I felt like being bad, and I felt like getting into my car and going home.

I turned to see Nate skipping across the parking lot. Hands in pockets, easy, athletic movements taking him across the pavement. “Hey,” he said. A light wind picked up his black hair. “Me and Chris are going to Ziggy's for a beer. Come with us.”

He cocked his head in the direction, I supposed, of Ziggy's. The two-lane highway headed out of the little village and toward the city.

I should have said: “It's too late.” Or, “I have to get home.” Or, “Yeah right, Benjamin Braddock-”

No, see, because he wouldn't even get that, idiot.

Instead I felt my mouth forming one of those “maybe” smiles. The one where your face is saying, “oh, I can't quite believe you're asking me this,” and you're smiling and everyone already knows you'll get talked into it.

The expression, in other words, of a twenty-year old bimbo.

What the fuck was I doing? I could feel this happening on my face, but I couldn't stop it.

“It's tradition,” Nate stated, his demeanor suddenly – sexily – quite serious.

Sexily, Laura? Get in your fucking car!

“You can't say no,” he stated, again with a weighted, serious tone. A confident tone.

Arrogant. Arrogant tone. He's probably twenty-one. He's just a little shit who knows he's cute and you're a batty old housewife. Open door. Get in car. Explain you have kids to kiss goodnight.

“Well,” I heard my mouth saying. “Is it far?”

I liked the way Nate was edging closer to me. He still had his hands in his pockets. A pleased smile was turning his mouth up again, the smile of making progress but not quite winning.

And his eyes were flickering with interest. I think that's what it was, really, in the end.

Nate was looking right at *me*. And not like, I was another person in the room he needed to step to the side of to get to the door or the trash bin.

At *me*. Trying to get me to give in, go for a drink. He was interested in something. It had been such a long time since anyone had looked at me like that.

“Just up the road,” Nate said, after a pause that was much too long. Much too interested.

This is all so wrong.

“Come on. We know you're married. It's part of the job.”

Say, “Maybe next week,” Laura. Act your age.

“I'll follow you,” my mouth said. “Give me a second to text home.”

And my body got in the car. And my eyes followed the old mustang they got into.

I sat down.

You're making a mistake here. Starting down some path of temptation you shouldn't go down. Just go home.

But wasn't this the idea? Go out, have fun? Meet some new people and write about them?

Nothing had even happened yet.

It was probably all in my mind.

It was just one fracking beer.

I typed.

[Me]: *Hey. Just going out for a beer at some place called Ziggy's? Crew says it's tradition. Can't get out of it.*

And then:

[Me]: Love you. Don't wait up. I'm too tired for this myself.

I looked up. The Mustang was in front of my car, the window down, Nate's arm hanging out the side. He was staring at me. When I looked up he raised his hand and gave me a thumbs-up, as a question.

I returned the gesture.

And we were off.

TURNED ON

CONRAD

It was much more annoying than I had anticipated getting home early, making dinner, and putting the kids to bed. Whenever Laura had made a comment about how she was exhausted at the end of day, or that I could just “once” put the kids to bed, I had felt irritation slide over me like a cheese grater getting dragged across my face. Now, I hated to admit that they were a huge pain in the ass and I was tired. And that the lame efforts I had made at “helping,” - like getting some pajamas, or watching them splash water all over the bathroom until Laura came and took over, were probably less helpful than not.

So I was feeling pretty good about myself after they went to bed and I had a beer and checked off my “good husband” and “better dad” boxes. I was helping out for real, I was being sympathetic to my wife, I was bathing children, I had made some food and cleaned everything up.

There was always the chance, also, that Laura's better mood from yesterday would continue. I wouldn't mind another romp, even a quieter one in our own bed.

I settled in to watch some TV.

My mind was nowhere in the realm of television, though. I was instead remembering the car, indulging my fantasies about Laura thinking of another man while we had sex, or imagining Laura right now flirting with Mac as she swung by the bar to pick up some beers for her tables. Batting her eyes. Smiling her smile.

It was all just a fantasy, though. A fun thing to think about, to get my blood moving. In reality, I was looking forward to Laura coming home, us sharing a beer, her telling me about her first day at work. I liked to hear Laura tell stories. She had a wicked sense of humor, and she painted everyone with it.

And then, maybe, we could keep our rekindled romance going upstairs...

I heard the phone buzzing and ignored it. I figured it was work. The second one came in, and then I ignored it a little longer, until it slowly made

its way around my brain that it was text and not an email alert.

I swiped at the phone and felt my heart lift at the sight of Laura's profile, and then fall as I scanned to the second, third, fourth words of the sentence.

[Laura]: *Hey. Just going out for a beer at some place called Ziggy's? Crew says it's tradition. Can't get out of it.*

[Laura]: *Love you. Don't wait up. I'm too tired for this myself.*

I read it. I re-read it.

I read it over and over.

I made myself lift my eyes and turn on the TV. I flipped through channels, but nothing I was reading from the menu was reaching my mind. My mind was filled up with circular thoughts.

There was disappointment.

And then there was the other thing. The feeling of paranoia, of jealousy. It was painful but it was also pleasant to slip into. I started brooding. Fantasizing. Imagining. In about fifteen minutes I was wired. I stood up and paced.

When I realized what I was doing I tried to stop myself.

First of all: I was being fucking ridiculous. Letting my heart start beating faster. My chest tightening up. For what? Why?

Second of all: I was being fucking ridiculous.

I imagined the crew from The Pied Piper, circa Wednesday night. A motley crew. A big fat man, a strung-out looking girl with stringy hair, and Mac.

But Laura had been stringing him on deliberately, and he was a pretty rough character. Not attractive. She wouldn't go there.

And Ziggy's. That place was a known dump.

Laura was probably miserable and trying to make the best out of a lame situation. Or cooking up more meat for her article on white-trash waiters.

But that thing, the thing that licked with a cool tongue at my heart, wouldn't dislodge itself. The jealous-lusty feeling.

It was too late to write her back now.

And say what, anyway?

Okay?

I typed it in, and my thumb hovered over *Send*.

I put the phone away.

For some reason, I decided to just pretend I had gone to sleep. Maybe I wanted to convey that I was such a cool guy that I didn't even think about what she was doing, and I had gone to sleep early. Or hadn't thought to look at my phone.

Oh, I imagined myself saying tomorrow morning, picking up the phone. My tone surprised. *A message. Oh. It's from you...*

Juvenile, I realized.

But I was still going to do it.

Without really being able to tell myself why.

I went to bed, queasy with these strange feelings I was having.

At one-fifteen I heard her come home, and I rolled on my side, willing my breathing to slow so I could pretend to be asleep.

Laura crashed around in the kitchen, and then there was a strange quiet. I heard water humming through the pipes, and I wondered what on earth she was doing. The realization hit me hard: she was taking a shower in the downstairs bathroom.

Why?

Where else can your mind go, if your wife comes home late and does that? What did she need to get off of herself so badly? And why did she do it downstairs?

Conrad. She's probably just trying not to wake you up. She probably smells like haggis and wants a shower.

Still...

Then I heard her plod upstairs. She closed herself in *our* bathroom without turning on the light, but then flipped on the fan. I heard her hiss at it: "*Shhhh!*" and then laugh at herself. She turned it off. I smiled in spite of myself. I loved the way she talked to inanimate objects. She apologized to the refrigerator if she bumped into it.

She stumbled around some more in the bathroom, and a quiet rage started building up inside of me again.

Except, I knew I was also being a huge dick.

And then there was the fact that I sort of liked the idea of Mac the bartender taking Laura to Ziggy's. Winking at her across the table. Asking why her husband let her stay out so late...

Laura slid into bed next to me and settled down like an elephant tamping down its bed. I almost laughed again.

Then all was quiet.

I had decided not to confront her that night because I didn't want to say anything stupid, and I was feeling and acting like an ass.

I closed my eyes and repeated my resolve to myself. But her antics in the bathroom suddenly rose up in my mind and I had an uncontrollable urge to laugh.

I hid it as an obnoxious snore, which she would believe.

I heard her stifle a laugh.

I closed my eyes and tried to steady my mind, and my breathing.

But then I felt Laura's body turn toward me. She was hot for some reason. I could feel the sandbag weight of her breasts against my back, and her nipples, two little stones, in the center of them.

Why was she so excited?

Her hand moved over my hip, and down to where my crotch was.

Where she found my half-hard cock, and purred a little before closing her hand on it through the fabric of my boxers.

I felt my dick twitching, rapidly rising to the occasion.

God. Why didn't we do this every night? How had we ended up the way we had, sleeping next to each other without so much as touching? The heat built up between us so quickly. Why didn't we let it boil over more often?

I could no longer pretend to be asleep, and I rolled onto my back, feigning sleepiness. My intention was to pull her to me and then keep rolling, roll on top of her. Dip into her heated wetness...

But she surprised me again slid down my torso, taking the top half of my boxers with her, peeling it away to let my hard cock spring loose.

Suspicion slithered around inside of me. There was a thing about Laura, that she had shared once upon a moon. She had confided it to me after she had given me the greatest blowjob of my life, and it was that she didn't care all that much for giving head ordinarily. But if she had enough booze and she was feeling really horny, it became one of her favorite things to do.

She wasted no time, after freeing my cock, in placing her lips around my head. Her mouth was wet and warm, and she moved her tongue in a circle around me. Then she grasped my shaft and pushed it forward so that

she could get to the underside of my cock and lick me from the base to the tip, her tongue flat against my shaft. She licked and licked, finishing off with a swirl over the tender bell of my glans.

But this was just her, teasing.

She reached the base again and turned her head slightly sideways. I felt her lips close around the flesh of my scrotum, right near the base. She sucked up some of the skin into her mouth and rubbed it between her lips. I gasped audibly. Her tongue made delicious circles over my balls, while her hand lazily pumped my cock.

I was rigid with desire, my head lifted to try and see what she was up to, but all I could see was her bobbing, glossy hair.

Her tongue made its way back to the head of my cock, dripping wet with spit. Now she gave a shake of her head, and tossed her hair back to look at me. Her saliva had caught up a few thick strands of her hair, giving her a messy, mouth-fucked appearance that drove me even wilder.

My cock was aching for her mouth, for another one of her rare and beautiful blow jobs.

But she pulled her legs underneath her, and I watched in confusion as she resettled herself. I saw now that she had no underwear on, just a silky nightshirt that was sliding off her shoulder. She scooted toward me, and spread her legs.

I was still unsure of where she was headed with this. I propped myself up, thinking she wanted to sit on top of me, but she pushed me back against the pillows and left her ass on the bed between my legs.

Then she reached with her hand, and guided my cock toward her.

I watched her use her right hand to pull her lips open. Her sex unfolded, petal after petal of dripping wet flesh. I propped myself up on my elbow to get a better look.

She guided my cock toward her, and I was trying to figure out the physics of whatever she was up to, when she pressed the tip of my cock against her clit. My head was kissed by her hot juices, and a few feathery touches from her soaked lips. But mostly, only the very tip of me was heated by her flesh as she rubbed my cock against her clit. Up and down. She closed her eyes and moaned as she used my cock to stroke herself to orgasm. Her body tensed, and her mouth went slack. Her eyes fluttered and rolled in her head, and she began to stroke faster and faster. The movement of my cock against her clit made her lips squelch with her juices, and she

started to rock her hips as she grew closer and closer. Meanwhile my cock throbbed in agony, just the head of it hot, as I watched my wife masturbate with my cock.

When she came she opened her eyes again, and her mouth spread wide as she gasped.

I sat, panting, as she enjoyed her orgasm, almost as though I weren't there in the room. My cock was so hard now I felt like it might rip open.

Then, she very neatly folded herself back up and under, and opened her mouth over the head of my cock. She teased me for a moment, her breath steaming my head, which was wet with precum. And then she swallowed me whole, her lips sliding down the length of me.

Her cheeks hollowed as she sucked me hard, and I gasped as my orgasm quickly built up inside of me.

She felt me coming, and took her time moving her mouth to the end of my cock. She sucked me off with a pop! and then stroked my shaft. With her lips right next to my head, she stroked me until my cum exploded. Strings of white cum slapped across her lips and cheeks, and she smiled.

I stared at my wife.

I shuddered, as I let myself indulge in the pleasant micro-fantasy, of Laura being splattered by cum. Just like she was now.

But cum from another man's cock.

“Fuck!!” I hissed.

Laura smiled.

JUST LONGING

LAURA

The dread started in as soon as the cab pulled up to the house. All the lightness of the evening fell down on my head, like a bucket of cold water had been thrown on me.

After all, what was I going to say?

I smelled my shirt.

Everyone else was smoking. You know how servers are.

Then there was the cab.

The fact that we'd have to go and get the car in the morning.

The fact that I was drunk.

I looked at the clock on the dashboard as I paid the cabbie.

Okay. Okay. It was only 1:15. Late. So late.

But not that late, especially for restaurants.

And it wasn't like I hadn't told him what I was doing.

I wasn't hiding anything.

Anyway, this is why I had taken the job, right? To get out of the house to have something of my own to do?

I was full of self-righteous indignation by the time I reached the door. I was also, I realized, a lot drunker than I thought. I closed my eyes and silently thanked myself for calling a cab. Refusing Nate's offer to bring me home. Giving the two of them cab money.

I half-expected Conrad to fling the door open, and start a fight with me. And I was ready for it, because when I get drunk I get guilty no matter what I'm thinking, and then I work out a defense for every possible interaction. Most of which never happen.

This was your idea, I was going to tell him. *It's not that late, what are you, my father...* it was all building up in a little micro-argument.

But when I opened the door, the house was quiet and dark.

I stumbled taking my shoes off, and made a clatter in the kitchen getting a glass of water. I stood in the silence of the house, in the dark, gulping a glass of water, my drunk buzzing in my ears. I felt like a teenager sneaking home late at night.

The effect was intoxicating.

I took a shower in the downstairs bathroom, singing silently, thinking about the evening. How much fun it had been to be out, laughing and drinking, singing karaoke.

Having men around. Young men. Unmarried men. Men who found me attractive, who were blatantly flirting.

Men I would never do anything with, of course...but male energy, male desire, pulsing around me. It had felt so good.

By the time I got out of the shower I felt guilty. Also there was no towel. I looked around. I was probably the first person to take a shower in that shower.

Fuck. Now I would have to clean it.

You are married, the shower seemed to be telling me. *You are thirty-eight years old*.

This evening had been fun but it was a one-time thing that couldn't happen again.

The reality was that I had a loving husband and a beautiful family, and a lot of laundry to do.

That was life.

To really drive it home for myself, I imagined the opposite evening happening: Conrad going out and tending bar one night a week, going out for drinks with all the waitresses afterward. Young, pretty waitresses who were looking at him with adoring eyes.

I slid into bed, cringing a little as the mattress moved with my weight. Stabs of guilt moved through me again. I had only ever moved like this, sneaking around in my own house, when I had been sick and trying not to wake anyone up. Now I was doing it because...because what?

Because in truth, I didn't want Conrad to wake up. I didn't want him to ask me why I was home so late, or ask me any questions about what I did.

Why?

It wasn't as if I had done anything I couldn't tell him about. I had gone to the bar. The music had been loud and I had let Nate buy me a few beers.

I had let him sit next to me, closer and closer until our arms were touching.

That's all. Nothing...obscene.

But you thought about it.

And now, as I was thinking about it, the sensation of his arm against mine sent a shiver along my spine.

I moved awkwardly, trying to jostle the sheets and the bed as little as possible, until I was facing Conrad.

He was face-up, his jaw slack, a dull snore rumbling around in the back of his throat. He seemed to be genuinely asleep.

Obviously not too worried about where I was.

I turned on my side without being careful of my movement.

How stupid was I being? How stupid was it to not want to wake him up, *and* to be annoyed that he was sleeping so peacefully, not a care in the world, assuming his wife would come home at the appointed time, not worried about it in the least...

I smiled at myself. I have this reaction when things get serious or intense.

I was acting like a crazy person.

Oh yeah. I was drunk. That was probably why.

Some guilt bounced around in my mind for a while, and then some irritation, and then some amusement about how silly I was being. Whenever I started feeling the warm glow of the evening's fun creeping over me, though, the guilt came back.

But the truth was, as I drifted off to sleep, I was thinking about Nate. Playing out a harmless fantasy or two. He was stirring up feelings I hadn't felt for a long time.

Not that I really wanted anything with Nate. He was a kid. But the *idea* of it, the way it was so forbidden....

We would exchange looks all night.

Bump into each other in the freezer, face-to-face.

His chest would be hard as a rock, young and warm when my hands pressed against it – accidentally, of course – and then our faces would draw nearer, nearer...

"I can't," I would tell him.

And that would be that.

Just longing. Simmering looks. Desire, that could never be played out.

It was all harmless, and Nate would move on soon enough. Or I would. In the meantime, there was no sense not enjoying the excitement of having some guys think I was hot, right? Of flirting a little?

Conrad gave a huge, loud sputter behind me, as if in protest. He shook me out of my freezer-encounter reverie. I covered my mouth to hide a laugh that threatened to escape me.

Of course, it was all so ridiculous. Conrad was the one I loved. Even if he was a loud sleeper, and even if we no longer had the sweet tension and aching of new love, new attraction, youth...

I closed my eyes again and tried to fall asleep without thinking about the very young, very good-looking guys at my new job. Without seeing Nate, smiling and palming salad bowls. Nate, smiling behind a cigarette. Nate's chest under his shirt, athletic and lean. I bet he could lift me easily with those climber-gym arms, the veins barely straining against his skin, his fingers digging into the flesh of my ass.

I wasn't sure what overcame me. I had an ache between my legs that had swelled because of the ideas in my head, and because of the attention I had been paid. But the desire pivoted very suddenly to Conrad.

I turned toward him.

I pressed my body against his.

It felt strange to be so horny at the end of the day.

I mean, really, it felt so strange to be horny at any time during the day.

I pushed my hand down to the front of his body.

I found his cock. Semi-hard.

The alcohol and the lust combined. It gave me an idea.

I stroked him through the fabric of his boxers.

It was rude to wake him up.

It was even ruder to wake him up when I knew perfectly well that I was going to think of something else...someone else...while I did what I was going to do.

But he wouldn't mind? Would he?

MILF

CONRAD

“So,” I said, kissing Laura on the back of the neck. “I didn’t get to ask you last night. How was it?”

My trepidation about Laura's shower, and the reasons she had been so horny, had faded a little with my orgasm and a good night's sleep. But I still had something gnawing at me. Something that didn't sit right.

Laura was behind the kids, pouring milk with expert efficiency into glasses. She had popped out of bed bright and early. She looked at me and gave me a quick warm smile.

She looked a little tired, but she had a lot of pep in her step. The slight dark circles under her eyes looked somehow less despairing. Her cheeks were flushed, and, most importantly, she was smiling.

She shrugged, though. “It's a pretty divey place,” she said. “I only made like...”

She hesitated. An odd hesitation, almost like she wanted to take back the sentence.

“Not very much money,” she said finally.

I opened the fridge. “You worked pretty late,” I said.

I tried to keep my voice casual.

After all, I was the one who had encouraged her to do this.

I knew how it was. You have a tough night, you work hard, and then everyone is pretty wound up. You have some cash. You want to go out.

“I went out with the...didn't you get my text?”

I closed the door and looked at her.

She looked genuinely concerned. Suddenly, I felt like an ass. I felt like an ass because I knew I was sort of reeling her into a guilt trap.

I shook my head. “I'm sorry,” I said suddenly. I felt the need to confess to not writing her back on purpose, because I had some sour grapes. I was actually jealous that she was out, having a good time. Even though I had been the one to suggest it. “I -”

“Get me some more water,” Jenny moaned.

“How do you ask?” Laura said sweetly.

“Please.”

Laura rolled her eyes and came closer to me, near the sink. She took down a glass, and turned on the water.

Taylor started crying. Probably because he wanted water, too.

God, these fucking kids.

Laura had clearly forgotten about my half-delivered apology.

“You meet any cool people?” I asked, after the water had been delivered, the faces wiped, and a few other concerns attended to.

Laura poured herself a coffee. “Uh...yeah, I guess. Pretty...standard people. You know. Kids, drug addicts, single moms. That kind of thing.”

“Oh. So who'd you go out with?” I wanted to leave it there, and not say what I did say next: “That Mac guy?”

I wasn't sure why I was asking all these questions. Partly, I wanted to show an interest in her hobby job. Wasn't that why we had done this? So we'd have some new people to talk about? Something else in our lives we could share?

Or was this just what I was telling myself? Because actually, I could feel a little bit of an itch.

A sort of spiteful, jealous itch.

It was stupid. I knew that.

But a man had to wonder, when his wife came home so randy.

God, Conrad. It wasn't as if she had never had a job, a full-time job.

And I hadn't felt like this about *that* job.

Okay, but it didn't help that Laura seemed to be deflecting the questions I was asking. It didn't help that she had been horny for the first time in...years, really...two nights in a row.

Did she hesitate a little too much before saying, as if she had selected the answer from several possibilities: “Nah, wasn't there.”

I watched her. She seemed to not even be paying much attention to the questions. Like it was no big deal.

It probably isn't a big deal, Conrad. You should probably just shut up.

But I didn't want to. I wanted to hear her say something that would cut deep, something that would explain her horniness in the most painful way possible.

“So who?” I prodded.

“You know. Kids, drug addicts. The cooks.”

I saw something flicker in her face.

The cooks, huh?

The cooks were always sneaking in there, grabbing up the waitresses. They charmed them with specially-crafted little crepes or some shit like that. Bartenders, sure, you could sneak them a drink, but it wasn't as charming as a personally-stacked olive-and-cheese teddy bear statue, or a sandwich made into a unicorn.

Also, girls seemed to be less wary of a food gift than an alcoholic beverage. Waffles with funny faces didn't scream "trying-to-fuck-you" quite as much as a personalized martini.

I stopped myself.

What the actual hell was I *thinking*?

Laura turned to me, a box of cereal in her hand. She smiled sweetly now. "It's pretty funny." Then she mouthed, "I'm so *old*!" She continued. "These guys are talking about, like...all these dating apps and this stuff I have never even heard of. They're on their phones half the time." She shrugged. "So...yeah. Mostly I just felt old. And god. I am soooooo tired."

She gave me a wink.

Was she referring to our hot sex last night?

Or something else?

She gave me a kiss and whispered, "That was hot last night."

This instantly made me feel better.

And, it instantly depleted something inside of me. Some little thrill I had been letting hum inside my chest.

Down in my groin.

Of course that's what had happened. Of course she had no connection to these people. Of course she was just happy to be out of the house, and it was paying off for me. Of course we were just in one of those pleasant upswings in our marriage. It happens.

Still.

I watched her stand on her tiptoes to reach a small dish, with prints of "birdies" on it, at Madison's request. The lean line of her calf rippled and lengthened, and I admired the curve of her ass. Her shirt slid up, revealing her still-slender waist. She had worked hard to return her stomach to its pre-child firmness, and with the exception of it being just slightly thicker, she had succeeded. I thought back to myself at that age, the age she was labeling "kid." If a MILF like Laura had come to work at my college bars and restaurants....

Something twisted inside of me again, as I took on that perspective. Maybe it was the first time I had really realized it. Laura, with her brown hair pulled up in a bouncing ponytail, and her small but nicely-shaped breasts moving with her stretching body – Laura was a MILF.

Believe me, I've always known Laura was attractive. Her body wasn't the kind that stopped anyone in their tracks...she didn't have Amazonian hips and breasts or Barbie-doll legs or gym-hardened anything. She just had a cute butt, a pretty set of tits, and a nice, flat stomach that had taken on the very tiniest of roundness after the kids (personally, I liked it). Her face was kind of plain, if she wasn't smiling: small, pretty features that were all pleasant. Brown eyes, a long, slender, well-shaped nose, and lips that were neither large nor small. None of it came together in a way that was particularly stunning, just pleasant.

When Laura smiled, however, it transformed the plainness of her face into radiance, and there was something very sexual, very hot about that. She had a wide, open smile, and she used it generously. It transformed her from “cute” to “dirty-hot.”

Or at least, it used to. I saw her smile like that less and less these days.

But I had always viewed her as “*girl*-hot,” and even though I had of course been there for the whole transformation from girlfriend to wife to mother to mother of three, it was like I just snapped out of a trance.

Laura was *hot*.

And she was a MILF.

And she worked at a restaurant with “kids.”

But they weren't kids. Not really. They were at least 21 if they were serving booze and going out to bars afterward. Young, but young *men*. Lean, full of energy, ready to do stupid things to impress some hot housewife...

My insides twisted again, and I felt my cock getting hard. A little pang of...what? Not exactly guilt, but maybe just...uncomfortable shame?...squeezed me.

Because I knew why my cock was getting hard. It wasn't just because my wife was hot. It wasn't the sight of her pleasing midriff, or the nice view of her round bottom she was giving me a few seconds later as she bent over to swipe some milk off the floor. It wasn't just that I realized I was married to a MILF.

It was also the thought, snaking through my bloodstream, warm like a drink, that other guys were looking at Laura. The idea that those guys were thinking the same thing I was thinking right then. I wasn't getting hard thinking about how I could move close behind her and slide my hand down to cup her round buttock, or how I could find a way to slip my fingers into her jeans and get as far as the hem of her panties before she slapped me away...

It was at that moment that I realized I didn't have a very good grip on things.

That I was starting to lose it.

"So, you're gonna stick it out?" I said, trying to keep my voice as calm as possible.

Laura was facing the window. She looked at her hands. There was a long pause, long enough for me to wonder if she heard me.

"Yeah," she said, just as I was about to ask her again. "Yeah. I think so."

ON THE SIDE

LAURA – 6 WEEKS LATER

There was a turn-around about half a mile from our house. I had never noticed it, for as many times as I drove past it. It gave you just enough space to pull over, and turn around if you needed to, but you had to be careful because it was about ten feet wide and then dropped off sharply into a ditch.

I pulled into it and put the car in park.

As I had for several weeks now, I adjusted the rear-view mirror and looked at myself. “Oh, Laura,” I said to my reflection. “What are you doing?”

Okay, so I wasn't *doing* anything. Not unless there's some law against putting your makeup on on the side of a road.

I dabbed some of the new, orange-red lip gloss I had purchased a few weeks ago on my lips. I knew it was a little bit wrong. I was, after all, hiding something from Conrad. I was leaving the house deliberately without my makeup on, so that he wouldn't do what he did the second week I worked at The Pied Piper, and eye my makeup suspiciously. Ask me about it. Say things like, “Is that a new shade of lipstick? Uh-huh. So you expect to see Mac there, tonight?”

Because he was joking. But the jokes were hitting a little close to home. Mac worked Wednesdays, and Mac was disgusting. I still hadn't told Conrad that he needn't worry about Mac at all. It was Nate. Nate he should be thinking of.

“You just want all those young guys to ogle you.”

I had rolled my eyes when he said things like this. I had denied it.

It didn't feel right, denying it the way I did – not because Conrad had it *exactly* right, but because there was some truth to it.

I felt a drop in my abdomen, like I was going down an elevator shaft. I had, in fact, been having a recurring dream, one I tended to have when I was dishonest with people. In it, I keep having to get on an elevator that works for a while and then continually plummets, for no reason.

Blush. Very, very light blush.

Mascara.

Here I was going a little overboard. It was very black. Very thick. I had to remove it before I went home.

There was deceit here, but not really that much, I told myself.

It was, after all, a requirement of waiting tables – at least if you wanted any tips as opposed to completely wasting your time – to look attractive.

I loosened my ponytail and let my hair fall down. In order to keep it from getting into my face I had a headband. I brushed it until it was glossy, and then I looked at myself in the mirror.

I looked good. I looked younger. Refreshed.

It was almost as if having this illicit, fantastical “thing” - after all, nothing was actually going on between Nate and me, aside from flirting – had rejuvenated me.

I lowered my eyes for second with a little pang of guilt.

Why couldn't Conrad “rejuvenate” me?

I had given that particular thought quite a bit of thought, on the side of the road. Because something about the whole thing felt a little tawdry, a little dirty. Conrad was the one I really loved. Conrad was the one who I wouldn't ever risk or betray. And I wanted Conrad to make me feel so good that I actually *looked* better.

But you can want things to be like that as much as you want.

At the end of the day, though, it was the idea that Nate's eyes were on me that made me elevate my eyes to just-below-whoreish. It was the look in *his* eyes that made me put on red lip gloss. Wear my hair down.

There was no danger of anything else.

And just to make sure, on Thursdays, I put on the worst pair of underwear I could find, and a bra that was barely held together by a safety pin.

I would never be so undignified, I told myself, to have an affair in those things.

As I had done for the past six weeks, I wrapped it all up in my mind very nicely. Thursday nights, flirting with Nate, were my escape.

And hadn't they made things better between me and Conrad? Didn't we have a more exciting sex life now? Things had gotten better than they had been in years, almost back to the same growling, hungry sexual relationship we had had before the kids, when we first got married.

Something wrenched around in my abdomen.

No, more precisely, my fucking groin. It turned and twisted and then it transformed into a dull ache.

Such a cliché, I thought to myself. I was turning into an old, crazy, horny woman.

The last time I had sex with Conrad bubbled up in my mind. I had come home from a night out with Nate, a few of the cooks, and another waitress. I was pretty loaded, and I had been exchanging heated looks all night with Nate. I had danced with him, up close, against his chest, getting pressed into him by passing club goers prying their way through the dance floor. We had kept it lighthearted. He had twirled me around in some ballroom moves to R&B. Clean, silly fun.

Except when someone pressed me into him, and we were stuck together like that for a moment, our lips were close and he was looking at me *that way*, and against my leg I could feel his cock. Hard. Big. Pulsing, practically, with all of that youthful heat.

I shuddered just thinking about it. I could actually feel myself getting wet. In my car, on the side of the road. All over again. Just thinking about Nate.

And when I had gone home, I had found Conrad waiting. Sitting in front of the TV. Pretending not to care where I was, but I know he was thinking about it. I knew he was a little miffed that I went out drinking every night after work, but he couldn't complain because it had, in fact, made everything easier and better around there.

I had enticed him into sex again and again. It was dangerous, ludicrous – how many times can you come home so wet and so horny before your husband starts to suspect something? But I was tipsy, not thinking. And I had wanted to get him in my mouth, feel him all the way down inside my throat. Not a thing I'm usually into, in a sober moment or at the end of the day.

Still, was it all bad? Was it all bad for Conrad? On Thursdays we had wilder, crazier sex than we had in such a long time. Maybe even better than when we first started fucking, if it was possible to believe.

Last week we had ended up on our own couch, curtains open. I had lain my head on the armrest, with Conrad crouched over my head on the armrest. I had opened my mouth and let him pound his cock into my throat, some wild thing I had only seen in a porno. He had come all over my tits,

gushing his warm seed all over me in wet, hot strands. I had rubbed it into my skin while he watched. He told me he almost had a heart attack.

So really...was it all that wrong?

I was thinking about all of this by the side of the road, and then I did something that made me realize I was losing my shit. I looked around. Nothing in any direction, except a farmhouse that seemed to be abandoned about two hundred yards away. Almost no traffic, and anyway, if I just...

I grabbed a map, and placed it in front of me.

And then I slid my fingers into my pants, and found my clit easily, despite the odd angle and the pressure of my jeans. An electric shudder went through me as I grazed the ultra-sensitive core. It was protruding, my clit hard, my pussy welling up with juices. I slid my finger up and down, frustrated that it was too hard to move any faster. My wrist hurt almost instantly, but I wanted to sit upright in case anyone passed by.

My cheeks flushed.

I closed my eyes and thought of Conrad's cock in my mouth. Then Nate's. Then how each of them felt, or would feel, inside me.

I came, gripping the steering wheel, just a few seconds later.

Jesus.

What the fuck was I doing?

Did it matter?

Did it matter where that came from, on my end, if I never crossed any real line?

I looked back at my eyes in the mirror. "Damn it." The mascara had smeared a little, as I had sweat. I touched my hair. It was damp at the temples.

Did I know what the line was, for Conrad?

Was it over the line to masturbate in the car on your way to work, half-thinking of your husband, half-thinking of someone else?

I tapped my teeth and started the car. Directed my attention to the road. These weren't really questions I wanted to be asking myself, or him. Even if it was the right thing to do.

Because I loved the way I felt like a hummingbird was trapped in my chest.

And I didn't want Conrad to tell me that was over the line.

Don't ask, don't tell.

Don't *actually* have sex with young men.

I pulled out onto the road.

SUSPICIOUS THINGS

CONRAD

I was awake, in the dark, watching the occasional headlights splash across the ceiling.

I couldn't sleep anymore, on Thursdays. I couldn't even watch TV.

I lay awake in bed, thinking of Laura.

Where Laura was now.

When Laura would be home.

Who Laura was with.

If Laura had put on her "secret" lip gloss or not.

What dirty thing Laura would do when she got home.

And why.

I looked at the clock. The numbers seemed to be transforming at an alarmingly slow pace.

A beam of light saturated the ceiling, but unlike the passing cars, this one brightened, glared, and turned the ceiling to a liquid gold glow. I squinted, irritated. The car remained where it was, in our driveway, lights blasting into the master bedroom.

I waited. Instead of a car door opening and closing, the low beat of a stereo kicked beneath the hum of the car's fan. The lights dimmed to parking lights.

I stood up.

The thoughts that raced through my mind were the most facile, the most base: we have all been there, driving a girl home, her hand on the door. You say something stupid, ask a question, get her to stay. Her knees turn back in your direction. The fan of the car turns on, your engine is too warm.

But you can't turn the car off here, not yet. And not with this girl. Her left hand is clasped on her knee, and her face is apologetic...she moves the gold band on her finger, gently, with her thumb. Maybe there's some regret there. But she's facing you, and her brown eyes are lit up in the back-splash of light on the garage door...

I stopped short of the window. We had a long driveway, and the master bedroom was large: we never felt the need for any window coverings on the only window that looked out to the front, half-blocked from the street view by the pointed roof of the garage. I knew I wouldn't be able to see into the car, but I leaned forward anyway.

The driver's arm, and part of his torso, was all that was visible. The lanky, muscled arm of a young guy. The hardness of youth underneath the white t-shirt.

His body moved, leaning in the direction of the passenger.

The passenger.

My wife.

His arm remained against the window for a moment. Resting on the ledge. He could just be leaning over to turn down the radio. To get something out of the glove compartment.

But then he leaned further. His arm moved, reached toward the passenger side of the car.

A sensation of cold, and hot, uncoiled violently inside of me.

What was he doing? It was pretty obvious.

Leaning toward Laura. Laura and her pretty ponytail. Laura with her looks that were almost sullen, almost plain, until she smiled. Was she smiling now, inviting him closer? Was he moving his hand toward her, closer to her jeans, closer to the new blouse she had worn? Was she brushing her new, long bangs from her forehead with that gesture of hers, the one from so long ago, half-impatient, fingers turned away from her face, a small flick of her head at the end to help them on their way?

Laura had a look, a look I hadn't seen for such a long time, partly incredulous, partly absorbed. Her smile was not entirely symmetrical; it was one of the things that held her back from the realm of plasticized, model-perfect beauty. This was the kind of look she gave from across the car, when I still didn't know if she would let me come up for the night. The kind of look she gave me when she knew she should do some work, and not be convinced to go to bed early...

Was she giving him this look now, from across the car?

I closed my eyes. A long, deliberate, heavy-lidded blink.

Involuntarily, my hand went to my forehead. I was sweating. My blood had gone colder than it had ever been before, and a chill went up my spine. But at the same time, like I had the fucking flu, I was so hot I was sweating.

She wouldn't. Laura wouldn't do that.

Was I closing my eyes because I wanted to shut the image out of my mind?

I knew I wasn't, really. I knew because I just kept going. Laura's right lip curled slightly more at the corner than her left. Her eyes scrunched into almonds of teasing, beckoning laughter. Her teeth slightly parted, her fingers brushing across her bangs. "I can't," she would be saying, but her mouth was smiling, inviting...and when he reached over to place his hand on her knee, she wouldn't move it. Her hand would drop away from the handle, she would press it into the fabric of his cheap, shitty seat, so that when he climbed in her direction she wouldn't slide away. And he would put his hand on her jaw, and pull her to him.

I knew what it felt like to have that kind of hunger for Laura's smile. It just...had been so long since it was like that.

Why?

The lights brightened, through my eyelids and my fantasy. The car door opened, the music tumbled into the driveway. Laura's laugh broke apart on the cement. The radio was muffled, Laura's voice said something, but not like she was hiding it. And then clearly: "Goodnight."

What kind of "goodnight?" The car door slammed and I stepped backward until I sat down on the edge of the bed. "Goodnight," just friends? "Goodnight," silly boy hitting on a married woman almost twice your age? "Goodnight," I hate to leave you, but...you know. *Him*.

Keys tinkled on Formica, slid with a careless throw. It was late. The clock flickered and it was 1:37.

Not *that* late.

But still. They closed at ten. She could have been cut hours ago. Where had she gone? What had she done? What had she been doing with her lean, athletic busboy, or waiter, or bartender, for the past hours?

I heard a thump downstairs, followed by a crash. And, very unexpectedly, a giggle. Laura's.

Laughing. Laughing about something breaking.

The searing thing inside of me twisted again, flared right up to my temples. My face felt hot.

Without really knowing what I was doing, I stood up and walked purposefully downstairs.

The lights were off. The kind of funny thing a drunk would do, thinking that leaving lights off after sitting parked in the driveway with headlights blasting into everyone's room would make a difference.

I flicked the kitchen light.

Laura, whose presence in the kitchen was announced by the scraping of glass and the sloppy, rustling movements of her clothing and her shoes, popped up from behind the counter.

She was smiling. Radiant. Her cheeks were flushed with alcoholic happiness. She covered her mouth and let out a wet, silly laugh. "Oh," she sort of gurgled. "Sorry. Sorry, honey."

That was it. She dropped back down, still smiling, and started to clean up the glass.

I narrowed my eyes.

In the back of my mind, it was burning me up that she was...that she was....that she was what?

More like her old self, Conrad?

Not as sorry as she should be for having a fun night?

Not as angry as she usually was when something got broken?

Drunk?

Probably back from making out with her boy-toy?

Another quiver of delicious and horrible pain.

"You're home late," I said, moving around so I could see her on the floor.

She tossed her hair back – it was not in a ponytail now at all, I noticed, but down. Well-brushed, *arranged*. I didn't understand what women did with their hair, but whatever she had done, it was straight, shiny, and looked as though she had made an effort with it. It looked glamorous.

Her lips were shiny with some kind of candy-pink lip gloss. Her eyes were also darker than usual. Sexily darker...her lashes were blackened by mascara, I realized.

It was too young for her, very nearly to the point of being silly. Almost, but not quite.

She had on a cream shirt, and a beige jacket. New.

What was I accusing her of, in my mind? What, exactly? So she had a new shirt on. So she looked hot. So she...

The scene from the car invaded my thoughts.

No, something was definitely up.

But she was oblivious to me, oblivious to my irritation. Her eyes were glassy. As soon as I noticed this, she brought her hand to her mouth and snorted again. She was laughing at nothing, giddy, being a silly drunk. The scent of tobacco wafted toward me.

“Have you been smoking?” I said. My voice was much more accusatory than I mean for it to be.

She was still covering her mouth, as if she had just heard the greatest joke ever. She nodded, like she couldn't affirm with words or she would lose it completely.

My chest burned.

“God, I'm sorry,” she said, standing up. “I really got...I really had way more than I meant to, and then this crazy man....you should have seen this guy, he's the one who's always down at Mercer's? He won the lottery or something and he...he was singing karaoke all night and buying everyone...he did a version....he did a version of....” she was waving her hands at the air and her eyes were twinkling. I softened a little. I hadn't seen her this happy, this buoyantly carefree in such a long time. “Of Billy Jean that was...I don't know what it was, it was like...genius, but also really...really....” she placed a finger under her nose, but too late, the laugh escaped her and sprayed a little on my arm. She shook her head violently, and when she looked at me, her eyes were wet with laughing tears. “I can't explain it,” she squeaked. “It was just so funny.”

I was torn. The image of the car was floating around in my head, mixing with what I was seeing right before my eyes, offering alternative explanations, making me feel foolish. Probably they had just been reliving the moment, maybe her waiter/bartender had been doing an imitation of this guy.

I was relieved.

I was disappointed.

I watched her in disbelief.

“Anyway,” she said, and she placed her forearms on my shoulders, tossing her hair again and pulling me toward her. “I know I'm being obnoxious. I'm sorry.” Her eyes were twinkling with mischief. I could smell hard alcohol on her. “How can I make it up to you?”

Her voice went from very silly to very low, very sexy, in a heartbeat. It was only at that moment that I realized I had an erection – I had one all along – and she could feel it against her leg.

Her lips grew closer to mine.

Oh, the old days. They were stained on her lips as vodka, cigarettes, and some kind of cheap lip gloss with a smell that was almost dangerously expired. The days when we had places to drive, and we laughed in the car together, and she gave me the kind of crooked smile she was giving me now.

The kind she had given to her boy in the car, I thought.

But the thought, rather than making me sullen, rather than making me angry, only surged inside of me.

But Laura was the one, very suspiciously, I might add – and this only fueled my desire even more – who was at work on my boxers. Working her fingers between the fabric and my skin. Her smooth knuckles caressed my lower pelvis, her fingernails moved like a breath over my pubic hairs, disturbing them only lightly, each one sending a sweet jolt through me. I looked down to see her hands dipping into my underwear, and up to see the smile on her face.

Why was Laura so suddenly frisky, in this particular way?

Her fingers were slightly cool when they closed around my cock. Her eyes glimmered when she found me, already hard, and she squeezed my cock with an excited, inviting, almost needy clasp, in both of her hands. Her fingernails swept over my balls, raising hairs the same she had done as she had moved her hands down, just moments before.

I used one hand to grasp the back of my shirt, and pull it over my head. The move was clumsy, but she didn't seem to care, and she slid my boxers away as I did it, so that they fell down around my ankles. She stepped back, but kept one hand making smooth circles over the tip of my shaft, so that I could pull my shirt from my arms.

When my clothing fell away, I had a brief image of her driver of the night, and his younger frame, his taut torso and muscled arms. I hadn't stood naked in front of Laura like this for a long time, and as she ran her eyes over my body I wondered if she was using her imagination to brush away the inevitable changes of time. I was in good shape, but I was not the same man she had met at twenty-two. I was not the same guy as her youthful ride home. I wondered if she was seeing me but imagining him, and the idea licked at me from the inside, almost sweetly.

It was not entirely unpleasant, the thrill it was giving me to think of her driver leaning over to whisper to her, to touch her, to touch her

inappropriately...

The idea sort of percolated up inside of me: maybe this was why Laura was so horny right now. Wasn't it strange, in every way, that she was making such an aggressive move? Right after a long shift? This was very unlike Laura, and when I had that thought, it started the fluttering in my chest anew.

Maybe she was turned on because she had gone just a little too far with her buddy in the car.

Maybe she was turned on because she hadn't, but she wanted to.

She pulled me down the hall to the guest bedroom.

I pushed her onto the bed. I felt a new, animal instinct surging up inside of me. I had a desperate need to pull her jeans off, to place my hand on her panties, to slide my finger inside of her and see how wet she was.

And I knew what I wanted to find. I wanted to find some evidence that she was up to something. That she was more turned on than she could possibly have been by this brief interlude with me.

I jerked her pants off after unbuttoning them, and they were so tight they almost pulled her with them, off of the bed. She kicked at me playfully and said, much too loudly, "Conrad!"

Seductively.

She kicked herself back up and onto the bed, and looked at me half-imploringly and half-confused.

I climbed on top of her, and reached with no hesitation for her panties. I cupped her mound in my hand, and the feel of the fabric, warm and undeniably moist against my palm, sent a shudder of incredible pleasure through me.

"You're very turned on," I half-whispered, almost accusingly.

Laura brought a finger to her mouth and bit it, playfully mimicking a "sex kitten" pose. She would never actually act like that, she thought it was silly, but she enjoyed making fun of it and for me, the effect was essentially the same.

Curious, though. Curious that she had nothing else to say.

A sense of urgency overtook me suddenly. A desire to feel more than just her being "very turned on," through her panties. I wanted to feel inside of her, get my fingers slick with her juices. Maybe taste her, as if I would be able to find something in the way she smelled. Maybe she would be too wet, too wet for it not be cum. Maybe she would stop me, tell me I couldn't

go any further, try to get me to stop because if I came too close to her cunt I would find some other scent there...

My thoughts went on and on like this, and I didn't do much to stop myself, even though the same thoughts were sending waves of anxiety and then pleasure, heat and then painful cold, despair and elation through me. What the hell was I doing? What the hell was I accusing my wife of?

I jerked her panties away, without pulling them down, and I heard the fabric rip.

Laura rose beneath me, to try and crane her neck down at her underwear. "Shit, Connie," she said, but her outcry ended in a laugh and she tossed her head back on the bed. "Grrrrr," she said, making a tiger growl that was not in any way intended to be sexy, only funny.

My heart tripped inside my chest. She was just being silly. I caught the scent of whiskey on her breath again and realized that she was just very, very drunk -

But my fingers dipped inside of her, and the silky oils of her wetness coated my fingers. She was so wet there was almost no friction as the superheated flesh of her pussy closed around my fingers. Two fingers, and they slid in as though into a pail of melting butter. My mind started up again, thinking things, believing things, convincing myself of things. Was she *looser*? More pliant? Stretched out?

You're imagining things.

Laura's eyes half closed and her breath rattled in her throat like a growl. The effect was intoxicating, when stirred together with thoughts of her fantastical – or were they? - transgressions, so I pushed further, harder, clawing forward to press her clit from the inside against my thumb on the outside of her pussy.

She yelped a little, and pleased, sexy yelp. She wanted more.

I rubbed again, and she purred.

I could make her come like this, she was so close.

But my hopeful paranoia, this strange thing that was taking me over, made me pull my hand from inside of her. Her eyes fluttered open, suddenly sobered, disappointed.

I moved down, down her body, taking the distended panties with me. I stared at her cunt as I did. It was dim in the room, but here was enough light from the outside porch light that I could see that she had shaved

herself into a very tidy triangle. My mind spun. She wasn't a full-bush, let-it-get-out of control type, but wasn't this a little...too trim?

You're really, really imagining things now. Starting to lose it. Falling apart.

I hesitated, in this weird reverie. I had been planning to go for her, to graze my mouth from her calf to her inner thigh, to the bone that joined her leg and hip, to the line of neatly trimmed hair, where I would be able to smell her tangy scent. And anything else that might be there..

But my hesitation cost me, and Laura giggled, and slid forward with her panties, and then she was on the floor in front of me.

She was on her knees.

I opened my mouth and sucked in my breath, as much for my surprise about how the situation I had been unfolding in my mind had been snatched away from me. And by Laura, once again, diverting to sucking my cock.

Which, don't get me wrong...but...

She waved a finger at me, smiling, telling me not to say anything stupid. She was sort of drunkenly giggling, some mischievous thought swirling in her own head.

By then she also had my cock in her hand, and she was guiding it to her mouth.

With almost no hesitation whatsoever, she opened her mouth and took me inside of her.

What should I call the feeling that had gone through me when she had thwarted my plans to lick her and taste her sweet cunt? To maybe find that she was far too wet, that her pussy was full of her own cum, or that – and the thought tantalized me as much as it terrified me – it was full of a saltier, bleachier kind of cum? Disappointment isn't exactly the right word, because it was disappointment and relief. Whatever it was, it was washed away by the feel of her hot mouth on my cock.

This felt so good.

Laura had been much wilder than I had expected, when I finally got her into bed. But lately she had just been going...over the top. Over the top for where we were in our marriage, so many years in. Over-the-top for thirty-eight.

And where was it coming from?

I looked down to see her lips encircling me, moving down the length of my cock, coming closer and closer to the base. The heat and the wetness

of her mouth was enveloping me. Not just my cock, but all of me.

I gasped.

And then my mind, my mind that was getting so out of control, slipped away again.

To another crazed thought. She was probably only doing this because she had wanted to stop me from finding her full of...

Stop it.

But the thought stayed in my head. And I let it. I let it stay there and sink into the whole moment. I let it stay there as I watched Laura's fingers close around the base of my cock and her head begin to bob over the end half of my cock, her tongue working her magical swirls around my shaft as she moved up and down it, her hand pumping in perfect rhythm with the movement of her head.

I tried to pull away from her at one point, so obsessive became my desire to feel inside her cunt, even if it was with my cock.

But Laura released my shaft, and reached behind me to grasp my ass, and then she pulled me to her face. My cock impaled her, and I felt the tip of me against the back of her throat. A small spasm as she gagged slightly.

I could feel myself going over the edge. My paranoid thoughts and my imaginings and real images from the last hour collided in my mind. I gave in, I let her press me closer and closer, and I let myself disappear inside her hot mouth.

I pushed her hair away and whispered her name when I felt myself coming – Laura wasn't big on swallowing, she liked to give very intense descriptions of the rancid qualities of cum – but she resisted, and dug her nails into the flesh of my ass.

I arched backward, and looked up at the ceiling. I groaned, trying not to yell too loudly, as my cum boiled up inside of me, filled my cock, filled her mouth. I felt the muscles of her throat constricting around my cock, and it sent an electric ripple through me, riding on the ending wave of my orgasm. I couldn't help it. I yelled.

Laura fell backward onto her heels, releasing me. She was laughing, holding one hand up to her mouth to wipe away the excess cum she couldn't swallow, and the other with a finger extended to tell me to be quiet. But her own laughter escaped her, and she collapsed on the floor, trying to smother the noise.

And I stood there, in disbelief.

It was a strange feeling, seeing Laura like that. A younger version of Laura, more like the Laura I had married. Silly, a little too tipsy. Laughing, doing naughty things and not worrying very much about the consequences.

And then a Laura I had never met before. Even at her drunkest and therefore dirtiest, when we first started dating and sleeping together, Laura had never grabbed my ass and shoved me into her throat, or let me burst inside her mouth.

A strange brew was inside of me. There was attraction, almost relief, that my plan was working on Laura, that she was relaxing and having fun one night a week, and, let's be honest, that said relaxation and fun had led her to feel more like having sex.

And then there was suspicion. Confusion. Why was Laura so unlike herself? I couldn't help but think her "friend" from the restaurant had something to do with it.

I couldn't help but think that Laura had stopped me from going down on her because she hid a very naughty secret between her legs.

Laura sat up. She was waving at the air. "I'm sorry," she said. "I don't even know why I'm laughing so hard."

Was Laura just in a carefree, tipsy mood, and laughing at something only because it was late at night and a sense of decorum demanded that she be quiet? She was always losing her shit during serious and solemn moments. She had a peculiar quirk, of finding especially serious moments to induce laughter. She had to leave a funeral once because she couldn't hold it in. She laughed all the time at church services and weddings. Sometimes even a serious movie could set her off. She claimed to have actually peed her pants when we saw *Pulp Fiction*, not because it was particularly serious but because the audience we saw it with was plainly horrified and didn't get the black humor, which had sent her into a fit of uncontrollable laughter.

But this was different, wasn't it? It wasn't a really solemn occasion.

Was she laughing because she held some private thought, or private joke, inside of her?

I picked at the painful wound inside of me.

Maybe she was laughing at me.

She looked up at me, wiping her eye. Her face fell when she saw my expression. I must have looked very glum, or very pensive. Either way I was serious.

“Hey,” she said. “What's with you?”

She stood up. She put her arms on my shoulders. She tossed her hair behind her. “I've got a joke. Ready? I heard it tonight. It can't possibly not cheer you up. You ready?”

I nodded. Why was she bothering me so much, in this happy mood?

“A horse walks into a bar,” she said, and the punchline got ahead of her and made her lip quiver.

She waited for me to say, “Yeah?”

Was it because I felt like I was losing control of her? What the hell was wrong with me?

I knew the joke. I felt certain I had told it to her a long time ago, though maybe I hadn't.

Or maybe she'd forgotten.

“The bartender says, 'why the long face?’”

Her mouth broke into an irresistible smile, and she looked up at the ceiling. “Ahhhhhh, Connie, please, it's a good joke.”

I smiled for her. “It's great.”

Normally, she would have known something was wrong. She would have had to sit there and talk to me about it, dissect it, make me tell her. She always spotted my fake smiles from miles away.

Tonight though, she kissed me on the cheek. “I have to go shower,” she said. And she pattered away to the bathroom. The downstairs bathroom again.

I sat on the bed. I lay down on the bed and I looked at the ceiling.

There were plenty of things to think about at that moment. Like the fact that Laura had been in such a hurry to take a shower. The white shirt in the car that drove her home. Why she was home so late. Where she had been and what she had done. Why she had such crazy sex.

Laura often says that I'm a surprisingly deep man. She doesn't mean that it's surprising, like I'm too dull to be deep.

She means it like, some of the shit lurking around in my mind surprises her.

Sometimes I even surprise myself.

Because what I thought about, sitting there on the bed staring at the ceiling, was not Laura at all.

Not in any kind of direct way, anyway.

What I thought about was my college buddy Troy.

And his girlfriend from back in the day.

Eliza.

And how I had submerged the fantasy of being not myself in that story, but Troy. Feeling the serrated edges of pleasure and pain slicing through me while I watched my girlfriend – or even more intensely, my wife – with another man's cock in her mouth, pleasing me by pleasing him, pleasing me by torturing me.

And as I sat there thinking about it, despite the odds, my cock got hard again.

PROBLEMS

LAURA

Thoughts are just thoughts.

And I was right. That's all they were. At the time.

They were burning through me, though. Making me crazy.

And thoughts are thoughts, but I was *doing things*, wasn't I?

I knew Conrad was not some kind of idiot. I knew he was suspicious of things. I could tell by his frowning smile. I could tell by his clouded eyes. By his distance sometimes, at night. By the way I caught him staring at me. Looking for details.

Sometimes this rattled me, because I knew I was up to things that were not over the line, but pretty close to it.

And then sometimes I just got angry.

After all, I hadn't *done anything*.

And I was entitled to my own thoughts.

And anyway, hadn't all of this made our sex life better?

I knew Conrad got into the porn at night. All men did. And what's more, I didn't care. After all, we'd been married for eight years, we had two kids, we were busy people and it was just hard to find time or passion. Whatever worked for him.

But if Conrad had his porn, then it was only fair that I had my own thoughts.

At night, in bed, as I drifted off to sleep.

But your thoughts, Laura, have real people in them.

That was also true.

But not real *scenarios*.

(I mean, also, to be fair, porn has real people in it.)

Not people he actually knows.

That was also true.

I wasn't going to feel guilty about a little harmless fantasizing.

About a twenty-three year old.

Legal. Perfectly legal. And anyway, it was just fantasy.

It was all just fantasy.

Anyway, I didn't really get into some kind of crazy detail with my fantasies. They were sweet, flirtatious, almost romantic. Unrequited. Maybe a make-out session or two.

I was always shaking my head and saying, *no, I can't, I'm married.*

And then...

Okay, maybe it didn't always end there.

Maybe Nate kept burning into me with his ice-blue eyes, and then he just wasn't able to hold himself back, and he kicked the freezer door shut and pushed me up against the wall. Maybe it was ice-cold against my back and searingly hot against my abdomen and chest, and he pushed my arms up above my head and held my wrists there.

Maybe he didn't hold my wrists at all, but held my head still with his fingers on the back of my neck and his thumb stroking the soft dent of my throat. Holding me still with his eyes, his breath crystallizing in the air, our lips dangerously close.

I can't, I might say, feebly, one more time.

But Nate's hands are already sliding underneath my shirt. His mouth is already on my lips. We're tearing our clothes off and we can't feel the chilled air at all...

It's not so much about sex with these fantasies anyway.

It's the cold twist in my stomach. The longing. The aching sweetness of thinking about getting something you want, but never getting it.

Also, it's just fun. Fun to flirt, when it's all just game.

Nate was a game, definitely. And Nate was young Everything was still a game to him. My stomach twisted, and my heart tapped at my chest.

I felt guilty, suddenly, thinking what I was thinking. Standing over the sink washing dishes.

And when I turned around, I could see Conrad there, looking at me. Like he knew something.

This look of his.

Part hungry. Part angry. Part hurt.

Why didn't he just say what was on his mind?

"What?" I snapped. My voice was angrier than I meant it to be.

"Is that how you're going to stack those dishes?" he said, averting his eyes to the dishwasher.

"Yes," I said. I dropped another one in, without even lining it up. "It is, as a matter of fact. I'm just going to drop all the dishes in here like this

and hope for the best.” My voice was really bitchy, I knew it.

Conrad shook his head and pressed his lips together.

I felt something inside of me boil over the top. I hated his “cool head act” more than anything.

“You have something to say about it?” I was practically shrieking.

We'd been having a lot of these kinds of arguments lately.

I knew I wasn't talking about the dishwasher.

Conrad adopted his expressionless face and set his glass on the counter. He held up his hands, as if to say “there's nothing I can do with this irrational woman” and turned to leave the room.

“If you have something to say, Conrad, then just say it.” I was seething. I slammed the dishwasher closed and heard a glass break inside. Ignoring it, I turned it on. The glass pieces clattered around.

Real mature.

Oh well. Too late to take it back.

I watched him leave the room.

I was talking about something else, and not the dishwasher.

Surely he knew that.

I turned back to face the window and jerked the dishwasher lock open.

There was a hard truth to things, and that was that something was off between us.

Sex was better, sure.

But we were each in our own little worlds, with our own little secrets.

I knew mine.

Did he know it, too? Or did he only think he knew some awful truth that wasn't right?

And how in the world do you bring all of this up?

My reflection glared at me in the window.

CONFRONTATION

CONRAD

We were on our backs, looking at the ceiling. Laura had come to bed half an hour later than me and just lay down.

There was something going wrong between us. I'd felt it for a while.

Sex was amazing, since The Pied Piper.

Amazing.

But something wasn't adding up the rest of the time. Like this dishwasher bullshit.

I mean, I knew what it was *for me*. I knew that I was losing control of my fantasies, and that they were bleeding into real life, and I could no longer tell where one began and the other ended. I knew they twisted in my gut, like an orgasm and a knife wound, and I didn't know what I wanted.

I just didn't know what was up with Laura.

I put my fist on my forehead, and I sighed.

To my surprise, Laura said, "I know."

It felt like the first honest exchange between us in a long time. Not that I thought either one of us was telling lies, specifically. But I felt sure that we were both holding things back.

But this, even without it being much of an exchange, seemed so clear to me. The way she said it. She knew it, too.

I had once been to therapy, court-ordered, for anger management. A long story, more about booze and being a bartender and having shitty friends than anything else. Surprisingly, it had turned out to be really helpful. I remember the guy, Dr. Malthus or some crazy name like that, telling me to keep things from getting bottled up by just saying them.

Confrontation, he had assured me, in his cultured Indian accent, *is much smaller thing when we confront what it small, and not anything which has grown.*

I loved that guy.

I turned on my side. "Something's up between us."

Laura already knew this so she just moved her head a little, a tiny nod.

“I want to talk to you about it. I don't know what to say. I...it's hard. It's weird. It's about sex. I don't want this conversation to turn into some kind of thing where we don't say what we mean, though, so I'm just going to say it. I'm...I feel like you have something going on behind my back. Somebody at the restaurant.”

Laura closed her eyes.

She shook her head.

“It's not that. It's not...” she seemed to suddenly think better of what she was going to say. “Okay. Okay, listen, can we have a conversation where we say, like, I don't know...we're going to tell the truth about everything and no one is going to get mad about anything?”

I felt something claw at me inside my chest. So it was true. Was she going to confess to me that she was having an affair?

And what was I going to do if she did?

As though she was reading my thoughts, she turned her head to me quickly. “I haven't *done* anything,” she said. “I just...I don't have anyone else to talk to about this.” She looked back at the ceiling. “And it's like...you already know. Obviously you know something is *up*. And you watch all this porn...that I...okay, so, can we? Can we have that conversation?”

She looked back at me.

A really strange mix of feelings was churning inside of me. I was actually feeling a little ill from it. Relief. Excitement. Fear. Jealousy, Anger. Lust. More excitement.

My heart was pounding.

“That conversation...” I said. My shaky voice trailed off. I was lost.

“Where we don't get mad. Let's just lay it all on the table,” Laura snapped. She was so impatient.

“Okay.”

“Okay.”

She pulled the covers up to her chest tighter and opened her eyes wide. Her mouth turned into a little smile. “Oh god. This is so stupid now that I'm talking about it. Okay, here it is. So yeah, there are some people at work, who I just...I really like flirting with. It's...I wouldn't do anything real with them, but I'll just be honest I really have fun flirting with them. And...”

My breath was caught in my chest, burning. “And?”

She shot me a look.

"I like, you know..." She looked back at the ceiling. Her face was now twisted into incredulity, and most of it was directed at herself. She pulled the covers over her head and said through them, blurting it out in rapid-fire:

"I like fantasizing about them and having an affair but I would never really do it and I don't really feel bad for thinking it."

Her breath inflated the sheet above her mouth, and then it fell.

"And I saw your porn," she added, and I could tell she was smiling.

Which porn, I wondered. Then I realized it didn't matter. I had a golden opportunity here, and I was more than a little turned on by what was being offered to me.

No, it wouldn't work, would it?

I didn't really want it, did I?

Did I really want to share this with her?

I watched her breath inflate and deflate the tent of sheet above her lips.

"Say something!" she said, flailing her arms above her head but not removing the sheet. "Say something or I'll feel like an ass!"

The sweet ache turned cruelly in my chest.

"Okay. Uh...okay. Listen, this is going to sound weird. I..."

Oh my god, I can't even believe I'm saying this.

Dr. Malthus's wizened face beamed at me and his soft, Indian voice beckoned me. "*Say whud you really feel, whad you are telling yourself, did is whud you should tell oder people.*"

"I can't believe I am even saying this."

Laura swept the sheet from her face and looked at the ceiling.

"Just do it," she whispered playfully. "I did it. Don't be a pussy."

"Okay fine. I have this fantasy about you sleeping with other men. So I sort of knew that you were...or I suspected it, but I don't...it's not all that...*unappealing to me.*"

Laura turned her head slightly and rolled her eyes up to look at me with disbelief. Her mouth hung open.

"Wait, so you...like that idea would...get you off or something?"

She turned back to the ceiling.

"So I have been feeling guilty," she said. "About nothing?"

"But you haven't actually..."

“No, I just said that.” Laura's patience snapped easily. She shook her head. “Oh my god.”

Silence.

“But you wouldn't actually want me to...go through with it or anything? It's just a fantasy?” she said.

I couldn't read into her tone.

There were two ways to go here. One was to say, “yeah, sure, no – it was just about the fantasy.”

I liked that version for her, and I liked it for myself. It would keep everything from getting difficult. It wasn't the truth, but it was a safe bet.

After all, Laura was only talking about a fantasy. She had made that clear.

Or, I could tell the truth. I could tell her I wanted to talk about taking it seriously.

For the first time, I felt myself really admit to myself that this was more than just an idle thought. That what I had enjoyed the most about Laura coming home late, about not knowing what Laura was doing, was that I wanted it to be more than a fantasy.

“No,” I found myself saying.

“No, it's not a fantasy? Or no, you don't actually want me to sleep with other people?”

“Oh god,” I said, collapsing on the bed again. “Can it be both?”

Another silence.

Laura's hand flew up to her nose. “I'm going to laugh now,” she said. “It's just so...tense.” She was giggling already. “I'm sorry, it's not about you, I just...” she was cracking up.

I rolled over, on top of her.

I held her arms down and she tossed her head back and forth. “No, no don't, I have to be able to stop myself from snorting. Oh my god, Conrad!” Her chest was shaking underneath me. I smiled. Her maniacal laughing was infectious.

After all, was anything really that serious, if you thought about it.

We touched our foreheads, and she stopped laughing for a second.

“So which is it?” she said.

“Which do *you* want it to be?”

She rolled her eyes. “I'll use your answer, then. Both?”

I smiled.

“So we're on the same page, then.”

Then I decided to go for it.

“Until we're decided, you tell me. Which one is it?”

Laura was very quiet. Then she looked at me, and her expression was very earnest.

“Serious, now. Is this a serious conversation?” Her voice was soft but it had taken on a tone she rarely used. She had used about deciding to have kids, she had used it for talking about getting married. This was her most real voice, the one she used to talk about things that were really important to her.

“Yes,” I said, trying to match her tone.

“Would you actually want me to go through with it?”

I pressed my lips together.

“I think I do.” My voice was a whisper.

She looked back up at the ceiling. She sighed. “I don't know, Conrad. It might be...it might be too much. You know?”

I remained silent.

She looked back at me, dropping her hand in her own, private frustration. “Wouldn't you get jealous?”

“That's kind of what...I know this is weird, but it's what it's about.”

A long silence as she turned back to the ceiling and watched it, almost like it was speaking to her.

“Let's...try just like...flirting or something, for now.”

“That's fine with me,” I agreed, almost too quickly. I would agree to whatever part of things I could get.

She smiled at my eagerness.

“Okay. So. Do you...I don't know, like you want to actually watch?”

“The flirting?”

She nodded.

“Yes,” I said. I wanted to watch anything, I was starting to realize. But we were moving toward “anything,” and I would take whatever I could get. “Or you could just...tell me about him, for now. What you like about him.” I turned on my side and let my fingers trail up her thigh beneath the covers.

She turned her head quickly back to me.

I expected her to say, “it's too weird!”

Did I want her to say that?

No, the fantasy was that she would do exactly what she did, but even as she did it, an unexpected jolt of pain shook through me.

"His name is Nate," she said.

"Is he hot?"

She bit her lip. She was looking at me strangely now.

"He's got a really great, athletic body." Her expression was probing now. She was enjoying something. My hand moved up to her panties, and I stroked the material, feeling the contour of her outer labia, and the center where her large clit had turned to a hard button and almost, almost protruded from between them. She moved her legs apart slightly, sending another shiver of pain and pleasure through me. "I've felt it before, against my back."

"Why was he...why was he against your back?" I could barely speak. My fingers detected a dampness in her panties, and I was thinking ahead to how I would slide them into her buttery flesh and find her wet, wetter than ever, for her "Nate." Only from talking about him.

"It was nothing scandalous," she said. "He just bumped into me while I was ringing something up...and then he...lingered."

She gasped as I slid a finger underneath her panties and along the hard ridge of her clit. Her juices had overflowed and the entire valley of her gash was soaked.

I was emboldened by her arousal. "But you wanted him to do something more than linger, didn't you?"

Her eyes dilated and she smiled. "I could feel his cock against my ass," she said. "I knew he wanted to do more."

"Was it big?"

"It felt big. I would need to get my hand in there and warp my fingers around it to really know."

"And you thought about that didn't you?"

I was working her panties away from her cunt, with her help. She was squirming to get them down her hips.

"Tell me," I said. I slipped a finger into her, and she smiled. "I think his cock is probably really thick. It felt thick," she said.

I put another finger inside of her, and began to finger-fuck her.

"Really thick," she repeated. "I might not be able to handle it."

Jesus, I wondered if she had any idea what she was doing. Or how she knew what to say right now. Her eyes were strange. Greedy. She was

enjoying herself.

I put a third finger inside of her. Now I could feel the pressure of her flesh straining with the thickness of my three fingers.

She closed her eyes, and a light whimper of discomfort came from her mouth.

“I think maybe, maybe he's even thicker than that.”

“Oh yeah?” I said. I added a fourth finger, and slowly entered her, my fingers rounded together. She gasped, and I savored her slight pain as I went deeper, inch by inch.

“Would he have to get inside of you slowly, like this?”

She bit her lip, and closed her eyes. In answer, she nodded.

“Tell me,” I breathed.

“He'd have to push into me, nice and slow, just like that. Just the first time. Just to stretch me out.”

A brief thought fluttered around in the back of my mind and gave me a little kick in the chest. I had no idea, no idea at all, how it was that Laura knew just what to say to get the blood thundering to my cock. But by now I was so hard I felt dizzy.

“But you would like it? Once he got inside of you and you felt...”

“All filled up.”

“Would you suck his cock first?”

Laura's eyes were glittering with a sexual, perverse energy now. Mischief. She shook her head. “No. No I'd suck his cock afterward, so I could taste my own pussy. And then I would let him come all over my face.”

I pushed inside of her and a light yelp came from her throat. I pushed my boxers down to release my cock. I could feel the tip of it was wet with precum. I pulled my hand from Laura's cunt, and rolled on top of her. With my right hand I found her soaked pussy, and I thrust inside of her, barely able to restrain myself from exploding inside of her right at that moment.

But I wanted one more thing.

I brought my hand to her lips, and I rubbed my fingertips over her lips lightly. Recognition – of what I wanted – flickered in her eyes.

“Show me,” I said.

She needed no clarification. She opened her mouth and used her tongue to lick the side of my pinky, lapping up her own juices that were stinging my nostrils. Then the side of my pointer finger.

And then, she opened wide, and used a free hand to push all four of my fingers into her mouth.

I was moving inside of her, and I could feel her grinding against me. As her mouth spread around my fingers, and I felt myself pushing down into her throat, gagging her and forcing her to slurp up all of her wet desire (for another man), I felt myself going over the edge. Laura. moaned into my hand, and her pussy started to clench me tightly. Her eyes were on mine.

I squeezed her jaw between my fingers and thumb as I pounded my cum inside of her. I felt her sloshing pussy tighten and then expand, wetter than before, overflowing with my cum and her own now.

When we finished panting out our orgasms, the mood became suddenly tender. I melted off of her, and she kissed my fingertips as I fell next to her.

She turned to look at me. “Conrad,” she said. “No matter what, I love you.”

Her voice emphasized *you*.

“I love you, too.”

There was something about it, at that moment, that seemed truer than it had in a long time. Maybe because it was standing out there in all that honesty, or because the conversation had been so raw. We said “I love you” all the time, but this was the first time, in a long time, we had said it as more than just a catch-phrase.

I closed my eyes, surprisingly, and fell into the best sleep I had for a long time.

RELIEF

LAURA

A strange thing had happened to me, since that night with Conrad. Well, for one thing, he had fucked me in a way he hadn't for a *long* time. Like a man who wanted to possess me.

I thought long and hard about it that night. Why I liked it so much. There had been a period of time when I did, at the beginning of our relationship. And then oddly, a period of time when that kind of sex just pissed me off a little. I mean Jesus, we were parents now. Almost forty. No one possessed anyone.

It felt strange to be back where I had been, in my late twenties. Wanting Conrad to think about me that way. His jealousy was so evident inside of him. Inside his veins like a hot liquid, making him say and do things I hadn't seen him do or say for a long time. Making him look at me in a way that was...

What was it?

I hated to admit it, but more *animal*.

God. So much for fucking feminism.

So there was that. I liked the new, hungry Conrad. The Conrad who had something to burn at him. His jealousy seeped through his skin right into me and made me heat up like I hadn't in a long time.

Before we talked about it, I had felt like I was playing a very dangerous game. I knew when I stayed out late he was getting jealous. I knew he was thinking about what I was doing, and I knew he saw in my eyes that I had someone else on my mind.

And it was true. I did. I thought about Nate and I thought about him in sexual ways.

And all the time, I told myself I was really trying to hide that fact from Conrad.

After we talked about though, after he fucked my brains out like that, I realized that I had been lying to myself. I hadn't been hiding it all.

I mean, we had been married for so long now, We *knew* each other. Conrad knew something was on my mind, and he knew it had to do with sex, and he was no idiot.

And I had *liked it*.

I had liked seeing it inside of him. Finally. Interest, really deep interest.

But the thoughts that something very, very wrong was happening had been there with me, too.

So now, it felt good to have cleared the air. To have admitted to each other what we were really thinking.

And once that had happened, I started thinking about Nate differently.

Not as some secret affair I could have – and truth be told, I was never really thinking of him like that, anyway. I had always imagined our secret affair, if I allowed myself a realistic fantasy, to be something I just nearly avoided. We would get close but it wouldn't happen. I was high on the angst, the tension – not the actual thing.

But now, now I was getting off on a different kind of tension. Conrad's jealousy, Conrad's thoughts. The idea of actually going through with it – of actually having sex with Nate. But not like before, where it would be because we just couldn't hold ourselves (me and Nate) back from our mutual attraction. Now it was having sex with Nate for Conrad, so Conrad could watch it, so Conrad could get his fantasies indulged.

And something about that idea was - and this was really surprising because I'd never once thought about something like that before – incredibly erotic.

I had told Conrad, more or less, that I didn't want to go all the way. That was mostly true when I said it, and mostly because I wasn't sure it was the right thing to do. Who can really know about another person? What they're really thinking, whether they really have the feelings they say they have? You throw another person in there and it gets messy.

It was better just to leave it, the way I had intended to leave it when it was just Nate and me, as a fantasy. A thing I got close to, flirted with, and then avoided.

That was best for everyone involved.

A quiet voice in my head always stirred when I had these thoughts.

For now, it whispered.

ONLY ONE WAY TO FIND OUT

CONRAD

It was a cold night. My hands were stinging from the biting wind. I had found a pack of cigarettes in Laura's pocket – not a brand she would buy, if she ever bought them, and so I was guessing they were someone else's. I had balked a little when I pulled into the Pied Piper parking lot.

This had been Laura's idea.

“You should come by,” she had said, mischievously. “Come by and see things in action. Would you like that?” She had been holding my cock in her hand, her body lying on top of mine. Of course I had liked the idea at the time. Of course it had seemed like the most incredible turn-on *at the time*.

But now, I wondered if it wasn't a bad idea. It could be going over some line, just a little too far. And then, what if I liked it?

What if I wanted more?

What if Laura liked it?

What if Laura wanted more?

What if we didn't feel the same way?

The cigarette burned my throat. God. So bad.

I looked back at the car.

I had already paid for a baby-sitter.

The inside of the bar was neon-warm and the music, muffled through the walls of the building, didn't seem all that bad.

I caught a glimpse of Laura through the window. At first I didn't realize it was her. She looked so young. Her hair was in a ponytail and it bounced as she leaned against an empty chair with her knee on it. She twirled a pen in her hand. She smiled, and tucked the pen behind her ear. Nodded enthusiastically. Laughed again, and was off, swinging her hips.

I tossed the cigarette, half-finished, and headed into the restaurant. There was only one way to find out.

A NEW THRILL

LAURA

When I first asked Conrad to stop by, the idea that was in my mind was that he would stop by as my husband. He would sit at the bar, I'd say hello to him, I'd introduce him to Nate, so he could see him first-hand.

And then, it was like we both got the idea at the same time, but we never said anything to each other. We just kind of lit up, and grinned, and we shared this sexy, crackling moment.

It was probably the most sexy thing that I had felt since this whole thing started, and I don't even know how to explain that to myself. Just the idea, lingering in the air, between us. The idea of him coming in, sitting down, pretending not to know me. And watching me flirt.

Had we shared the same idea? I guess so. Things were getting strange now, but pleasantly strange. Strange like we could get the same idea, and share it, without having to actually say it.

Or did we have the same idea? I don't know. I don't know if it was the same thing that was turning me on as it was for Conrad.

But the more I thought about it, the more I liked the idea.

I didn't like liking the idea, that was the thing. It seemed like there were so many ways it could wrong. How could I trust that Conrad wasn't just saying all of this to entrap me? Or because he wanted to save face?

I didn't want to do anything that was actually over the line.

So this was perfect.

And it was hot.

It was hot from the moment we thought of it, and it was hot all day while I imagined it happening. I found myself excited at work, waiting for him, looking at the door every time it opened. It had been a long time since I felt any kind of desire like that. Excitement, at just the idea of seeing him.

And it felt good to be feeling this about Conrad, instead of Nate.

Even if it sort of had to do with Nate. It had shifted a little, back into the sphere of our marriage.

Every swing of the door made my heart fly to my throat and then fall.

And then I saw him.

He was standing in the parking lot. Smoking.

God. For a second I thought he was going to give up, Decide he didn't want to do it.

But then he crossed the parking lot.

His eyes were set on something. On me. An obsessive, possessive look. A look I hadn't seen for a long time. My pulse raced. I was practically shaking. I took an order and went into the bathroom. I looked at myself in the mirror.

“Calm the fuck down, Laura. Or it won't be any fun.”

But I have to confess. It was the kind of adrenaline, the kind of excitement, that comes from doing something illicit, something new, and I hadn't felt it for a long time. I hadn't even dreamed I was ever going to feel it again with Conrad.

So to say I was deliberating about it would be a lie.

I was hooked.

When I walked out, he was already at the bar. I decided to give the whole thing my all. I didn't look at him. I strode into the kitchen, and looked around for Nate. I wanted to turn up the heat on the flirting now, and it wasn't because I really wanted to flirt with Nate this time.

This time, it was because I wanted to make Conrad's blood boil.

“You got somebody at the bar,” I said, and I placed a hand on his shoulder. I spun around, popping an ice cube into my mouth.

Nate watched me. He was watching my mouth. A thrill went through me. Not so much because I was having any serious thoughts about Nate as a real affair, but because I thought of him now as an affair for Conrad's entertainment.

“Thank you,” he said. “I'll just deliver these wilted salads to five...”

“I can do it,” I said. I took a bowl and slid my fingers under the one he was holding, touching his hand, lingering for a moment with all of the electricity between us. He tapped my finger with his and tucked his money book into his apron. “Thanks,” he said.

I smiled. I wanted him good and flirtatious for Conrad. Casting his eyes in my direction as much as I could entice him to do.

A shiver of excitement ran through me, and as I swung through the door, I had to ask myself what it was.

WATCHING

CONRAD

It wasn't as if there were a lot of people working at the Pied Piper to confuse him with, but it was as though the air sort of rippled when he came through the door of the kitchen. First Laura, pushing the door with her back, holding some salads in her hands. Her face was bright, her mouth open in a big smile. They were talking as they pushed through the door to the kitchen, and the sight of him – the real him, not Laura's rendition of him – sent a cold pulse through my veins. And then it turned warm. I felt my cock coming to life just watching this minor scene, one that probably played out a million times a day.

He was tall, and young. Athletically built – definitively the same hard torso I'd seen in the car. His arms were muscled, and his hands looked strong. I remembered Laura mentioning now that he liked to go climbing. His hair was a little mopish, his eyes charming. He had the face of a funny-man, I would know because that had been me.

His mouth was moving, a wry smile on his lips. His eyes were on Laura like glue, watching for her reaction, hoping to make her laugh. Hoping to make her come back for more jokes, and then something else.

Laura laughed. Her laugh broke apart and echoed around the room. Light. Carefree and really delighted. She fluttered her eyes.

And then he reached out, and touched her.

Nowhere obscene. On her wrist. “Thanks,” he said.

And she spun around, looking over her shoulder, casting her most flirtatious smile back at him.

I would know. She had reeled me in with it.

His eyes lingered on her when she strode away. Lingered, I could tell by their half-lidded, slow blink – on her ass. Involuntarily, I gave a small turn in my chair to look at Laura retreating, and admired her ass – round and cute, maybe a little smaller since she had started working here, and perfectly molded into her jeans. Her ponytail bobbed as she walked briskly down the aisle with the salads aloft.

Nate was walking toward me.

“Good evening sir, welcome to the Pied Piper. What can I do you for?”

Funny guy.

No look of recognition or suspicion crossed his face. My blood was racing, hot and cold, hardening my arteries. I could feel my heart tapping at my chest. Something inside me took over. An impulse.

“Any chance I can get *her*-” Laura, I moved my head in the direction she had gone, and let my voice drip with lechery, “to wait on me?”

I had seated myself at the edge of the bar area, as Laura had advised me to do to get the best view of as much of the restaurant as possible, and to get Nate as my waiter. I would need to order food, or the tight-lipped bartender with eighties bangs who was frowning at every order the waiters left for her, would take over.

He tapped his pencil on an order book and smiled. We shared a leering, knowing, locker-room smile. He nodded. “I’m...disappointed I’m not good-looking enough for you,” he joked. A tough joke to make right, but he flew it well. He scrunched up one side of his face. “I’ll see what I can do. Beer, meanwhile?”

“Something easy-drinking.”

“Cheap or expensive?”

I could see what Laura liked about him. He was funny, he was sharp, he was suave. He wasn’t giving off any adolescent asshole vibe.

His eye was caught by something behind me, and I knew it was Laura. Her ponytail bobbing, she passed us again, and my heart rate jumped. I hoped it wasn’t obvious. My face felt flushed.

I wondered how she was going to play it.

She put out an arm, and touched Nate on the bicep. I looked at her hand – my wife’s hand – on his arm. She gave it a little squeeze. She leaned close to him, far closer than she needed to. “Six needs another pitcher of Coors,” she said. She squeezed his arm, and I watched her fingers against his skin. She moved her pointer finger a little, to stroke his flesh.

I could feel my pulse quicken by tens of beats per minute, and blood was flushing my face. As she walked away, she let her arm drop to his forearm, and slide away.

Nate turned, and gave her a quick glance as she retreated. His face was slightly bemused. When he looked back at me he raised his eyebrows, almost as though to apologize.

For a second it almost stopped my heart, but then I realized it was just an exchange of one-upmanship, and he was trying not to look like too big of a jerk. *What can I do?* He seemed to be saying. *The ladies love me.*

I leaned to watch Laura's retreating figure, and for a moment she looked nothing like my wife. It was almost as if I could see her through Nate's eyes. She looked young, the way she had looked when I met her, as she skipped away.

"Little old for you, no?" I ventured, when Nate returned with my beer. "The waitress."

Nate turned to the dining room, where Laura was serving a large table with another waiter.

He leaned on the bar. "Dude," he said, and I almost laughed at how young he suddenly seemed. "That girl? Is like thirty-eight. She's *married*." He looked at me, expecting an expression of disbelief. I gave him one, and my cock stirred as he said the word *married*.

"No shit," I said. "Sorry. I thought you had a little something -"

Nate shook his head. Then he sucked on his lower lip.

I was pleased to hear this, I have to admit. A tiny ping of disappointment came with it, but mostly I was relieved that Laura's confession had been accurate. There was also a tiny pang of guilt for suspecting my wife of doing something she hadn't, even after she had talked to me about it.

Nate gave a quick glance around the dining room, to confirm Laura wasn't listening, and added, "Not yet."

And then this kid winked at me.

I popped a peanut into my mouth. Laura paraded by, shaking her hips. She gave me no notice, but when she reached the door, she turned to push it open with her back.

That's when she gave me the look. The same look that Eliza gave to Troy, so many years ago. The same look that had been in my mind for so long, burning through me. The look I had fantasized about and kept as a secret.

It actually shook me. I gave a shudder, and Nate's eyebrows came together in momentary concern or confusion. I tapped my beer, as though to blame it.

"Beer okay?" he said.

“Just cold.” I was barely able to get my words out. Laura's complicit, flirtatious look still had a grip on the air in my lungs.

Nate tapped the banister. “Let me know if you need anything,” he said. And he disappeared into the kitchen, where I knew he would go and find Laura.

I drank three “enormous” beers and picked at an order of haggis and mashed turnips while I sat there, watching them. I was so absorbed by Laura and her swinging ponytail, her youthful laughter, and her ostentatious flirting with Nate, that I ate some of the haggis without even tasting it. I'm told this is some feat.

I was grateful that a TV was on the wall to give me something to appear absorbed by, and to escape the hawkish and angry gaze of Sherry. Laura had warned me about her, and even in the state I was in, I found her so severe she was funny.

There were times in the evening when the two of them would disappear from the flow of constant traffic in and out of the kitchen. I felt sure this had been planned by Laura, and that she had asked to bum a cigarette out back, knowing that I would sit there, my eyes on the swinging kitchen door, my heart racing. That my mind would begin to imagine delicious and terrible things in the back room: Laura with her hands against the wall, bent over, guiding his cock to her dripping cunt with one eye on the open pantry door. Smiling as he slid inside of her.

But she would reappear. The second time she disappeared and came back, she exited the swinging doors smiling, beaming her wicked little smile right to me. She reached up to her lips and swiped at the corner of her mouth.

Very seriously. With a cruelly sweet smile.

She did it so artfully. The same way she would wipe a drop of cum from her mouth.

She knew what she was doing.

I sucked in my breath and let the sensation wash over me. Then I turned to the television and tried to distract myself, to calm my aching erection. But my mind went straight to envisioning her on her knees, with the waiter's big cock – for surely it was big? - filling her mouth full of cum. I imagined her smile, as she slurped it all off of him, and he stood there, breathless, thinking to himself how experience really did count for

something...and then I imagined her walking out the door, realizing, by the bitter taste in the corner of her mouth, that she had been just ever-so-sloppy.

I needed to go. The babysitter could only stay until nine, and that had been the agreement between us: that I would get just a taste of her teasing. It was better that way, to just get a taste of it, just for fun.

But I had a hard time tearing myself away.

And still, I felt unsatisfied.

I went home, paid the sitter in a daze, and then lay down in the bed. My fantasies grew, and bloomed, and took on enormous, fantastical, filthy proportions as I lay there.

My mind was to full of images of Laura's mouth around Nate's cock, of Laura bent over on the sheets of a bed, clutching handfuls of sheets and moaning wetly while his cock moved in and out of her dripping cunt, to focus on the thing I really wanted to get to the bottom of:

How could I get Laura to really do it?

FURTHER

LAURA

I was taking things farther than I ever had before with Nate.

Conrad's eyes, so determinedly affixed to the TV, as though he wasn't watching any of this, are what made me do it. I could feel him following us when we weren't looking in his direction. I could feel his stare, hungry and burning, from across the room, as I smiled at Nate and touched his arm. As I stood waiting by the line for my food, and I nudged him gently with my hip.

Nate, as I suspected, was getting sucked in by it all. His eyes were glittering with the idea that he had a chance now, a real chance. I could tell he was imagining what was under my shirt, wondering if an older woman really had some magical powers she had acquired over so many years of sexual maturity. To to give an amazing blowjob, or perform some acrobatic feat he didn't even know about.

I liked this about guys, really. Men never lost this sexual hopefulness. All guys were big, imaginative dreamers when it came to sex. They all really believed in their heart of hearts that there was something left to be done that the internet had not made raw and real in an amateur porn video, and they would get to discover it someday.

I felt myself getting wet, tingling with excitement. My fantasies ran two ways: one to Nate, to feeling, finally, the hard muscles that contoured his shirt. I knew his skin would be hot, hot with that raging metabolism of youth. I wanted to place my palm on his hard ass and dig into his unyielding flesh as he fucked me against a wall. I could almost feel the wall on my back, cold and hard. I could almost feel his body, just a shade softer, slapping against my skin.

Then there was the more tangible fantasy, the one I knew I would really have and make real. There was Conrad, who was going to wait for me at home. Conrad who would be sitting on the bed, waiting to ask me what I had done all night.

I fantasized about telling him a lie. Making up a fantastical story about actually crossing the line. Seeing how he would take it if he thought it had really happened. I could feel his fingers probing me, finding my pussy

as wet as it was now, maybe wetter by the time I got home. I imagined smiling at him, teasing him. Telling him to taste me if he wanted to know the truth.

Or maybe I wouldn't let him. Maybe I would just get his cock inside of me, and tell him how Nate and I had fucked in the bathroom of Ziggy's. I could give him details, drive him wild.

There was another current of fantastical thoughts, in which I actually gave in to Nate. Maybe in his car. We would stare at each other, all the evening's flirting sizzling in the air between us. He would look over at me once, twice, and then pull the car over on the gravel road, unable to hold himself back. Maybe the same turn-around where I had secretly put on my make-up. Maybe right in the field where Conrad and I had done it that night months ago.

Maybe that's just the story I would tell Conrad.

I started doing my sidework early. The place went dead around eight-thirty and Lorraine cut me, but I lingered around, doing things slowly, because Conrad was still there.

We exchanged a knowing glance when he left. I was walking out of the kitchen and he brushed by me. We came within a few inches of each other, and I said, "Excuse me." I saw him smile beneath his cool exterior.

It gave me a thrill to be playing this game with Conrad. As though there were something illicit now about *our* relationship. His fingers briefly brushed against mine, and the heat of his touch crackled through me.

I lingered long after getting cut, because I wanted to make Conrad jealous, wondering where I was. I knew he wanted me to do it, too.

Or maybe because I didn't want to go home just yet.

Was it possible for both things to be true at the same time?

Nate was getting bolder. He stood next to me where I was slowly rolling silverware, and placed his muscled arm against mine. The heat of his body rippled through me, and my breath escaped in a little puff. I no longer had any idea what it was that was turning me on the most: Nate or Conrad. The game or the reality.

He nudged me a little. "You're taking a long time to wrap these silverware up," he joked.

And then his hand moved over mine. He made a pretense of "helping," folding the knives and forks into the paper napkin with my hand,

but it was all pretense. He wanted to touch my hand, wanted me to feel his fingers over mine. “You up for Ziggy's tonight?”

He turned toward me to say this, close to my ear, and his breath was hot on my skin as he did. He might as well have asked me to fuck him, right there, because that's how it sounded to me.

I paused, because I knew that even though no real words were being exchanged here, about anything except going or not going to Ziggy's, that the question was more than that.

And so was my answer.

A knife turned in my stomach.

“Yes,” I breathed.

Conrad had known, after all, that we would go out after work. It was all part of the original plan. I wondered if he knew that my flirting with Nate would push him to make this kind of move, though.

But I didn't know how to put the brakes on any of it.

And I didn't really want to.

We were walking across the parking lot, together, without talking. Both of knew something would happen, and who knew what it would have been if we had only ended up at Ziggy's. I was picturing getting closer and closer, until we ended up in the car together.

But first I would text Conrad, I had decided. Just to give fair warning. Or give him a chance to stop me, if this wasn't really what he wanted.

Or would I?

I don't know. I had no idea what I was doing. I was in a little bit of a trance as I crossed the parking lot.

Deep down inside, I felt like Conrad wanted me to do it. To go all the way. He had met Nate, he knew who he was. He had seen him in the flesh and he had left for home without saying, “hey, that's my wife.” That meant he was still into this game, right?

But without saying anything to each other, I knew I needed to tell him first. Ask him, in fact. Make sure this is what he really wanted.

And I wasn't doing that. But Nate's eyes were burning into mine and the way he had touched me in the restaurant had done something to me.

Who knows what would have happened, if all of that played out?

My reverie, however, was broken, when Jamie, the scraggly short-order cook, who was also a parolee who wore an ankle bracelet and who

had to be home by ten, jumped out in front of us. From somewhere behind the same car, the wan waitress Anna appeared, plume of smoke first, long ash-blond hair next, and finally her thin limbs and long, pretty face.

“WHHHHHHAZZZZAAA!” Jamie yelled.

We stopped and stared at him.

“Going to Ricardo's,” he said, and held his arm out to encircle us. Meaning, so were we.

Nate was already shaking his head. “No way man. Ziggy's.”

I looked at Nate, confused. He mouthed “strip club” in my direction and shook his head some more. “Moms here has to be home by twelve anyway,” he said, as soon as he could see that Jamie wasn't having it.

I rubbed my forehead with the back of my thumbnail. Nate occasionally called me “moms” when he needed an excuse for something and wanted to use me, and it really got under my skin.

So, engaging in one of my worst habits, which is to do things I don't really care to do myself just to piss other people off, specifically in a situation like this one, I said:

“I'm game.”

Nate's eyes grew wide. I couldn't tell if he was impressed or horrified.

The other convenient thing about this was that the weird spell between Nate and I was broken.

I looked down at Jamie's ankle. “Aren't you under house arrest or curfew or something?” I asked. I really did have a mom tone of voice and it made me cringe.

“Nah, Moms, I cut it off.”

“Okay,” I said, shrugging. God, young guys really were so stupid.

Nate looked at me. “You really wanna go?”

I was thinking fast. Actually, the idea was somehow becoming more appealing by the minute, because I had thought a few moves ahead: I could say I wanted to change my clothes, I could talk to Conrad personally, and I knew that if he went for it, it was going to drive him even wilder that I was going to a strip club.

“If we're going to such a great establishment,” I said, having no idea where or what Ricardo's was, but assuming that like most strip clubs the designation would be a good piece of humor, “then I need to go home and change.”

Jamie raised his eyebrows at me. “I dunno. You look pretty good to me.”

I was thankful, suddenly, for an earlier accident: barbeque sauce stained my jeans. I held my leg out for him to see.

Nate was staring at me. But the idea of having me in the strip club, dressed up, and the fact I would go home to do it, seemed to circulate pleasantly in his mind. He warmed to the idea. It rose from the bottom of his face to the top like a filling bathtub.

“I’ll drive you?” he asked.

Since I had started going out with Nate to tease Conrad, Con had started dropping me off at work. No sense having to deal with picking up the car the next morning.

For fun – because it was fun, wasn't it? - I winked at him and said, “We have to be sneaky.”

I could see the ripple of pleasure it gave him. We were off.

“SNEAKING AROUND”

CONRAD

Laura held up two dresses. “You have to choose quick,” she whispered. One was a red dress from years ago, a cocktail party for her work. Unforgettable. But a bit too fancy for a place like Ricardo's.

My mouth was dry. I raised a hand to point at the simple black dress. There wasn't much to it, really: short, tank sleeves, clingy material. It could look casual or fancy. It would look incredible on Laura.

She had come home earlier than expected. She ran up the stairs without turning on any lights. She was breathless.

I had looked out the window. Nate's car was across the street, which is why I hadn't seen him pull up. The lights were out and the car was parked at a distance that seemed sneaky or underhanded somehow.

But Laura was not sneaking. She was flushed, excited. She crouched next to me at my desk, where I was staring at the screen and fantasizing about Laura and everything that had happened at the restaurant. She looked up at me, her arms on my thighs.

“Okay,” she had said. “This is the deal. We ran into Jamie, he's the kid on parole, I don't think I told you about him, but it isn't important, anyway, he cut his ankle bracelet off and he wants to go to a strip club and I said I would go but I said I have to come back here and change so I could talk to you about it.” She took a breath. She was talking a mile a minute. “So I told Nate I would sneak in, change my clothes, you'd probably be sleeping. He thinks you don't know I'm going.”

It had sent such a shiver of rapture through me, to hear that. My head was trying to catch up with the story.

“So what do you think?”

I thought...what? I felt myself nod. Laura with Nate, going to a strip club.

She took me by the hand and told me to help her pick out her outfit. So here we were. My hand pointing at her black dress.

Laura stripped.

I looked at her underwear.

“What's with the crappy underwear?” I asked, amused. Her bra was held together by a safety pin.

She looked up at the ceiling. “Oh god. Okay. So...I wear this stuff so I won't be tempted to...you know.”

I blinked.

She looked at me, a mixture of annoyance and laughter crossing her face. “So I won't have sex with Nate!” she whispered loudly.

This sent a ripple of emotions through me, and all of them seemed to crash together right in my groin.

She lowered her arms, which were halfway down the torso of the dress, to pull over her head.

And then she was suddenly serious. She put a hand on her hip, and cocked her hip slightly.

Now her comical, lighthearted voice was gone. She went stone-serious. “Should I change them?”

I felt like someone had grabbed my chest and squeezed it very slowly, and very hard. We both knew what this question meant.

Right?

I could feel my pulse quickening. A hot stain of fever was creeping along my cheeks. This was it. This was the moment where I could give my wife permission to have sex with another man.

I looked at her underwear. They were so bad. I thought she should change them just...because they were so bad.

But if I said that, would she take it to mean: *go ahead*?

But isn't that what I really wanted?

I stood up and moved to the drawer. I found a pair of black underwear, silky and lacy, and I handed them to her.

“You're sure?” she said.

I wasn't. I was. I wanted this, and I didn't.

Which one was pulling on me harder?

I knew that I wanted to say yes. Go ahead. God, I wanted that. But there was something inside me that insisted on telling me that this would change things forever.

That's probably why it was so appealing.

Risking everything.

I moved my head slowly up and down.

She stood close to me, and her lips were next to mine. She placed a hand on the back of my head, and turned on her sultriest voice. "I want to hear you say it, just so there's no confusion."

The fist that was gripping my insides squeezed hard. I could see now that Laura was all-in, and it was searing hot. But it also troubled me, because it seemed like just hours ago that I had been pondering how I would get her to go all the way.

Did it bother me that she got there by herself?

Should it? Wasn't the outcome the same, no matter what?

"I want you to wear these black underwear," I said, noncommittally.

Laura smiled, but she was still wired with the serious tension of sex.

"Say it, Conrad."

Her fingers raked the back of my head, down to my neck. I shivered.

"I want you to do whatever you want to do," I said, my voice low.

Her eyes fluttered a little, and she moved her hand down my chest.

There was a quality to Laura now that was different. Something inside of her that she never had before. Maybe a new-found sense of power, or a self-possession. Her lips moved closer, and she brushed them against mine as her hand stroked my cock through my sweatpants. "What if I want to sit on his lap and watch the dancers?"

"Okay."

Fuck, she was driving me wild.

"What if I want to kiss him?"

"Fine."

She drew a bit of my lip into her mouth and nibbled it with her teeth.

"What if I can't wait until I get home, and I want to suck his cock?"

"Oh god, Laura." My cock was so hard that it hurt again, and she was trailing her fingertips over it, through the fabric, only making it harder and teasing me more.

"Well? Do you want me to suck his cock, if that happens?"

I closed my eyes. "Yes."

We kissed. I pressed up against her, and I moved my hands down to her bare tits.

"Anything else?" she breathed in my ear.

I knew what it was now, Laura knew she had me by the balls. That she could wrap me completely around her finger now, with this fantasy.

Laura could always have done that, before, she just never seemed to act on it.

“Can I do anything else? Or is that as far as I can go?”

The rush of blood to my cock seemed to have actually robbed my muscles of enough oxygen to move. I sort of felt like I was going to collapse.

“Just that,” I managed to say.

And Laura pushed away from me. “Okay. Get me a sexy bra, then,” she said, and she bent over to slide her underwear on.

I watched her, transfixed. Paralyzed. I watched the black lace as she used her fingers beneath the elastic to smooth out the wrinkles and lay the lace precisely and beautifully against her skin.

I never took the time anymore to appreciate Laura's lingerie. I wondered why. The boy-cut panties framed the delightful tiny round of her belly, the sweet curves of her hips, and her muscular thighs perfectly. In the mirror I could see the fabric, just above the swells of her buttocks, showing them off.

She laughed, and I realized I hadn't fetched her bra from the drawer. She pushed me aside and did it herself, and I watched her put it on, tucking her breasts into the matching lace and satin, plumping them until they were, like her ass, perfectly framed. They were round and seemed fuller.

“I have to hurry. Remember, I'm sneaking around.”

She slipped the dress over her head.

When it was on, the dress clung to her figure. She gave me a whirl.

Then she leaned in to me, and strangely, did not ask for any final confirmation.

“Don't wait up for me,” she said. She grazed my lips with hers.

And then she left, leaving me standing in the room with the most intense hard-on I'd ever had.

I managed to look over my shoulder, out to the street. I saw Laura skipping along. Her feet were bare, she held her shoes – a pair of high, sexy heels – in her hand. She hopped into the car, and Nate, that little wife-stealing shit, drove away without turning on his headlights.

But the joke, I suppose, was on him.

I HAVE TO GO

LAURA

“Just drive into the driveway,” I told Nate, but he stopped the car about a block from the house. He turned to me and slid his hands between my thighs. His hands were hot, and he brushed them only against my inner thighs, only midway. He was looking at me with his intense blue eyes.

“I had fun tonight,” he said. I could feel his hand moving further up. I didn't try to stop him.

He leaned over and kissed me. I could tell by the way his lips were hard, and his cheeks were flushed, that he was pumped with desire. I knew, without looking or feeling, that his cock was rock-hard. If he moved his fingers up any further, he would find my panties soaked, my pussy ready for him.

He moved a hand to the back of my head and worked his fingers through my hair. He used a thumb against my jaw to hold me there, so he could kiss me harder, his tongue plunging into my mouth.

“I have to go,” I whispered, when we finally took a breath. His hand closed around my thigh, and his pinkie finger extended to brush over my panties. Right over my clit. I shuddered.

“Really?” he said. His eyes flicked to my house up the street. “We could just...”

I smiled. I kissed him again. His lips were hot, eager, probing. It ended up much longer than I had expected.

“I have to go,” I said.

It wasn't that I necessarily wanted to: part of me would love to have sex with Nate in the car, letting Conrad watch what he could from the bedroom. I knew he was there, watching like a hawk every passing car, every headlight. He would like it, to see my heels bouncing around in the windshield, and Nate's white shirt slide up his torso. He might even like that the view was incomplete, and terrible.

But I wanted to drag it out a little longer.

I was enjoying teasing both of them, truth be told. Watching them twist with their desires.

There was also a part of me, I knew, that was afraid to actually go through with it. Because what would happen then? Then everything would be real, and everything would need some kind of ending.

This way, we were all just waiting for the tipping point, for the climax, and none of us were thinking about the aftermath.

It was just like sex in some compromising position or place. It all seems fine and great until everyone comes.

And then you're sitting there, maybe in a car in a field, or a phone booth, or with someone you shouldn't be with, and you're like: what the fuck am I doing?

I felt like this side of the climax was more fun. Prettier. Sweeter.

I kissed Nate and grabbed the handle. His hand tried to grasp me between my legs but I pushed him away. "Sorry," I said. "I have to go."

I jumped out of the car.

He rolled down his window and hung his arm out. "Laura," he hissed.

I turned around. I could see he wanted me to come back. Get a last kiss. Another feel.

I looked up at our window, knowing that Conrad was probably there. Peering out into the darkness. I smiled for him.

Then I turned around and went back to the car. I leaned over, and I really laid it on thick, letting Nate draw his hand from behind my neck, down the collar of my dress, and down...brushing over my breast.

Then I left him, and went home.

STRIP TEASE

CONRAD

Laura came home at three-thirty.

It was later than it should have been, even if she had stayed until the very last call. The club was only thirty minutes away, by the most generous estimate.

That left at least – *at least* – an hour of unaccounted-for time.

I had expected her to stay out until closing. In fact, I wanted her to. And I supposed that she knew that. Of course I couldn't sleep. I didn't even try.

I was glad I had gone to the restaurant. That I had an image of Nate in my mind. That I had something to feed the increasingly lurid fantasies I was spinning up, alone, in an armchair downstairs.

After Laura left, I couldn't take it. I went into the shower and jerked off. I came in seconds, just thinking about her sitting on Nate's lap in the strobe lights of the strip club. Her legs crossed, her head turned up, her mouth open in laughter. His cock hard underneath her thighs. His eyes only on her, in spite of all the other women in the club.

As soon as I came though, the doubts started creeping in. What the fuck was I doing, letting my wife go off to a strip club with a twenty-three year old waiter? In her fancy black underwear? Basically having instructed her to fuck him?

The water ran down into my face. This was a terrible idea.

But then, I started to imagine it all again. The electricity that had snapped through me when Laura's voice had rippled over my lips:

“Do you want me to suck his cock, then?”

The hours ticked by. And then it was later than it should have been.

It meant, as soon as it was three o'clock, that Laura had definitely done something other than go to the strip club, tease Nate, and come home.

Had they gone to his place? What was that like, I wondered? Some Bohemian love-den, or was he a jock, with beer cans everywhere and a Budweiser neon sign on his window?

But more importantly, were they writhing like snakes now, or was her mouth around his cock now? I let my mind picture Laura in ever-more dirty

fantasies, until she was hanging over the edge of the bed, her mouth open for Nate's cock. His balls slapped against her forehead as he hammered his big, pink cock in and out her mouth, filling up her throat while she just let him have his way with her.

The fantasy made my cock harden again, and I was tingling with the desire to throw Laura on my bed when she got home, and sink into her hot flesh.

But what was I going to find there? Was she going to be all filled up already, all worn-out and too tired to fuck again because Nate had fucked her raw?

I had basically told her to do it.

The knife twisted inside of me again.

This went on and on, and I went upstairs to watch out the window. It was tiresome, standing there. There was no chair and the window was too high for one anyway. Nothing to do but feel the glass getting cooler and cooler in the night air, picture Laura on all fours crying out for more, and wait.

I watched her kiss Nate in the car. It was hard to see, but I could see their bodies coming together. There was nothing else they could be doing. I strained to see the details: where he placed his hand, how her body moved. But it was too dark and too far away.

Then she emerged from the car, and looked up at the window.

She knew I was there, watching. She smiled and turned around to give him a kiss.

I reminded myself that Laura had come to me first to okay this evening. That I had let it happen. That all of this was of my own making.

But it also felt out of control.

I stayed where I was and watched Nate drive away.

I heard Laura's footsteps immediately on the steps. I turned to face her.

She stepped out of her shoes and held them in her hands.

The moment was a little awkward.

“So,” she said.

“So.”

She tossed her glossy hair over her shoulder and took a step toward the bed. She lay down on it, stretching her self out. She twirled a shoe in her

hand.

“How was Ricardo's?” I said, moving closer.

“Really, really interesting,” she said. “I learned some *very* interesting things from those girls.”

I felt my cock start to throb again. I was a little speechless. Laura propped her head up on her hand.

“Did you practice any of them already?” I managed to say.

She twirled her shoe by the heel. “With Nate, you mean.”

“You've been gone a long time,” I said.

Another twirl.

“Do you want to hear all the details about what I did with Nate?” she said. Her voice was sort of a growl.

I gave her a nod. I couldn't get an intelligent statement out anyway.

She sat up on the bed and pulled her legs underneath her.

“Sure you won't get jealous?”

“That's what I want,” I managed to say.

Her eyes were twinkling. “Hmm. Maybe I had just better keep some of it a secret. Maybe it's too dirty. Maybe if you just...ask me. I'll give you an honest answer.”

She slid her dress up to her panties. “Or you could just check for yourself. Use your imagination.”

Jesus fucking Christ. Somehow I had created a monster.

I should have known. Laura was always – and this came as a complete surprise – a really dirty talker. That is, she had been. Before the kids. She had a writer's ear for it. I don't even know where she got this stuff, or how she managed to hit things just the right way.

But now, now it left me with the heat, but also the worry.

Why. Why did she know just what to say? And why was she having *such* an easy time with this?

Maybe she had been having an affair along, for example. And now she was liberated to whatever she wanted.

She pulled her dress over head.

The black bra was gone. Her pert tits bounced lightly and then glowed white in the moonlight, her pink aureole washed pale in the light. Her nipples were hard.

She had a challenging expression on her face. I knew she wanted me to ask.

Where was the bra?

Instead, I stepped toward her and placed my hands on her ribcage, behind her tits. I placed my thumbs on her nipples, and I jerked her toward me. The violence with which I did it took her breath away, maybe scared her a little. I gave her a little smile, to let her know it was all part of the game.

“Were you very bad, Laura?” I growled.

I could see by the flush in her face, and the way her eyes dilated even more, that she liked this.

“Yes.”

I brushed her lips with one finger. I had an urge to put my fingers in her mouth, and pry her open, look inside, but I resisted it. “Did you suck Nate's cock?”

She waited, letting me stroke her lips and hover in that torturous silence for what seemed like an eternity. Then she opened her mouth and sucked my forefinger all the way to the last knuckle. Her tongue swirled over my finger. She sucked in her cheeks, the way she would if she were actually sucking cock.

Was this her answer?

“Was it big?” I asked, my finger still in her mouth.

She nodded.

“Was it the biggest cock you've ever had in your mouth?”

She nodded. Her eyes were on mine.

I reached down to her panties with my free hand. I slid my finger to her gash, and found the hot liquid welling from inside her. Her panties were soaked. The scent of her juices filled my nose...but it was only her, dripping, soaking wet.

I found her clit, and she released my finger to gasp.

I went ahead and put my fingers in her mouth, pulling down on her jaw to open it. “He didn't come down here,” I said, squeezing her clit between my fingers and making her twist.

She shook her head.

“Did he come in your mouth, then, Laura?”

She smiled.

A shudder of pleasure, with sharp teeth of pain, went through me. My heart was racing around in my chest. And my cock was as hard as I thought it could get without exploding on its own.

“Show me,” I said, pushing her down and using my hand to slide my boxers away from my cock.

Laura bowed to the pressure of my hand, but then she resisted and sat up.

“The thing is,” she said. “If you want it to be realistic, you need to fuck me *first*, and get my cum all over your cock. And then I'll lick it off...” Then she lowered herself down on the bed again, with her ass in the air.

I stepped out of my boxers, and moved around the bed.

I reached out for her ass, and slid the underwear from her hips.

“Just to the knees,” she said. “Leave them there.”

“That's what Nate did?”

“Mmmhmm.”

Her wet panties were heavy as I slid them down her legs and left them at her knees. The effect was incredibly dirty. Her ass was displayed to me, round and small, and between it her snatch. Engorged. Wet. Apparently used. I could smell her from where I was, as though she were right in front of me.

“Where were you?”

Laura propped herself up on her elbows so she could turn her head back to me. Another smile. “Not in a bed,” she said. But this will have to do.”

“And did you have any foreplay?” I said.

“Of course. I was teasing him all night. But once we locked ourselves in Jamie's big Suburban, things went fast.”

In a car.

“So you just bent over like this-”

“No, he pushed me down. Actually my dress was still on, and he pushed it down to my head. Then the underwear...”

“And then what?”

“And then he moved his cock from my clit to my ass a few times.”

I did the same, imagining that fucking *kid* with his huge cock, sliding his dick around my wife's asshole, while she pressed her body to the floor of the car and moaned.

“And then?”

“And then he...well he started to go inside of me.”

I pushed into her, and I slid into her slippery folds with no effort at all.

“But his cock was so big,” she continued. “And I haven't really had sex with anyone but..you...in so long...so he had to go really, really slowly.”

I started to move back and forth, unable to stop myself. Her pussy sloshed with sticky sounds.

“But finally, finally, he got all the way inside of me.”

Laura moaned.

“Keep talking,” I whispered.

Laura moaned again in response. “I was so full. It felt so good. And he started to fuck me.”

“Hard?”

“Hard, all the way in. I could feel his balls slapping me here,” she touched her clit.

I pressed my palm against the small of her back.

“And then I...” she seemed to lose her breath. “I...oh, oh fuck, I came all over his cock.”

She was moving her own ass now, grinding against me, hungry for her own orgasm – what seemed to be one of many, many she had had that night. I felt her squeeze around me and I leaned over her, pressing against her back, trying to avoid coming.

Because I wanted to hear the next bit.

I pulled out of her while she was still throbbing. Her pussy was quivering, and her cum gushed from it in sticky waves.

“And then?” I said. I could barely talk.

She sat up, pushing her hair out of her face. “And then, he asked me to try something the strippers had talked about. It was what got us all hotted up really.” She turned to me, and she had her tits in her hands. She was pushing them together, massaging them seductively, a bit like a stripper.

My cock was screaming at me.

But I let it play out. She evidently wanted to tease me up until the last moment.

She leaned over the bed, and I was confused for a moment. She sat up quickly though, with her shoes in hand.

“The conversation started about shoes. Why the strippers always have such outrageous shoes, how they dance in them...what you'd expect, they make your legs long, right. But then this one girl said she likes those shoes for blow jobs.”

I was panting now. My cock seemed to be pointing upward. Her cum was drying on it. But she wanted to tell this story. And I wanted to hear it. She leaned backward to put her shoes on. Quite a feat. I watched her, stunned. Entranced.

“So of course,” Laura said. “I had to ask what that was all about.”

“And Nate was where?”

“I was sitting on Nate's lap. His cock was hard all night, and I could feel it. And while this girl told us this story...well, showed us really. Hand me my shoes.”

Laura was moving now. Getting onto all fours. But then she lay down. I was a little confused.

“The reason she likes it, is so she can do this,” Laura said. She kicked her legs up and into her hands. She grasped her own heels, kind of like a yoga pose.

Oh god. I had seen this before.

It was incredibly lewd.

I knelt onto the edge of the bed, though. In time for Laura to lift her head, and open her mouth.

“So we listened to this story,” she said, looking up at me. “She said guys love it so much they come right away. Some of them come on her face before they get their cock in her mouth.”

I could see it happening. I held my cock for her, but she was waiting to see how much I could take.

“And I said...‘I don't believe that.’ And she said, ‘try it.’”

This sent a jolt through me. Fuck.

And image of her and Nate, running through the parking lot, hand in hand, to “try out” the stripper's technique, flashed through my head. I grasped her hair and I pushed her onto my cock. But I was barely inside of her mouth, looking at her hands on her stilettos, her twisted, damp panties, and I came. I pushed her down on me, down to the base of my cock, and slammed myself deep into her throat.

WHAT REALLY HAPPENED

LAURA

Conrad collapsed on the bed.

“Holy shit,” he said.

I couldn't really read it. Was it, “Holy shit that was good?” or “Holy shit, this is fucked-up?”

I lay down next to him.

We looked at the ceiling for a minute. We were both sweating, and my blood was pounding in my ears. I wouldn't have heard him anyway, if we had started talking then.

Finally, I lifted my hand and put it on his chest. It was probably time to come clean. Because maybe he was regretting all of this.

And if he wasn't?

I wondered about that. I wondered what I would feel if he had no regrets at all. If me doing that kind of thing with Nate was really something he wanted to make viscerally real.

I also wondered about myself. I mean, saying all of that had definitely turned me on. *Imagining it* turned me on. But would I do it? I'd do it with Conrad – I just had – but would I do it with another guy?

“What are you thinking?” I said.

Conrad didn't really think I'd go through with all that, did he? He didn't actually think I would have been so extreme.

He sighed.

I propped myself up on my elbow. “Are you having regrets?”

Conrad really had to think about this. I could see that.

Obviously – obviously by how steel-hard his cock was, he was getting off on all of this. But something wasn't quite right with him.

“God,” I said. “You really think I *did* all that.”

I flopped onto the bed.

The relief seemed to well up inside of him. He had been rigid, lying there, and he seemed almost to melt into the bed.

I grabbed a stray pillow with my right hand and crossed it over my body to hit him on the face. He chuckled. I blew air out of my mouth.

“Conrad, jeez. I can't believe you *believed me*.”

He stopped laughing.

“You were very convincing,” he said. He was almost defensive.

I pulled the pillow away from his face. I wanted to keep this from getting too serious.

“This is what I'm worried about,” I said. “About actually going...you know. All the way.”

His face became serious. “Me too,” he told the ceiling.

I looked at his face, searching for his thoughts.

“It's just...you didn't have to be such a fake slut right off the bat,” he said.

“I thought it was hot?”

“It was.”

I made an exasperated sound and flopped onto my back again.

Conrad narrowed his eyes.

“How'd you know all that...stuff, anyway?”

“What stuff? How to suck cock?” I rolled my eyes.

“No, like what to say.”

I had a confession to make. After Conrad had revealed his secret fantasies to me, I had done what anyone does these days. Instead of talking to a friend – because it was just too wild – I had consulted the internet.

And then I had dug through his computer files.

In my former, professional life, I was a consultant. This was my old job: digging through things and getting a picture of what people really wanted and really needed. From the things they did, every day. Finding all the tell-tale signs of what they actually wanted, not what they *said* they wanted. It made me a good consultant. And it made me a good non-fiction writer.

“I researched you,” I told him. Conrad chuckled, his mood instantly lightened. He should have known, his laugh was saying. I was glad he didn't seem to miffed about it. “Shouldn't you be asking me, what *really* happened with Nate?”

His laughter stopped and his eyes flapped open wide. It was funny to me that he hadn't even considered this question. I *had* been gone a long time. I *had* come home wet as hell, and ready to go. Something had happened tonight.

He turned to me. “What *did* happen?”

I paused. It was a pretty mundane truth, after what I had just told him. I laughed lightly.

“We waited for a cab from one to three. None ever came. Nate decided he had sobered up.”

Conrad opened his mouth to protest.

“He really didn't have that much.”

“And you kissed.”

I paused. I had decided, before I even gave in to anything with Nate, that I would have to be honest with Conrad.

But it was kind of hard to get going with saying the truth, as opposed to a made-up story I was just using to turn him on. “Well...not exactly just kissing.”

I watched Conrad's face carefully, because it was his reaction – and whether it was genuinely okay with this or not – that was important to me.

“We sort of...made out.” A giggle escaped me. “Oh god, it sounds so adolescent.”

Conrad, though, had rolled back toward me and his eyes were dilated with interest. He started to trail his hand down my body, lightly. I felt his cock twitching against my thigh.

“Tell me more details,” he said.

“They're...not going to compare to the scene I just described.”

His fingers arrived at my sex, and he began to work his way inside of me. His thumb stroked my clit, right on the sensitive bundle of nerves protruding from my swollen button, and it was like he struck a match.

“Okay so,” I said. “We left the club and we were both pretty turned on.”

“Why?”

I closed my eyes. Conrad's fingers were inside of me now, probing, feeling for the underside of my clit so he could make me squirm.

“I sat on Nate's lap all evening, that part was true. His cock was hard, but not because he was looking at the girls. And we just...did that thing, you know, where we came close to kissing but didn't, and I just sort of teased him. Flipped my hair around.” I smiled. “Sort of wriggled on his lap so I knew I was...like, moving around on his cock, right?”

It was incredible to me that Conrad seemed even more turned on by this PG-13 description of the evening than the XXX-rated one I had given him a few minutes ago. He curled his fingers upward and clawed at the

rawest part of me. I sucked in my breath, unable to speak for a moment as a wave of ecstasy rolled over me.

“And then, you know...the stripper really did come and talk to us about that...maybe not so...directly...but it was...a conversation.” Conrad had his thumb on my clit again, and he was pressing it from the inside of me. “Oh god,” I breathed.

“Keep going,” he growled.

It was so hot seeing him like this. Hungry again, the way you are when you first start fucking, or even before that. When nobody knows, yet, what they're going to get, or if they're going to get anything. Everything edgy and bright.

“So we were really heated up,” I said.

“You were too?”

“Yeah.”

“You were wet?”

I let a moan escape me, because he pinched my clit at that precise moment and sent an almost too-intense jolt through me. “I was..I was really wet.”

“So you're outside.”

“Mmmhmmm....oh god.” I could feel my orgasm building, knotting up in my abdomen. I could scarcely concentrate on what Conrad was saying.

“And then what?”

“I...I don't...” my voice trailed off. I was so close.

Conrad stopped and the disappointment slammed inside of me. I opened my eyes.

“Tell the story,” he said.

“And then...he did some thing where he tried to, I don't know, wrestle a piece of paper from my hand, and then he had me backed up against the wall, and we looked at each other...and then we kissed.”

He began to move his hand slowly.

“Oh god, Conrad.” But he was staring at me. *Keep talking.*

“And so...then we started to kiss, and he had me...pressed up against the...the...” I was losing it again.

“The wall. And could you feel his cock?”

“Mmmhmmm.”

“And was it big?”

“It...I put my hand on it...over his...over his jeans...and it was big. It's big.”

This drove Conrad insane. He rolled on top of me, and I grimaced as he withdrew his hand just seconds before I would have gone over the edge. But his cock was inside me soon enough, filling the void, and he began to thrust inside of me, deep and hard.

“Where did he touch you?”

“On my...fuck...on my, I let him get his hands just on my underwear. Over the top, not...”

But whatever else I was going to say was lost, as the lust coiling up inside me unwound suddenly, and shook me harder than ever before. I screamed into Conrad's shoulder, and held on to him as he pounded into me, harder and harder, until I felt his warm cum inside of me.

SERIOUS NOW

CONRAD

“So I'm serious now.”

“Me, too.”

“One hundred percent honesty.”

“Okay.”

I was in the shower, and I was staring at the tiles at the back of it. Was I about to do what I was about to do?

Fucking Laura last night had been the hottest sex I had ever had or imagined having in my entire life. And it had been pretty clear that she had liked it, too. And she had admitted to going over the line – though disappointingly, not as far as she first told me.

About that. It had grated pretty painfully while she told that outrageous story. Of course it was so incredibly hot that my cock had taken over, but I felt pretty sure I would have been bothered by it today, if it had all been true.

And that's because...well, I knew it was because it would have meant Laura was out of my control. And I hadn't gotten to see it. And so it wasn't really my fantasy anymore.

I found my mouth moving and saying all of this without me really even authorizing it. I spat it out sort of robotically.

“I know this isn't really fair but...I dunno. I want to ask you to do it someplace I can see it, and it's sort of about, me not being cut out of the picture, having some control over things, you know?”

Silence on the other side of the curtain.

Oh no.

Was she pissed?

“Do you still actually want to do it?” I said. “You're attracted to him right?”

Laura threw the curtain back with a scrape of the curtain rings.

“So...you want to watch, is that it?”

I knew my cock was hard, just thinking about this. I looked down and Laura's eyes followed mine.

She tossed her hair again.

“Okay. Honesty,” she said.

There was a long, terrible pause while I waited for her.

“I want to do it,” she said softly. “It's just...”

Her face was serious. And then, just as I started to despair, I saw the corner of her lip shake a little. Holding back a smile. “I have no idea how we can arrange it so you can watch it.”

She reached into the shower, and grasped my cock. Her hand began to move up and down my shaft, stroking me, as she kept talking. “So you tell me, because I found all this stuff on your computer, like I said...tell me if I'm right? You want me to suck his cock and look at you while I'm doing it? That's the thing you want to see the most, isn't it?”

Fuck.

Her words almost slammed an orgasm through me by themselves. Her hand was stroking me quickly now. She smiled. “That's it, isn't it. You can tell by the videos.” She looked down at my cock and watched herself stroking me for a moment. “What I can't figure out, so you need to help me, is whether you want to see his cum all over my face, or you want me to swallow?”

She moved her hand up and down my shaft, slowly at first. Her eyes were on mine, burning right into me. She was serious now, I could tell. She was thinking of him, thinking of sucking him off, and she was looking at me. She stroked harder as I tensed up, her eyes blazing with exactly what I wanted to see: desire for me, while thinking of another man. I yelled as my cum surged up from deep inside and exploded, splashing all over the tiled wall.

Laura giggled, washed her hand in the shower stream, and closed the curtain. “Get back to me on that. I have to think of a way to make this work.”

It was just then that I got it: the hobby job Laura had had shifted, from being a waitress to doing something more akin to her old line of work. She had analyzed my fantasy, researched it, and now she was going to make things happen.

It took me a few moments to recover. My ears were pulsing with the remnants of my orgasm. The sound of the shower was a dull roar in my ears.

“So,” Laura said, and the hollowed-out sound in her mouth indicated she was brushing her teeth. “I was looking into this on the internet, and it

seems like...you know, some people just *ask* the guy, the...what is he called?"

My insides twisted. The idea of Laura on the internet, in the middle of the day, "looking this up," was recalling my drained cock to new action. I pressed my hand on the tile and steadied myself. "The bull," I managed to say.

"Yeah, the bull," Laura said, and spit. "They just ask the guy to do it. I just...I dunno. Do you think I could do that with Nate, though? Like just say, hey, I've been flirting with you because my husband wants to watch me with you, so will you come over and be the bull?" She was a little giggly by the end of her sentence.

I opened the shower curtain. "You're kidding, right?" I said.

She looked at me. The toothbrush was still in her mouth and she moved it with deep sexual innuendo. "What? No, I'm serious."

I sighed. Women.

"This guy is what, twenty-three?" I said. My cock started to throb again, thinking of Eliza and Troy. "If you say, 'hey, I want to give you a blowjob,' and then follow it up with twenty minutes of chatter about how you want to do it, whatever it is, like, elephants and circus clowns or...whatever...he's going to hear: 'Hey, I want to give you a blowjob.'"

Laura turned to the sink and spit again. "I dunno..." she said, dubiously.

I turned off the shower.

"I know," I said, stepping out and reaching for her hips. I pulled her toward me. "You just tell him what you want, and he'll do it." I started to pull her camisole down her shoulders.

She looked at me, and her doubts were still evident in her face. "So, I just say..."

I worked my hand underneath her shirt, and reached behind her to pull her closer. "You just say, 'I'll have sex with you, but my husband has to watch.' And he'll be like, 'whatever turns you on.'"

Laura gave me an incredulous look.

"And if he doesn't?"

"Please."

She laughed. "You would do that?" She squirmed away from me.

I was thinking how to answer, but my wife's hawk-like eyes missed nothing.

“Ahhhhh,” she said, turning back to the sink to pour herself some mouthwash. “So you *have* done it.”

I shrugged. “I was young.” I grabbed a towel. I was dripping all over the floor.

Laura swished mouthwash around in her mouth and eyed me through the mirror.

I stood behind her, so she could feel my erection through her clothing, against her ass. “We are all the same,” I purred.

She nearly didn't manage to get the mouthwash in the sink when she laughed.

“Oh my god.” She looked back up at the mirror. Then she shrugged. “This is really what you want to do?”

I pressed into her. She laughed again.

“Okay...then I'll ask him, Thursday.”

I said nothing, just moved my hand up her shirt.

“And then I guess...we'll see. So what do I do after that?”

We looked at each other.

She turned around to face me. “Hotel,” she said, and I nodded. “Definitely.”

She moved her hand down to my erect cock, and smiled as she began to stroke me. “You're sure it will work?”

“Sure.”

We kissed, and I started to push her back into the bedroom.

“Conrad, *jesus*, ” she said, but her voice was teasing.

And then she said the words that sliced me with the most delicious, painful, sweet cut I can remember having in my life.

“Think you can get a sitter for Thursday night?”

HOW THINGS WORK OUT

LAURA

By the time I got Nate alone in the pantry, I had suffered for a half an hour waiting tables with everything that was about to happen looming over me, twisting up my insides. Conrad had indeed gotten a sitter, and then a hotel, and the plan was all in place. I had dressed in front of him, enjoying the tantalizing agony he was enduring as I chose my underwear, as I put on my shirt.

The excitement, for both of us, was almost too much to bear.

He chose the color of my lipstick, advised me on my hair. Dressing me up, almost like a doll, for the evening ahead.

There's an intellectual part of me, of course, that *wanted* to find this...well, a little bit fucked.

But there was a more primal thing inside of me that loved it. I loved the idea of finally feeling the weight of Nate's hard body, his cock inside of me – but as a sexual act, separate, really, from Nate and me, and more as an act on Conrad himself.

My underwear were wet before I even got in the car.

The sitter was there on time, and Conrad drove me to The Pied Piper. No talking, just this really heavy, intense tension between us.

I put my hand on the doorhandle. “Last chance,” I said. “Unless Nate won't do it,” I added with a laugh.

Conrad was silent. He wanted this, I knew, as much as I did. But there was still a lingering worry – and maybe this is what made it so enticing – that it would all go wrong somehow. That it wasn't the right choice for our marriage.

He gave his head a slight shake.

“I'll be there,” he said. “But if you change your mind, at any time...”

We kissed. I could feel it snap through him like a wave of energy.

And then I was there, trying to get Nate in the back where I could tell him my idea.

Nate was turning it on, hard. He came up behind me in the pantry, and his hard chest was hot against my back. I could feel his cock was already a little hard. “I missed you last week,” he whispered.

I led him on for a bit. Maybe because it was fun, maybe because I was nervous about actually doing this – once I proposed it to him, it would be pretty hard to get out of. I had some real...I don't know, shaky moments. Moments where I was convinced, just for a second, that I should call the whole thing off.

But the truth, at least deep down inside of me, was that I wanted it.

And the other truth was that it was all made sweeter by the faint possibility that it could all go wrong. Something about it being at the edge of everything, pushing against the safe, comfortable limits of our relationship, made it all that much more appealing.

9:30. Lorraine cut me, and I went back to finish up my sidework. Nate passed by, raised an eyebrow, and I used my head to tell him to head to the freezer.

He joined me a minute later. He made some corny joke about warming me up and pushed me against the wall.

It felt so good to be able to give into him. Fuck, he was hot. I let myself get carried away for a second, pushing my hand up his shirt to feel his sculpted chest.

“Can you go out tonight?” he said.

This was the moment. I smiled at him, surprising even myself with the devious, coquettish smile I gave him. I bit my lip and fluttered my eyes, savoring the disappointment dripping down his face. My mind was suddenly ahead of me, planning out the next moves in the conversation like it was a presentation.

“I have plans with Conrad,” I said.

Nate's face was mixture of disappointment and...yes, there it was, jealousy. I don't mind admitting I was really getting off on that. It was so raw, so sexual. So possessive. I let it wander around in him and then I stopped him before he said anything stupid.

“But..” I said, and I ran my hand back up his shirt. I moved a nipple around, and smiled again.

I definitely had him on the hook now. What would I say next? What was the catch? Would I meet him later?

“I have an idea,” I began, and then I let my face cloud over. “No, you wouldn't like it.”

He was all-too eager to like it, whatever it was. He pushed me against the wall and grinned. “I think I would. Does it involve seeing you?”

He couldn't have set it up better.

“Well,” I said. “I have a confession to make.”

He almost growled.

“I...I also have plans with you.”

“Oh yeah?” He pressed his mouth against mine and his hand went between my legs. I was already so wet that I felt sure my jeans might betray that fact. “What are they?” he whispered.

“You, and a hotel,” I said. He purred like a fucking cat.

“But,” I said, and he stood back from me, amused. He had a very self-assured look on his face now, and I could see that what Conrad had said was true: he would only hear that I wanted to fuck him. He wouldn't give a shit about anything else. “I'll fuck you, and give you the most amazing head you've ever had...” I trailed my fingers down his shirt and put my hand on his balls, cupping them through his jeans. “But...Conrad will be there, watching.”

It took a while for that last bit to get through to his mind, I could see. But when it did, it flashed over his face, sort of like the light of a firefly. His features went a little confused, and then I could see he gave it very, very brief consideration, did the male math Conrad said he would, and his face went back to self-assured and almost cocky. “Weird,” he said. “But whatever.”

There was a tiny temptation to slap him.

But I was too caught up in my own fantasy to care.

I guess that's how these things work out.

WAITING

CONRAD

Waiting in the hotel was the most torturous experience of my life.

It was a motel, and admittedly not extremely fancy but there really wasn't anything else nearby, and Laura had found it extremely amusing when I told her about it.

"I mean, we aren't going to sleep there, so who cares?" she had said. She texted me at 9:50.

It's on.

I stared at the screen.

I had a practical problem, and that was that I had no idea what to do with myself. Sit down? Stand up? I sort of wished I was still friends with Troy, so I could ask for advice.

I paced the room. I took a shower and masturbated, because I knew I wouldn't last long without doing that. I paced again.

My feelings were in an uproar. I was excited: I knew that. The idea that in less than half an hour I would have in front of me, where I could see it, hear it, and smell it, the very thing I had coveted so secretly for so long, of course was inside of me like electricity. My cock had been rock hard since I had watched Laura getting dressed, smelled her neck where she had applied perfume, though about how someone else would be doing the same thing right in front of me...

Still, the excitement was mixing with so many other feelings. Jealousy, of course, but I had long since figured out that jealousy gave me a high, that I liked it the way a person likes the burn of alcohol: it will turn into something else. It was like a bell for Pavlov's dog, and set me salivating.

But I had to admit that there were other, darker things underneath the surface. Laura's nonchalance, for example. The possibility that she agreed to this not because she wanted me to be happy, as she was pretending, but because she just wanted an excuse to fuck some young guy and get away with it. The idea that maybe she was devious and not devout, that she had tricked me into believing this was my own idea. That I had rented the hotel room in which the undoing of our marriage would begin.

It was too late. It was too late, of course, to back out – and Laura had given me the option, hadn't she? So many times, right until the last moment.

In the end, I knew that no matter what the risks were, I was going through with it if Laura was.

Because wasn't the risk precisely what made it so incredible?

Wasn't that it, in the end, the reason I wanted so badly to see my wife's eyes looking at me, with another man's cock in her mouth, the way Eliza had looked at Troy? Because I wanted that kind of strange loyalty, the kind that transcended the physical? The kind of loyalty you simply had to have faith in, and which wasn't the rote, empty motions of a stale marriage. The kind of love that was above the quick, dismissive “I love you,” at the end of every conversation?

I sat down in a chair and edged it so that I was in a shadowy corner of the room. I hoped that Nate would take this as my intention to stay out of whatever they were doing, and be an observer.

A text:

Leaving now. You ready? Still want this?

I texted back, my fingers so nervous I could barely type:

Yes.

And then, a few moments with my stomach cold, wondering what the hell I was doing. Then:

I love you, Conrad.

It was only by pushing the boundaries of our love that we could really test it. That's what I could suddenly see.

I typed:

I love you too.

GETTING THERE

LAURA

Nate had gone through a series of mood changes on the way to the motel, and so I had put my hand on his thigh, and started to use my pinky finger to tease his cock a little through his jeans.

It would be too much if now he wanted to bail.

We stopped in front of the motel. It wasn't very classy, but I hadn't cared. It just made logical sense – close by, inexpensive. Sheets weren't what this was about, anyway.

But now I suddenly worries about Nate.

His face revealed no comment on the motel.

Of course. He was twenty-three. He was about to get laid.

“So...” he turned off the engine. He turned to me. “This isn't going to be like...I don't know....I'm not into any kind of group sex thing.” He suddenly seemed almost bashful.

This cracked me up and I laughed out loud.

“No,” I said. I shook my head for emphasis. “Nothing like that.”

“So what...what is he going to do?”

I shrugged. “I have no idea. It's our first time.”

Nate's mouth opened in shock.

He shook his head. “He's not going to...I don't know. Freak out or something?”

I shook my head. Though who really knew?

To save any of this from derailing, I leaned over and burrowed my hand between his legs. His cock was rock-hard.

Never mind. No need to worry about that...

I kissed him. He was just as delicious as before, but my mind was not on the illicit thing happening between me and Nate as much as the fact that Conrad was inside, waiting to see it all.

And call me crazy, because this is not something I would have ever guessed about myself, but I was ready to put on a real show.

THE REAL HOBBY

CONRAD

Laura texted me to open the door. It was good thinking on her part, sparing us an awkward moment when I would have had to open it for them, and Nate would be right there.

I sat back down in the chair I had arranged, in a darker corner of the room. I was hard as a rock already, and my stomach twisted in the most delicious anticipation I had ever felt. Laura entered first, and she smiled at me. Nate came in behind her, and his cocky-attitude was slightly dampened for a moment. He demurred to Laura, who took a look around the room and instructed him to sit on the bed closest to me. He gave a furtive look at the corner where I was sitting, and a flicker of recognition crossed his face.

But he played it cool. He grinned a little, and it wasn't a jerk-smile. He gave a jerk of his head. "Hey what's up man?"

Not meant to be answered. I gave him a little nod. I could see he got it: I was the guy from the restaurant. He sort of shook his head in bewilderment, but Laura distracted him. "Right there," she told him.

Laura had a certain aura to her that had gone missing a long time ago. The thing that I had loved about her when our marriage began: an unfettered sexual confidence. It didn't stem from her attractiveness. She was, as I've mentioned before, a plainly pretty woman. She had a nice body. But no single feature of hers was jaw-dropping. Like her smile, which turned her face from ordinary to extraordinary, Laura's "hotness" came from her attitude.

I hadn't seen her like this for a long time, but she had it back now, whatever that elusive quality was.

The only question that nagged in my mind was of course: who was it for?

But I pushed it away.

Laura took a survey of the room with her sharp, analytical eye, and I shivered with excitement. She was sizing things up, almost professionally. I knew, somehow, that she had done her consultant's job and sifted through my porn, and cataloged my reactions to her suggestions alongside the things

I had said to her over the past ten years. From this information she had probably drawn herself a pretty accurate map of what I wanted to see.

Laura, after all, was an excellent consultant.

I knew I was about to see her best work.

But first, she was going to give Nate a show. “Not so fast,” she said, pushing him onto the bed when he made a move toward her.

He sat down, somewhat reluctantly, with his hands on his knees. He watched as Laura unbuttoned her jeans and slid them down her hips, shimmying out of them very skillfully, almost in a strip-tease. She kicked them aside.

“Take off your shirt,” she told him.

Nate obeyed, eagerly. Once his shirt was discarded I could see the lean but muscular body that had tempted my wife. A different kind of jealousy rippled through me.

Then, with the typical Laura goofiness she can have, she raised a hand and said loudly. “Oh! I almost forgot!” and turned to her huge purse on the opposite bed. She bent over, showing Nate her cute little butt in her black underwear, and he started to reach out to touch her when she twirled around. She had an object in her hand.

A clear, plastic object. A cold fear, and a slick disappointment moved around in me. She wasn't going to get into some kind of dirty toy game, was she? That wasn't really what I wanted to see.

But she pulled the clear plastic items apart, and they quickly turned into what they were: two clear plastic...shoes.

Hooker-ish, stripper shoes.

Where had she even gotten those?

“Where did you get those?” Nate laughed, echoing my thoughts.

Laura shrugged. It didn't matter. She moved closer to him and put her hands on his shoulders. “My husband liked that story,” she said. Nate's hands were on her hips and moving up, underneath her shirt. He must have looked like he wasn't registering it, though I was. I already knew which story. My cock throbbed.

“The one the stripper told us...about why she likes her stilettos so much?” Laura prompted.

Nate's hands stopped, and I imagined what must be going through his mind.

Laura stepped back and dropped the shoes to the floor. When she stepped into the first one, it raised her a good six inches. It also flexed and toned the muscles of her whole leg, making it look longer...and incredible. She kicked on the second one with her toe.

Then she pulled her tight black shirt up and off of her torso.

There she was. *My* wife.

She looked spectacular. It was suddenly as though she had been transformed into a different person, in a way. She was fucking *hot*. Her lacy black underwear was just bordering on trashy, particularly with her plastic shoes. Her limbs looked long and sexy; her stomach was just barely rounded at the edge of her black lace panties, her breasts seemed fuller and plumped out of the cups of her bra. But the most sexy thing about her was the change in her demeanor, the way she was owning this moment.

Nate appeared, for a moment, to have no idea what to do. Laura put her hand in her hair and fluffed it.

She backed up and sat on the bed.

She spread her legs wide and drew her finger from just below her bra strap down the center line of her abdomen, all the way to her underwear. She was looking right at Nate, and she ran her tongue along her upper lip.

Fuck. It was too much. She was putting on a show, and she was great at it.

She held one hand up and beckoned Nate toward her. "We'll start with this," she said.

He moved toward her, and I saw the brilliance of her planning: she had placed herself right where I would be able to see her face. She was going to get his cock out and suck it, and treat me to the look I had fantasized about for so long.

With her legs still spread wide, a bit akimbo in the tall heels – and I shivered, imagining her plan for that later – she unbuttoned Nate's jeans. She pulled his boxers down.

I watched her face, and it was hard to know if she was being theatrical or not, but whatever she saw made her eyes light up. "Wow," she commented. "Packing quite a..package, hmmm?"

from where I was, I could see that Nate's cock was indeed quite a package: it was pointed straight out, thick, uncircumcised, and quite - almost incredibly – long.

I watched as Laura enclosed the thick meat of it in her hand, and I heard Nate gasp. She fluttered her eyes up at him, and moved her hand up and down the length of his shaft, smiling deviously. She moved her mouth closer and closer to his cock, and I could hear the impatience in his breathing as she teased him with the promise of her lips around him. She pulled on his foreskin, exposing his swollen head.

She made a circle around the ridge of his glans first, and I could almost feel her doing the same for me. Laura's tongue, Laura's tongue, pretty and pink, making circles on the head of another man's cock.

She swept her tongue upward through the center of his head, right over the hole, and she smiled. "Mmmm," she said, and gave him a look. His cock was probably gushing precum, though I couldn't see from here.

She turned her head sideways, and held his cock upright so that she could place her tongue flat on the left side of his dick and lick the length of it. She lowered her eyes as she began, close to the base, and then as she ran her tongue along the long, meaty length of it, her eyes lifted. Smiling, they met mine.

I actually shuddered with the energy this sent through me.

She reached the top of his cock and moved over to the other side to give it the same long, lingering treatment. Then she slid down to the floor, and turned her head to get beneath his cock, swirling her tongue all around his balls, lapping at them like a cat cleaning his paws. Nate turned his face up to the ceiling and sucked his breath in.

Then, on her knees, she opened her mouth and guided his long, thick cock to her mouth. She kissed the head of it, and then her mouth spread open as he pushed inside of her.

And I watched my wife's mouth stretch open and fill with Nate's big slab of meat.

It was so thick her eyes began to water, but she took it all, almost all the way to the base.

And then, as she began to bob her head back and forth to pleasure him, she looked to me. Her eyes locked with mine, and there it was: the fantasy I had for so long. Laura's pretty brown eyes, burning into mine, sharing some secret communication known only to us – one that came only from the years of intimacy we shared – while her mouth was filled completely with another man's cock.

My own cock was dripping cum, staining my pants, which I had left on. The pain of it was almost crushing.

Laura did this for a bit, each time managing to fit more of Nate's long cock into her throat, until at last she had taken it all, all the way to the base. Her chin pressed against his balls and her lips met the flesh over his pubic bone. But her eyes were still on me, watching my own pleasure, enjoying what she doing to me.

I had forgotten completely about the promise of the shoes, but not Laura: she pulled Nate's cock from her mouth and licked at his glans as he made a disappointed noise. She smiled. "Don't come yet," she said. "I'm not finished with you."

Then she climbed, very nimbly, onto the bed.

She got on all fours, and now she was looking like a porn star. Her limbs were long and she was in fantastic shape – she posed sexily, with her back arched, as though she were a professional. She gave her hair another toss. "Let's give it a try," she said, and she looked at me. She gave me a conspiratorial grin.

Then she looked up, at Nate, whose chest was heaving.

She lowered herself to her stomach. She did it slowly, first one elbow, then the other. She watched Nate, who was breathing unevenly, and seemed to get a kick out of his pain.

"You'll have to grab my head, probably," she advised him.

She kicked her heels up, and reached behind her to grab her heels. She lifted her head, and Nate reached out to palm my wife's head in his strong, wiry hand. And then he pulled her to his pelvis, impaling her with his cock.

I watched all the many inches of him disappear into Laura's mouth, as she lay there prone and lewdly holding her heels, just like all the dirty actresses of porn. The sound of Nate's cock in her mouth added a filthy dimension to her act. But Laura kept her eyes open, and trained on me.

Her eyes seared through me, and I was mesmerized. All the blood in my body was going to my cock, and I have no idea why I dropped my eyes from her burning stare, just a little. When I did, I saw the white of her graceful neck, and the hard bulge that was swelling it open. The bulge of Nate's cock, going up and down her throat.

Fuck.

She dropped her heels suddenly, and pushed herself up to sitting. Nate emitted an exasperated sigh: he was clearly close to coming. But Laura was on top of it.. She took his cock in her hand, and got back on her knees. She stroked him as she rubbed his glans over her lips, teasing us all with the wet promise of her mouth.

It was too much for Nate, and he groaned. His white cum exploded and streaking Laura's face with creamy, sticky strands.

She jerked every last bit of cum from him, and then gave her lips a cleansing swipe. She left the remainder of his cum streaked on her face, in her hair. She seemed to know I wanted it there, drying against her skin, a reminder of her corruption and bad behavior.

“I'm not done,” she told Nate, as he began to step backwards.

She was back on the bed, on her knees at the edge. She put her hands on his shoulders. She slid one hand down to his cock, which she stroked lazily so that I could see it. The kid was stunned, but his cock had never really gone flaccid. It jerked and twitched to hard life gain in Laura's hand.

Then she placed her mouth next to his ear, and began to whisper to him, smiling. Nate's face began to brighten, and then she lifted her eyes to meet mine again as she whispered her final, teasing instructions.

I had no idea what she was going to do. Watching her whisper into Nate's ear was almost too much for me. The scent of sex – Nate's cum, briny and almost astringent, reached my nose. Floating under it the tangy ambrosial scent of Laura's cunt.

She slid her panties down her hips, twisting a little this way and that to get them to her knees. She reached behind her and unhooked her bra, freeing her pert breasts.

I realized that Nate was getting his first look at Laura's small, tidy nipples, centered in her taut mound of creamy flesh. Laura showed off her lovely body, and pushed her tits together for show, but she immediately changed her tack and turned away from us, on all fours.

She had her ass on display now, and briefly I wondered when she had shaved. She was almost completely bare, with only a tiny landing strip above her snatch. The outer lips of her pussy were smooth and creamy, disappearing to folded petals of pink. All of it glistening with her own excitement.

Nate remained where he was, but it obviously taxed him a little. His hand twitched and a shiver went through him as he followed Laura's

apparent instructions to watch. Watch, as she reached a hand between her legs from beneath her, and slid her long finger between the folds of her dripping cunt. We were there together, Nate and I, as she teased us both with her own finger, stroking her clit, her legs trembling as she made herself come. Her finger was soaked with her own juices.

She didn't stop there, though. She took her finger up, up to the dull pink ring of her ass. She made a circle around her anus, smearing her juices on it until it shone.

She tapped it and turned back to face Nate.

I was paralyzed by how hot I was by now. I almost couldn't breathe.

Nate stepped forward, and with the hand between her legs, Laura guided his cock to her pussy. Then she pushed herself back, back until his shaft began to slowly disappear inside of her flesh. It was a tight fit; Nate's cock was thick and it strained her inner labia until they were almost white. Laura turned her head up to the ceiling and let out an anguished moan. But she kept going, until his entire cock was embedded in her flesh.

He began to fuck her, apparently a further instruction Laura had whispered in his ear.

"Oh, fuck! Oh, god!" Laura mewled. She turned her head down to the bed. It really was a lot for her to take, but she was also, clearly, enjoying the ecstasy of it. "Oh fuck."

She turned her head, and looked at me to say the next bit, with a smile. "Your cock is so big, Nate. Fuck, I'm all filled up!"

Clicked, ripped directly from my pornos, but it did the trick. God, she was good. My cock screamed at me.

I watched as Nate hammered into her and she yelled at him to fuck her harder, and not to come yet because she was almost there. Then I watched her spasm from her core to her toes as she screamed with her orgasm. The sticky sloshing of her pussy became even soggier, and I knew she was gushing cum all over his cock.

Nate could barely make it a second longer. His body was tensing, but he withdrew just before he came. Laura fell to her chest and reached her hand back to pump his cock.

He aimed, as she had instructed, right for her asshole, covering it with a load of cum that seemed even larger than the previous one.

His white froth dripped down Laura's taint, as they both remained motionless except for their heaving chests. I watched his cum slide over her

outer lips, down her nearly-bursting clit, into the reddened folds of her pussy.

For a moment we were all frozen in time, and then, as though he suddenly remembered where he was and what he was doing, Nate looked around nervously. His eyes darted away when he saw me.

He picked up his shirt from the floor, and pulled up his pants. "Uh..."

Laura was still on the bed, her ass in the air, Nate's cum dripping lazily between her legs.

She sat up and twisted around, so she was propped on her side. She swiped a sticky strand of hair from her face. "That was lovely. But you'd better go," she told him.

Nate looked around the room again, and shrugged. The situation was weird, but he had a fucked-out glow about him, and I knew he was numb above and below the waist. He tossed his shirt over his head.

He looked at Laura. "Do I...?" She waved him away, not needing any kind of affectionate closure.

"Uh...see you at work then, I guess," he said.

Laura gave him a smile.

He closed the door behind him, and Laura looked at me. Her eyes were lit up. "So?"

I was unsteady as I rose and walked to the door to lock it. I stood at the edge of the bed and looked down at my wife.

I wanted her to get on all fours again, and let me watch the cum dripping between her thighs. I didn't know how to best articulate that, but Laura saved me by sensing what I wanted. She turned and got herself into that same position, but facing the end of the bed. Treating me to the fantastic view of her abused pussy while I undressed.

I reached out and swiped a smear of cum around her asshole.

"I thought you were going to let him -"

"Fuck me in the ass?" Laura finished, mischief glinting in her eyes when she looked back at me from the bed. Her face was pressed into the sheets. "Not this time."

She winked at me.

But I had been waiting far too long, and my cock was too hard to take any more teasing. I grasped Laura by the hips and thrust myself inside of her.

It didn't take much of her hot and stretched flesh on my cock, combined with the memories of everything I had just seen, to send me over the edge to a screaming, crushing orgasm. I buried my cock as deep inside of her when I came, filling her sopping pussy with my own load of cum.

I fell on top of her. I was actually dizzy, even lying down. My ears were ringing so hard I couldn't hear anything.

I rolled to the side to keep from crushing Laura. She was still for a moment, and then her hair whipped me in the face as she turned to face me.

"That was hot," she whispered.

"That was fucking hot," I agreed.

Her eyes moved over my face, and I could see she wanted to take in my reaction. The real one, deep inside of me.

But she was silent. She closed her eyes for a moment.

It seemed funny that, even after all of that, it was hard for her or me to share an honest thought about what had happened.

"I'm okay with it," she said, finally. "I'm really okay with it."

She rolled to her side to look at me. "Are you?" She moved her fingers over my chest. Her face had lost all of its sexual deviousness and now she seemed tender, concerned.

I nodded. "I am."

I really was.

Laura leaned forward and we kissed. It was the kind of kiss that went deeper than the ordinary, perfunctory kisses you give each other after so many years of marriage. It was renewed. Or maybe regenerated.

Or maybe it was an entirely new thing, underneath the passion that was in it.

Whatever it was, I knew we were on to a new chapter in our lives.

Laura fell back on the bed.

"I like my new hobby job," she said, grinning.

We both knew she didn't mean the restaurant.

I had no idea where things would go from there, but it seemed promising.

EPILOGUE

LAURA

I decided, after talking it over with Conrad, that I should probably quit The Pied Piper.

Nate wasn't really "that kind of guy," but I had doubts about his ability to keep his experience to himself. The most likely candidates for him to spill the beans to were Jamie, or Aaron, the cook. Things got around fast in the restaurant business, and the idea of having to deal with all those little twerps trying to get me into bed seemed pretty annoying.

Conrad agreed. Besides, we had sparked our sex life, gotten what we wanted, and now we needed some time to think about where we were going with this in the future.

I decided to go in for a beer on Tuesday, before I quit, when I knew Nate would be working. Conrad wanted to come, but I told him it was probably best to wrap things up myself.

I sat in the bar, so I could get Nate for a server.

He saw me when I walked in, and gave me a wink.

In truth, I felt a little twist inside of me. Similar to the one I'd had at first. He was a great-looking guy. His springy hair, his ice-blue eyes. His very hard body, which had felt as good next to my skin as I had imagined it would.

And, let's face it – he had a great cock. Size doesn't matter that much, but size like that is certainly...well...an incredible asset. An incredible experience. I won't lie.

But all the feelings I had for Nate, that had kept me twisted up inside, were gone. I didn't imagine any more tense moments with him in the freezer, because the tension was gone. Anyway, what I had loved more than any of that was being watched. Performing for Conrad. Acting like a dirty porn star, for my husband.

Nate approached me, and he had a knowing grin on his face.

He tucked his money book into his apron.

"Tuesday, huh?" he said. "You aren't planning on jumping ship?"

I shrugged. I had worn a very hot shirt, and some tight pants, and I really felt my renewed power as a sexual being. I liked the way Nate was

looking at me now. "I think it's time," I said.

He nodded, like he had already seen it coming. "So...anything you want. On the house," he told me. "Enormous beer? Haggis egg rolls?"

I laughed. At least he had a good sense of humor.

"Just as long as you're not trying to get me back into bed."

He smiled. "I'm a guy."

"Small beer," I laughed. "I'm really just here to-"

"I know," he said. "Wrap things up. Still...if you change your mind... call me any time."

He sauntered off. He brought me my beer, I drank it. He gave me a few looks as he went back and forth to the kitchen.

When I finished he came back and smiled again. He could see I was getting up to leave.

"More beer?" he said. "Or anything else?"

I felt like ruffling his hair, but resisted the urge.

I waved, and started to walk out.

"Hey, Laura," he called. "You were gonna write about this place, right? Still gonna do that?"

He was grinning.

"I don't think it's appropriate for...the kind of journals I submit to," I laughed. I had forgotten about that project long ago. The idea now seemed preposterous.

He shrugged.

"Maybe submit it somewhere else," he suggested, eyebrows raised. "You know. Online or something." He mouthed the next bit: *Er-o-ti-ca*. "It's a good story."

I gave him a kiss. On the lips. He was still beautifully, wonderfully hot.

"It's a good idea," I conceded. "Maybe I'll do that."

And, as the idea started working its way through my head as I left The Pied Piper for the last time, it seemed better and better.

Huh.

Maybe I would.

END

MORE FROM ARNICA BUTLER

Thank you for reading. I hope you enjoyed my story as much as I enjoyed writing it.

Please don't forget to leave a review...it's the best compliment I can receive, and it helps boost sales and get my stories out to the readers who want them, so I can keep writing more long works like these for you to enjoy!

Also, don't forget to [Sign Up For Our Newsletter](#)

*If you enjoyed The Hobby Job,
give my other novels a try!*

[Ela's Performance](#)

Peter's sweet-faced and fiery wife is headed back to school for a degree in violin performance. Unexpectedly, Peter finds himself becoming very paranoid about who Ela is spending so much time with, and what she is doing at school so very late. It isn't as if he doesn't have his reasons for suspicion. There's the way his own relationship with Ela started, and their own past experiment with an open relationship before they were married. A few other strange things to fuel his jealous fantasies...

And when he discovers someone from Ela's past has resurfaced, he'll take a chance and confront his own desires and obsessions...but will he get what he really wants?

[The Hotwife Tattoo](#)

When Greg's brother marries his wild, tattooed, ex-girlfriend Renee, he knows things will be a little complicated. But when Renee befriends his wife Sara, she starts to change in almost unbelievable ways. Greg sees that there is something more to Renee's plans than just friendly sister-in-law

bonding. Is Renee's influence all bad, or can Greg get something he has always wanted and never admitted to is wife – maybe even himself?

The Tenant: A Very Naughty Hotwife Novel

Once upon a time, his exotic and incredibly sexy wife Anna loved to indulge Brian's fantasies...to a point. She teased strangers, and took them to cruel, tantalizing places. But she never went all the way. The game ended when Brian and Anna got married, and that was that.

Or was it?

When the gorgeous, charming, and very black John moves into their basement rental, Brian finds that his sleeping desires have been building up all these years. He doesn't just want Anna to tease. He isn't just toying with the idea. He is obsessed with driving his wife to do things with another man. Lewd things. Obscene things.

When he confesses his desires, is Anna just a little bit too willing to make things just like old times? Is she too easy to push over each new line? Brian can't help but wonder if his own obsessions have gone too far...or if Anna's have.

A Gamble: The Making of A Hotwife

Ryan is just an average guy, coaxing his sweet, beautiful wife Victoria into playing into his hotwife fantasy – even if they're just pretending. But a trip to Vegas with his co-worker Brad and his sexy wife Irena turns Ryan's life upside-down. To help Ryan, Brad makes a proposal that could change everything...but it all centers on Victoria's innocence. How far will Victoria go to save what she holds most dear, now that her virtues, her love for Ryan, their marriage, Ryan's desires, and even their finances all hang in the balance? This is a 52,000-word novel about risk and romance, filled to the brim with the hard, steamy scenes you love. Please enjoy!

The Hotwife Summer

When Ben and Summer have the chance to spend the summer in Italy, their stale marriage starts to heat up in ways Ben could only have dreamed about. Summer is ready to take his hotwife fantasy all the way, and her choice is a sexy, Italian, Michelin star-studded chef. It's too late to put the brakes on what he's set in motion when Ben discovers the humiliating truth about Summer's choice of man. Summer has a taste for being naughty, and a filthy little plan of her own. Will it be everything he could wish for, or will Ben's cuckold fantasy turn into a nightmare he can't escape?

A Dark Place: Cuckolded In Lagos

Three people are carving out their fortunes in Africa's largest city, but each of them holds a deeper, darker desire. What is the secret desire of the angelic Charlotte, who finds all men's eyes on her after dark in Lagos? What about Andrew, who keeps a secret hunger so buried perhaps he doesn't admit it even to himself? And what could be darker than Clement Ambode's already shadowy “*reliability*” as an all-purpose contractor in the underbelly of Lagos?

Charlotte, Andrew, and Clement will find themselves in a very dark place when their worlds collide in this ultra-sexy, novella-length cuckold story.

Not Black And White

When a photographer turns Rick on to the idea of watching his wife with another man, Rick feels an obsessive desire inside of himself catch fire. He can't help arrange for his shy, girl-next-door wife Danielle and the rugged, black photographer to cross paths. He knows that Drake Reyes' erotic photographs are not as abstract as they appear, and that Reyes sleeps with his married models. He knows his wife is not immune to Reyes' charms – no one is. He just can't help but imagine what it would be like to stand in his gallery, looking at Reyes' lurid photos, knowing his own wife is the model, knowing how the photos were taken. But was it really his idea, or have Drake and Danielle been as manipulative as he has?

Please note, this is the novelized version of the short story Black and White , with significant changes to all scenes depicted in the short story, as well as the point of view. There is, however, some repetition: scenarios which occurred in the short occur in the novel. There are plenty of fresh new adult scenes, however. Please enjoy.

NOVELLAS BY ARNICA

Try To Have Some Fun

Poor Keith. He's been condemned to a campy cruise with his family and friends. Worse yet, he suspects something is going on between his wife and bad-boy Hank, the husband of a family friend his wife has invited along. Keith's in for a very big surprise – and much more naughty, adult fun than he expected on this cruise – when he finds out what's really going on.

Claire's Cowboy

When he gives his wife Claire the gift of a vacation of her choice, Chris is perplexed when she wants to go on a horseback-riding adventure in Montana. Nothing about that kind of trip has ever appealed to Claire. Next, she mentions a mysterious ex-lover, and she turns out to be nearly a professional at riding horses. Chris can't help but wonder if her choice of vacation, and the rugged man who will lead the tour, are just an uncanny coincidence...or if there is something more to Claire's cowboy?

Nothing Better To Do

Rob is finding out from the locals in his wife's small mountain hometown that his soccer-mom wife Kirsten may have been quite a different person once upon a time. He'll find out the truth first-hand when a late summer blizzard traps everyone at a party, and his wife comes up with some very indecent ideas for passing the time.

After all, there's nothing better to do...

If you're a new fan of Arnica Butler, why don't you try [Wives Gone Wild](#)?

I've put together ten of my short stories about wives on vacation, who get taken every way you can think of while their husbands watch. **Ten stories for \$4.99!** For fans of my longer hotwife novels, these stories may not be for you (but then again...they might). These are quick or medium-length, dirty stories about men taking willing wives right out from under their husbands' noses. Most include very graphic scenes of humiliation, menage, cleanup and...well, that's all I can write about here!

Stories included in this bundle are: *Double-Cucked; Cuckolded in Texas by The Oil Tycoon; Watching My Wife Get Trucked; St. Paddy's Day Cucktale; A Long Hard Winter; Watching My Wife Get Lumberjacked; My Wife Goes Back To Black; Cuckolded On A Plane!; Cuckolded In Vegas!; and Cuckolded on My Dominican Vacation.*

All stories are available for purchase individually for \$2.99 and some are in Kindle Unlimited for free, with the exception of Cuckolded In Texas, which is only available here. I want to give readers a chance to read some of my earlier works and quickies at a discounted price.

Because sometimes, you just want to get down and dirty, right?
Enjoy!